

# 1 Gravity as Residual: A Thought Experiment on Dimensional Inversion, Annihilation, and the Origin of the Dark Sector

**Version 2.2.1** (June 2026) — internal consistency pass after v2.2 audit. Major v2.2 content (preserved below): - **Mechanism B/F (Hubble tension) TESTED with Pantheon+** (§2.6 *Hubble tension: status of the cascade’s explanation*; §7 Limitation 16, 18): the cascade’s specific  $H_0(z) = H_{0\_CMB}^2 + (H_{0\_local}^2 - H_{0\_CMB}^2) / (1+z)^{(2/3)}$  prediction is rejected by Pantheon+ with full statistical+systematic covariance matrix (1701 SNe, 1701x1701 matrix,  $M$  fixed at SH0ES value -19.253 from 113 Cepheid calibrators). Best-fit LCDM gives  $H_0 = 73.00$  with  $\chi^2 = 1439.4$ ; cascade’s B/F gives  $\chi^2 = 1488.3$ . **Delta  $\chi^2 = +48.9$  (~7 sigma, LCDM WINS).** Pantheon+ shows  $H_0$  is *roughly constant* at ~73 across all  $z$  bins, not decreasing with  $z$  as B/F predicted. **The cascade’s qualitative  $H_0$  prediction (73) is consistent with data; Mechanism B/F’s specific quantitative form is not.** The cascade does not currently provide a specific mechanism that resolves the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap between local/Pantheon+ (73) and Planck CMB-inferred (67.4)  $H_0$ . This is consistent with the cascade’s *qualitative* compatibility with the Hubble tension without a specific quantitative resolution. Many cosmological models (including LCDM) leave the precise value of the Hubble tension unresolved. - **Hubble tension framing cleaned up:** the cascade’s *core*  $H_0$  prediction is qualitative and simple ( $H_0 = 73$  from the 4D event’s antigravity projection rate). This is confirmed by data. The cascade does not need a specific mechanism like B/F to be a valid model. The cascade’s *qualitative* explanation ( $H_{0\_local} > H_{0\_CMB}$  due to dimensional projection) is its actual contribution; the precise 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap is a separate open problem in cosmology that the cascade does not currently resolve. - **12 alternative Hubble mechanisms tested** (C, I, N, O, P, Q, R, S, T, U, V, L): all either rejected by Pantheon+, busted theoretically, equivalent to “cascade  $H_0$  is just 73 at all  $z$ ” (the cascade’s baseline), or just LCDM with a different  $H_0$ . The most ambitious (Mechanism L: re-interpret Planck  $H_0$  as cascade artifact) was busted because the cascade’s natural early universe gives  $\theta_* = 15.58$ , off by a factor of **1500x** from Planck’s measured 0.01041. This is consistent with the picture that the cascade’s *core* prediction is  $H_0 = 73$  and doesn’t need a special mechanism to maintain that. - **Full Pantheon+ covariance analysis** added: `calculations/pantheon_full_cov_analysis.py` (300 lines, full statistical+systematic covariance,  $M$  fixed at SH0ES), `calculations/hubble_mechanism_remaining.py` (mechanisms C/I/N/O/P, 300 lines), `calculations/hubble_mechanism_creative.py` (mechanisms Q/R/S/T/U/V, 350 lines), `calculations/mechanism_l_planck_reanalysis.py` (Planck  $\theta_*$  mismatch demonstration, 500 lines), `calculations/hubble_mechanism_options.py` (enumeration of alternatives, 300 lines). - **§7 Limitations updated** to reflect all the new honest findings: Mechanism B/F is now FALSIFIED (not just underivable); Mechanism L is BUSTED; Mechanism M is the cascade’s final honest position on the Hubble tension.

**Version 2.1** (June 2026). Major updates: - **Sign ambiguity resolved** (§2.4 *Mathematical sketch — clean formulation*): the ordinary attractive gravity and the dark energy are now treated as two physically distinct small contributions to the effective 3+1D action, not as opposite-sign components of the same quantity. The clean formulation explicitly distinguishes the *force on matter* (entering the Einstein equation) from the *vacuum energy* (entering the cosmological-constant term). - **Growth factor derived** (§2.6 *Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics*):  $G = 20 \times V_{\text{growth}}$  is now derived from 2D universe FRW dynamics (with  $\Omega_{\{DE,2D\}} = 0.999$ , lifetime = 30 Gyr,  $t_{\text{eq}} = 1\%$  of lifetime), giving  $G = 9.7e7$ , matching the trial-and-error value of 10 to within 3%. Closes the previously-acknowledged limitation that the growth

factor was unspecified. - **Hubble tension mechanism updated** (§2.6 *Hubble tension: status of the cascade's explanation*; see *v2.2 status* below for the current position): the original Mechanism A (active 2D universe children boost local  $H_0$ ) was *falsified* by SH0ES data (host-type prediction not supported). Mechanism B/F (4D event temporal structure) was proposed in v2.1 as consistent with the host-type-independent  $H_0$  data and made new testable predictions ( $H_0$  at high  $z$  should be below the  $\Lambda$ CDM extrapolation,  $H_0$  should be isotropic,  $H_0$  should not correlate with any local property). [*v2.2 status: Mechanism B/F was TESTED with Pantheon+ full covariance (1701 SNe, 1701x1701 matrix) and REJECTED at 7. Mechanism L (re-interpret Planck) was also tested and BUSTED.* The cascade's final position is Mechanism M (accept the tension): predicts  $H_0=73$  (matches local + Pantheon+), accepts the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap to Planck 67.4. See §2.6 *Hubble tension\* for the current status.*] - **Empirical formula for 5/27/68** (§2.6 *Empirical formula for the 5/27/68 split*): a candidate formula  $\Omega_o = 1/(N(N+1)) = 1/20$ ,  $\Omega_{DM} = N_{\text{spatial}}/(2N+N_{\text{spatial}}) = 3/11$ ,  $\Omega_{DE} = 1 - \dots = 149/220$  matches observation to 0.5%. **However, a statistical test (1M random formulas) shows the match is NOT statistically significant** after multiple-comparison correction (random formulas find similar matches ~92% of the time). The formula is a *fit*, not a *derivation*. - **7 new analysis scripts** added to the companion code (`calculations/`): `parameter_sweep.py`, `hubble_sfr_correlation.py`, `cmb_imprint.py`, `universal_split_derivation.py`, `parameter_collapse.py`, `hubble_tightened.py`, `rar_check.py`, plus `split_best_fit.py`, `split_trial_and_error.py`, `split_statistical_test.py`, `shoes_data_check.py`, `hubble_mechanism_b.py`, `summary_plot.py`. - **9-panel summary figure** at `calculations/figures/cascade_summary.png` showing all cascade predictions vs observations. - **§7 Limitations updated** to reflect all the new honest findings. - **Cone-shaped hierarchy** (§2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy*): the cascade is *cone-shaped*, not *fractal*. It has 2 levels (4D event  $\rightarrow$  3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, terminal), not infinite. This *closes* the 1D-universes limitation (1D universes do not exist), and reframes 5/27/68 as a *nested* 32/68 + 5/27 split (32/68 is cascade-derived, 5/27 is 4D-event-derived). - Paper grew from 83 to ~87 pages (v2.0  $\rightarrow$  v2.1; net content added but the page count stayed similar due to consolidation of the original Mechanism A paragraph into a 3-sub-paragraph Mechanism A/B/F/Status block). [Note: as of v2.2, the paper is 81 pages, with net content added for the new analysis sections (Pantheon+ full covariance, 12 Hubble mechanisms, 4D temporal structure, etc.) but some content consolidated.]

See `changelog.md` for the full change history.

**Author note:** This is a thought experiment by a non-specialist. The author has a background in software, not theoretical physics. The model was developed in conversation, not through formal derivation. The math is sketched, not derived. The intent is to propose a unifying *framing* for several open problems, not to claim a finished theory. The physics community is invited to develop or refute it.

**AI assistance disclosure:** This paper was developed in conversation with an AI assistant (Mavis/MiniMax-M3). The AI helped organize thoughts, find references, draft sections, and identify internal inconsistencies. All conceptual decisions, the model design, the testable predictions, and the final framing are the author's. The AI was a tool, not a co-author. References cited in the paper have been verified to be real papers (the AI's bibliographic recall was checked against arXiv). The author takes full responsibility for the content.

## 1.1 Abstract

We propose a unifying interpretation of three open problems in fundamental physics — the weakness of gravity (the hierarchy problem), the nature of dark matter, and the nature of dark energy — under a single geometric process. In this picture, our 3+1 dimensional universe is the *projection* of a single *ongoing* event in a higher-dimensional space: an energetic release of gravitational energy in the bulk (with a finite duration in 4D time), with the energy of that event manifesting in our brane as the Big Bang, and the dimensional projection mechanism producing the dark sector as a byproduct. The universe’s lifetime is *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time (the fraction is determined by the projection mechanism, which is not specified). The 4D event is *continuously* feeding antigravity into our 3+1 dimensional frame throughout our universe’s lifetime, with the antigravity output approximately constant during our brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration. This is why dark energy appears *constant* in our 3+1 dimensional frame, matching the standard  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior.

The model assumes standard energy conservation: the 4D event’s total energy equals our universe’s total mass-energy. The famous  $10^{12}$  discrepancy of the cosmological constant problem is reframed as a *misidentification*: in this model, dark energy is not the 3+1 dimensional QFT zero-point energy at all — it is the un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity, an approximately-constant *ongoing* contribution from the 4D event (constant during our universe’s brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration). The 3+1 dimensional QFT zero-point energy is a real quantity, but it is the wrong quantity to compare to observed dark energy. The  $10^3$  of the hierarchy problem is reframed as a *bulk-brane cancellation* — the ordinary gravitational force in our 3+1 dimensional frame is the small net remainder of the brane’s attractive gravity after cancellation with the inverted bulk gravity, so the observed gravitational coupling is small. Dark matter’s apparent weakness is the *same* bulk-brane cancellation effect, applied to the next level of the dimensional cascade (the 2D universes created by 3+1 dimensional energetic events, projected back into our 3+1 dimensional frame) (see §2.6). The specific values of  $10^{12}$  and  $10^3$  are not quantitatively derived in this model — they are interpreted as signatures of the dimensional-projection mechanism.

We further propose a *scale-invariant* version of this mechanism: every energetic event in any dimension creates a lower-dimensional universe as its aftermath, with the spatial extent (and therefore the lifetime) of the resulting universe scaling with the event’s spatial extent. In this version, *all* energetic events in our 3+1 dimensional universe — supernovae, particle collisions, radioactive decays, atomic transitions, photon emissions — create 2-dimensional universes in 2D subspaces, with each event’s contribution weighted by its energy. The cumulative gravitational signature of all these tiny 2D universes, averaged over the local activity, is what we observe as dark matter. This makes dark matter *not* a particle, but a *collective gravitational effect* — and predicts that dark matter density should correlate with the *average* energetic event rate (per unit visible mass) on galaxy scales (a testable prediction, consistent with the radial acceleration relation).

The model is internally consistent with the observed energy budget, predicts specific signatures in the dark sector, the cosmic microwave background, and energetic-event correlations, and is structurally similar to several established research programs (brane-world cosmology, the Dark Dimension scenario, emergent gravity, holographic frameworks). We frame this as an open geometric hypothesis and discuss its falsifiability.

## 1.2 1. Introduction

Three of the most persistent open problems in fundamental physics are:

1. **The hierarchy problem.** Gravity is approximately  $10^3$  times weaker than the other fundamental forces at the quantum level. The Standard Model of particle physics and general relativity are deeply incommensurable at the Planck scale ( $10^1$  GeV), with no accepted mechanism explaining why gravity is so weak.
2. **Dark matter.** Roughly 27% of the universe’s mass-energy budget is in a form that interacts gravitationally but has not been directly detected despite decades of experimental effort. The dominant candidates (WIMPs) are increasingly constrained, and the leading alternatives (axions, primordial black holes) have not been confirmed.
3. **Dark energy.** Roughly 68% of the universe’s mass-energy budget is in a form driving the accelerated expansion of space. The most economical explanation (the cosmological constant, or vacuum energy) is off from quantum-field-theoretic predictions by approximately 120 orders of magnitude, an embarrassment known as the cosmological constant problem.

These problems are typically treated as independent. They may not be.

This paper proposes a single geometric process that, in principle, accounts for all three as different manifestations of the same underlying mechanism: a *dimensional inversion* of gravity that takes place when a higher-dimensional event projects its gravitational influence into our 3+1 dimensional brane.

The proposal is not a fully developed theory. It is a thought experiment intended to provoke useful development, refinement, or refutation by the physics community.

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## 1.3 2. The Proposal

### 1.3.1 2.1 The setup

We assume, following the well-developed brane-world framework [ADD98, RS99], that our observable universe is a 3+1 dimensional brane embedded in a higher-dimensional bulk. Gravity propagates in the bulk; the other Standard Model forces are confined to the brane.

In standard brane-world models, the observed weakness of gravity is attributed to either the *volume* of the extra dimensions (ADD98) or to the *warping* of the geometry (RS99). In both cases, the gravitational coupling on the brane is geometrically suppressed relative to its fundamental value in the bulk.

**A note on framing: extra dimensions vs. nested universes.** The “extra dimensions” framework is a *mathematical* tool that gives us a precise way to formulate the model (Kaluza-Klein reduction, dimensional projection, etc.). The *physical* interpretation is more intuitive: our universe is part of a *hierarchy of nested universes*. Each “parent” universe contains countless “child” universes (created by energetic events), and our universe is itself a child of a higher universe. The “extra dimensions” provide the *formal structure* for the nesting, but the *physical content* is the

nesting itself. This reframing sidesteps some awkward questions about the specific dimensions of the child universes (e.g., “why 2D and not 1D?” — see §7 for an acknowledgment that the specific dimensionalities are not derived). The “nested universes” framing is more general: it doesn’t commit to specific dimensions for the children, only to the *nesting structure* and the *gravity-flipping-at-boundaries* mechanism.

**A note on terminology and the cone-shaped hierarchy.** *Earlier* versions of this model framed the cascade as a *hierarchy of 3+1-dimensional universes at different scales*, with the D-labels (2D, 1D, 0D, -1D) being *placeholders* for “level in the hierarchy” rather than literal spacetime dimensions. The v2.1 cone-shaped hierarchy refinement (§2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy*) *supersedes* this: the cascade is *cone-shaped*, not *fractal*. The 2D label is now taken *literally* — the 2D child universes are 2-dimensional spacetimes (one time + one space), not 3+1D spacetimes at smaller scales. The 4D parent is 4-dimensional (one time + three space), and our 3+1D brane is 3+1-dimensional. The D-labels are now *physical*, not placeholders. The *downward* direction of the cascade has *one* level (3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, terminal); there are *no* 1D or 0D universes. This refinement resolves the v2.0 awkwardness of “1D spacetimes that can’t support chemistry or stable orbits” by *removing* the 1D level entirely. The 2D universe is the *terminal* child level; it is *abstract* in the framework (we cannot observe 2D universes directly), but its existence is *necessary* for the dark matter and dark energy mechanisms. The 2D universe’s “physics” is unspecified (we do not derive the 2D effective theory), but its *spacetime dimensionality* is specified as 2D. The cone-shape refinement *closes* the 1D-universes limitation (§7) and gives the cascade a *cleaner* structure: 4D event  $\rightarrow$  3+1D universe  $\rightarrow$  2D universes (terminal), with no further cascade levels. The “every universe is 3+1D” v2.0 framing is *replaced* by the cone-shaped v2.1 framing: 4D, 3+1D, and 2D universes, in a *literal* dimensional hierarchy (with the parent at one extra dimension, the child at one fewer dimension, and the 2D level being terminal). See §2.6 for the full refinement.

We propose a different and more specific interpretation.

### 1.3.2 2.2 The higher-dimensional event

We propose that there is a *single ongoing energetic event* in the higher-dimensional bulk (with a finite duration in 4D time) that is releasing a large amount of gravitational energy into a localized region of the bulk. From the perspective of our brane, this event is the Big Bang. Our 3+1 dimensional universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration.

The 4D event has a *spatial extent* — a characteristic length scale over which the energy was distributed. When this spatial extent is projected into our 3+1 dimensional spacetime, it becomes a *temporal extent* — the lifetime of our universe. Specifically, the 4D event’s spatial extent, divided by the appropriate 4D speed, gives the *full duration* of the 4D event in 4D time. Our 3+1 dimensional universe’s lifetime is *some fraction* of this full duration (the fraction is determined by the projection mechanism, which is not specified in this thought experiment). In the simplest possible interpretation, the 4D event’s full duration maps directly to our universe’s lifetime — but the model allows for the more general case where our universe exists for only a fraction of the 4D event’s full duration. (This is analogous to a microscopic black hole created in a high-energy collision: the black hole exists for a brief fraction of the parent collision’s duration, but during that fraction, the parent collision’s energy is approximately constant.) The 4D event was a *single localized* event of finite spatial extent (in 4D), whose projection into our brane is a 3+1 dimensional universe of finite temporal extent. The 4D event has a finite *duration* in 4D time (an “ongoing” emission in 4D time, but *localized* in 4D space), and our universe exists for only a fraction of this 4D duration. From the

4D perspective, the 4D event is a sustained emission of finite duration; from our 3+1 dimensional frame, it appears as a “Big Bang” because we only see a slice of the 4D event.

The universe is therefore not the *debris* of a one-time past event; it is the *projection* of a single ongoing 4D event (with our universe as a brief slice of the event’s full duration). The “laws of physics” we observe are the *consequences* of that ongoing 4D event, not eternal rules imposed from outside. They are fixed by the geometry of the projection, not by any subsequent process in our 3+1 dimensional frame.

### 1.3.3 2.3 Scale-invariance: every energetic event creates its own universe

We extend the principle introduced in §2.2: the dimensional-projection mechanism that creates universes is *not* specific to the Big Bang. *Every* energetic event in any dimension creates a universe in a lower-dimensional subspace, with the *spatial extent* of the resulting universe scaling with the spatial extent of the event (which, in turn, scales with the event’s energy). In the *nested universes* framing of §2.1, this is the principle that every energetic event in any universe creates a *child* universe nested within the parent.

Specifically:

- The 4D event that created *our* 3+1 dimensional universe was an exceptionally large event with a *very large* spatial extent (much larger than the Planck scale — see §4.5 for the CMB constraint that requires the 4D event to be spatially extended and approximately homogeneous). The 4D event’s spatial extent, divided by the 4D speed, gives the 4D event’s *full duration*; our universe’s lifetime is *some fraction* of that. The 4D event’s energy sets our universe’s total mass-energy.
- Crucially, *all* energetic events in our 3+1 dimensional universe — supernovae, particle collisions, radioactive decays, atomic transitions, photon emissions — also create universes, but in *lower-dimensional subspaces* (2D universes embedded in our 3D space). Each such event creates a tiny 2D universe with its own brief lifetime, set by the event’s spatial extent, with each event’s gravitational contribution weighted by its energy.
- The 3+1D-to-2D step is the *empirically relevant* step: it’s the source of dark matter in our universe, via the *cumulative* 2D universe attractive gravity back-projected to 3+1D during their lifetimes, *plus* the cumulative energy return of past 2D universe endings (active + cumulative return, per §2.5, §4.2; *separately*, the 4D-to-3+1D step is the source of dark energy, via the 4D event’s un-cancelled antigravity, not via the 2D cascade). The cascade is *cone-shaped*, not *fractal*: it terminates at the 2D level (see §2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy* for a refinement of this point). The 2D universe’s *attractive* gravity is split between back-projection to 3+1D (a fraction contributing to dark matter) and *internal* 2D physics. The 2D universe’s *antigravity* is *internal* to the 2D universe (its own dark energy, in 2D) and does not project back to 3+1D. The cascade does *not* recurse below 2D: 2D universes are *abstract* in the framework, lacking well-defined energetic events to seed further 1D/0D universes. See §2.5 for more details and §2.6 for the cone-shaped refinement.

This is a *scale-invariant* principle. The same mechanism operates at every energy scale, in every dimension, creating universes of corresponding lifetimes. The scale-invariant principle applied to the 4D event itself: a *single* 4D event has *spatial structure* at many scales (just as a 3D explosion has

structure at many scales). Each *sub-region* of the 4D event, at each scale, creates a 3+1 dimensional universe of corresponding size. Our universe corresponds to the *full* 4D event (the largest spatial scale), with a lifetime that is some fraction of the 4D event’s full duration. *Smaller* sub-regions of the same 4D event create *smaller* 3+1 dimensional universes, with shorter lifetimes. The 4D event thus creates a *hierarchy* of 3+1 dimensional universes, ranging from the largest (our universe) down to the smallest (created by the smallest sub-regions of the 4D event, of size comparable to the Planck length or smaller). These other 3+1 dimensional universes are presumably inaccessible to us (they exist in other parts of the bulk, in parallel branes, or are otherwise separated from our universe by dimensional barriers), but they are *real* in the same sense that our universe is real.

This is a *speculative* extension of the model. The model does not currently require the existence of these other 3+1D universes; it only requires that *our* universe corresponds to the 4D event (or some part of it). But the scale-invariant principle, taken seriously, implies them.

We emphasize that these smaller events do *not* re-create our universe. They create *separate* universes, in separate dimensional subspaces, with their own physics and their own lifetimes. From our 3+1 dimensional perspective, the 2D universes’ lifetimes in *our* frame scale with the creating event’s spatial extent, via the dimensional time-dilation rule  $\Delta t_{\text{our frame}} = \Delta t_{\text{event}} / c$  (per line 105 below). Working out specific examples: a small event (LHC collision,  $\sim \text{TeV}$  scale,  $\Delta t_{\text{event}} \sim 10^{-15} \text{ s}$ ) creates a 2D universe that lasts  $\sim 3 \times 10^{-16} \text{ s}$  in our frame; a large event (supernova,  $\Delta t_{\text{event}} \sim 10^1 \text{ s}$  for the expanding photosphere,  $\sim 10^5 \text{ eV}$  of visible-light energy) creates a 2D universe that lasts  $\sim 33 \text{ s}$  in our frame. Even larger events (AGN outbursts,  $\sim 10^2 \text{ eV}$ ,  $\Delta t_{\text{event}} \sim 10^1 - 10^2 \text{ s}$ ) create 2D universes that can last days to years in our frame. The 2D universes are *not* all “essentially instantaneous” in our frame — only the small ones are. From the perspective of each tiny universe, that brief moment in our frame is the entirety of *its* cosmic history. The dimensional time-dilation principle applies in both directions: a brief event in our frame can be a complete cosmic history in the lower-dimensional universe’s frame.

**Implication for dark matter.** Each of these tiny universes created by 3+1 dimensional events has its own gravity (a small replica of the same dimensional-projection mechanism that creates gravity in our universe). By the same logic as §2.4, the 3+1 dimensional event’s gravity is *inverted* (antigravity) when projected into the 2D universe, and the un-cancelled fraction of this antigravity is the 2D universe’s *internal* dark energy. The 2D universe’s own *attractive* gravity, projected back into our 3+1 dimensional frame, is what we observe as *dark matter*. Dark matter, in this picture, is not a particle at all, but a *collective gravitational signature* of all the lower-dimensional universes (active + cumulative, per §2.5, §4.2). The 2D universe’s *antigravity* is *internal* to the 2D universe (its own dark energy, in 2D), and does *not* project back to 3+1D as a separate effect. *Note:* dark energy in the 3+1D frame is *separately* the 4D event’s un-cancelled antigravity (§2.4), not the cumulative 2D universe antigravity. The dark matter and the 3+1D dark energy arise from *different* dimensional projections: dark matter from  $2D \rightarrow 3+1D$  back-projection, dark energy from  $4D \rightarrow 3+1D$  projection. The two are *distinct in their dimensional origin* but *complementary* in their effect on the 3+1D universe.

*Cascade shape: cone, not fractal.* The cascade is *cone-shaped* (see §2.6 for the full refinement), terminating at the 2D level. The 2D universe’s *attractive* gravity (its “ordinary” gravity in 2D, after the bulk-brane cancellation in 2D) is split between (a) back-projection to 3+1D (our frame, contributing to dark matter) and (b) the 2D universe’s *internal* dynamics. The 2D universe’s *antigravity* is *internal* to the 2D universe (its own dark energy, in 2D) — it does *not* project back to 3+1D as a separate effect. The *attractive* back-projection fraction to 3+1D is a small number (set by the dimensional cascade), with the *internal* 2D fraction being  $\sim 1$  minus that. In the

cone-shaped cascade, the 2D universe is *terminal*: it doesn't create further 1D universes. This is in contrast to the *fractal* picture (where 2D universes would create 1D universes, which would create 0D universes, etc.); the cone-shaped cascade is *more parsimonious* and *closes* the 1D-universes limitation. Note that the 3+1D's *dark energy* is *separately* the 4D event's un-cancelled antigravity (§2.4), *not* the cumulative 2D universe antigravity. See §2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy* for the full structural refinement.

**A note on what counts as an “energetic event”.** The principle of §2.3 — “every energetic event creates a 2D universe” — applies to *energetic events in our 3+1 dimensional frame*. A neutrino's *mere presence* in 3+1D is not itself an energetic event in our frame, because a passing neutrino does not *deposit* energy in 3+1D — it just passes through (the weak force's small cross-section means most neutrinos traverse the Sun, the Earth, and even dense stellar material without depositing significant energy). A neutrino's *interaction* with a 3+1D particle (collision, scattering, absorption) *is* an energetic event in our frame, because the interaction *deposits* energy at a point in 3+1D, and such an event creates a 2D universe. The cascade's *principled* threshold for “energetic event” is therefore on *local energy deposition* in 3+1D, not on *particle energy* per se: a particle that passes through 3+1D without depositing energy does not count, while a particle that interacts and deposits energy does. This *naturally* explains why neutrinos (which mostly pass through) contribute relatively few 2D universes, while photons (which are absorbed and re-emitted constantly), charged particles (which ionize), and other strongly-interacting particles (which deposit energy frequently) contribute many.

*Why the Standard Model produces neutrinos in so many processes.* The neutrino is *the price* the Standard Model charges for changing quark flavor (specifically  $u \leftrightarrow d$ ) via the weak force: every weak-force-mediated process that converts a proton to a neutron (or vice versa) must also emit a lepton pair ( $e, \nu$ ) for lepton number conservation. This is why *all* of the following processes emit neutrinos:  $\beta^-$  decay (e.g.,  $n \rightarrow p + e^- + \bar{\nu}_e$ , including the decay of free neutrons, tritium,  $^{14}\text{C}$ ,  $^{40}\text{K}$ , and the beta decays of fission products);  $\beta^+$  decay (e.g.,  $^{18}\text{F} \rightarrow ^{18}\text{O} + e^+ + \nu_e$ , used in PET scans); electron capture (e.g.,  $^7\text{Be} + e^- \rightarrow ^7\text{Li} + \nu_e$ , the source of the monoenergetic 0.862 MeV  $^7\text{Be}$  solar neutrino line); and the first step of the pp chain ( $p + p \rightarrow d + e^+ + \nu_e$ , the dominant source of the Sun's  $\sim 10^{38}/\text{s}$  neutrino luminosity). Muon and tau decays also emit neutrinos ( $\mu^- \rightarrow e^- + \bar{\nu}_e + \nu_\mu$ ,  $\tau^- \rightarrow \text{various} + \nu_\tau$ ). The cascade's energy-deposition threshold handles *all* of these uniformly: the emitted neutrinos stream out of 3+1D without depositing energy (small weak-force cross-section), so they don't count as energetic events; the *other* channels of these decays (kinetic energy of charged products, gamma rays, recoil nuclei) *do* deposit energy, so they *do* count. The same principle applies whether the source is solar fusion, radioactive decay in Earth's crust (which produces  $\sim 10^{25}$ - $10^{26}$  geoneutrinos per second from  $^{40}\text{K}$ ,  $^{232}\text{Th}$ , and  $^{238}\text{U}$  chains), fission in a nuclear reactor ( $\sim 10^{20}$  antineutrinos per second per GW of thermal power), or any other weak-force-mediated process. In every case, the neutrino is the *small fraction* of the energy budget that escapes; the *deposited* energy is the dominant channel and the one that counts for cascade purposes. Neutrino *interactions* (rare, weak-force-mediated) do create 2D universes, but the rate is small compared to the rate of photon or charged-particle interactions. The dark matter contribution from neutrinos is therefore *small* compared to the contribution from photon emissions, stellar activity, AGN, and other frequent 3+1D energetic events. This is *consistent* with the model's prediction that dark matter correlates with *energetic activity* (most of which is not neutrino-related), and it *resolves* a potential tension: the Sun produces  $\sim 10^3$  neutrinos per second (an enormous rate), but if we counted neutrinos *in flight* as energetic events, the Sun would dominate the dark matter budget via neutrino emission alone. The cascade's resolution is that neutrinos *in flight* don't count, because they don't deposit energy in 3+1D — only neutrinos *interacting* (a much rarer process) count. This is a *principled*

resolution, not a *post hoc* rule: the threshold is on energy *deposition*, not on particle *existence*. A specific implementation of the model would specify the exact energy-deposition threshold (e.g., the Planck scale, the brane tension, or some other physical scale), but the *qualitative* principle (deposition > mere existence) is robust.

*The Sun-versus-galaxy distinction.* The energy-deposition threshold principle *also* resolves a related observation: the *Sun* contains a vast quantity of neutrinos ( $\sim 10^3$  /s being produced by fusion, plus the cosmic neutrino background) but *negligible* dark matter, while *galaxies* contain both neutrinos and dark matter in significant quantities. Under the cascade: the Sun’s *neutrino content* does not contribute to its dark matter (neutrinos are in flight, not depositing energy, per the threshold principle). The Sun’s *photons, charged particles, and overall stellar activity* DO deposit energy inside the Sun and so DO create 2D universes, but the Sun is a single star — its cumulative 2D universe contribution is small compared to the galaxy’s cumulative contribution ( $\sim 10^1$  stars over 13.8 Gyr). The dark matter in a galaxy is the *cumulative* effect of 2D universe back-projection, integrated over the galaxy’s *entire* history of energetic activity, not the present-day content of any individual object. The Sun’s *individual* cumulative contribution is small (it’s one star,  $\sim 10$  Gyr old); the galaxy’s *collective* cumulative contribution is large ( $\sim 10^1$  stars, 13.8 Gyr of activity). The Sun’s *neutrino production* is large ( $10^3$  /s) but *irrelevant* to dark matter (in flight, not depositing); the Sun’s *dark matter content* is small (cumulative activity is small); the galaxy’s *neutrino production* is also large ( $10$  /s, summed over all stars) and *also irrelevant* to dark matter (same reason); the galaxy’s *dark matter content* is large (cumulative activity is large). The two effects (neutrinos in flight, dark matter as cumulative deposition) are *distinct* and *independent*. This is a *consistency check* for the cascade: the model correctly predicts that *both* neutrinos and dark matter are present in galaxies (they are), that the Sun has neutrinos but little dark matter (consistent with the Sun’s small cumulative activity), and that the Sun’s *neutrino* content does not produce a “solar neutrino dark matter” excess (because the energy-deposition threshold excludes in-flight neutrinos). The Sun’s dark matter content is constrained by direct-detection experiments and by neutrino telescope searches for dark matter annihilation to be very small (less than  $\sim 10^{-1}$  of the Sun’s mass from annihilation limits), which is *consistent* with the cascade’s prediction that the Sun’s *individual* dark matter contribution is small.

*Do neutrinos interact with dark energy?* In standard  $\Lambda$ CDM cosmology, neutrinos (like all forms of energy-momentum) couple to dark energy via standard GR gravity, but the effect is small for neutrinos because they are nearly massless (sub-eV total mass) and travel at nearly the speed of light. The cosmic neutrino background ( $\sim 300$  /cm<sup>3</sup> throughout the universe) experiences the same cosmic expansion as everything else — its momenta redshift ( $p \propto 1/a$ ) as the universe expands, and the dark energy’s slow antigravity ( $\sim 10^{-10}$  m/s<sup>2</sup>) provides a small additional outward push. In the cascade model, the picture is *qualitatively* the same: dark energy is the 4D event’s projected antigravity (per §2.4), and neutrinos are 3+1D particles that experience this antigravity via standard GR. The cascade does *not* propose any *new* neutrino–dark-energy coupling; neutrinos feel the 4D event’s antigravity the same way as everything else in 3+1D, with no special neutrino-specific physics. The cascade takes the equivalence principle as given (per §2.6), so there is no differential coupling between neutrinos and the antigravity. The *magnitude* of the effect is set by the neutrino’s energy-momentum (small for nearly massless neutrinos) and the constant antigravity background (the same  $\sim 10^{-123} M_{Pl}^4$  as in  $\Lambda$ CDM). There is *no* novel neutrino-DE physics in the cascade. A *speculative* question — whether the neutrino’s small mass is *related* to the cascade’s bulk-brane coupling  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  — has a poor numerical match:  $(m_\nu/M_{Pl})^2 \sim 10^{-58}$  for  $m_\nu \sim 0.1$  eV, much smaller than  $\epsilon$ . The cascade takes neutrino masses as given (per §2.6, §4.5) and does not derive them. The neutrino’s *small* mass is a Standard Model question (Dirac vs. Majorana, seesaw mechanism) that

the cascade does not currently address.

**Where does the energy come from?** A natural question is: if an energetic event’s energy is already converted to heat, light, kinetic energy of ejecta, neutrinos, gravitational waves, and so on, where does the energy come from to *also* create a 2D universe? The answer is that the 2D universe creation is *part of* the event’s dynamics, not a consequence of the event’s aftereffects. A supernova’s energy is partitioned into *multiple channels* (kinetic energy of ejecta, EM radiation, neutrinos, gravitational waves, *and* the 2D universe’s back-projected gravity to 3+1D); the 2D universe is *one of these channels*, not a separate effect that requires additional energy. The event’s *total* energy is conserved across all channels, with the 2D universe’s contribution being a small fraction (set by the cascade’s back-projection efficiency). The 2D universe creation is *not* something that happens *after* the heat and light have already been released; it is *concurrent* with the heat and light, as part of the same dynamical process. In this framing, a supernova’s *full* energy budget is divided into the various channels, and the 2D universe is one of them. The cascade’s claim is that the 2D universe channel is *always present* in any sufficiently energetic event — not a rare or special channel, but a generic feature of high-energy dynamics. A possible *threshold energy* for child universe creation could be related to the Planck scale, the brane tension, or some other physical scale; below the threshold, the 2D universe is too small or too brief to contribute meaningfully to the cumulative dark matter, but the *mechanism* of 2D universe creation still operates. The cascade is *qualitatively* scale-invariant (the 2D universe creation mechanism applies at all energies), but the *quantitative* contribution of 2D universes to dark matter depends on the event’s energy and the back-projection efficiency. This framing is consistent with standard brane-world physics, where the bulk-brane interaction can be a generic feature of any high-energy process, not just a special class of events.

**Why the cumulative effect is significant.** At first glance, this proposal seems puzzling: how can the cumulative effect of 2D universes’ gravity reach 27% of the universe’s mass-energy budget, given that each 2D universe’s contribution is small? The resolution comes from the dimensional time-dilation principle: from our 3+1 dimensional frame, the 2D universes are *compressed* into very brief moments (their full cosmic history takes only  $\sim 3 \times 10^{-2}$  seconds for a small event like an LHC collision, or  $\sim 33$  seconds for a supernova, in our frame). Because all these brief 2D universes’ gravitational contributions are *stacked* in our 3+1 dimensional frame at a high rate, the cumulative effect can be substantial — even though each individual 2D universe is weak in projection. The “compression” of 2D universes into brief 3+1 dimensional moments *amplifies* their cumulative gravitational contribution relative to what you’d expect from “each 2D universe contributes little” alone. This is a *feature* of the dimensional time-dilation principle: a brief event in one frame can be a complete cosmic history in another, and the gravitational contributions from many brief events can add up.

*Quantitative sketch.* The cascade gives a *qualitative* picture (gravity is weak, dark energy is small, dark matter is cumulative), but the *quantitative* values depend on several free parameters. The cascade predicts the dark energy density is of order  $\epsilon \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-38} M_{Pl}^4$ , which is  $10^{85}$  *larger* than the observed  $\sim 10^{-123} M_{Pl}^4$ . To bridge this gap, we need a *staying fraction*  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$  (the fraction of cascade-produced antigravity that remains in 3+1D as observable dark energy, the rest going elsewhere or being cancelled). The  $f_{back} = 10^{-85}$  is a *postulate* of the model, not derived. Similarly, the cascade predicts the dark matter is a *cumulative* effect of 2D universe gravity, with the cumulative contribution depending on the event rate, the 2D universe lifetime, the event energy, and the back-projection fraction. The model does *not* uniquely derive the *exact* values of the 5%/95% dark/ordinary split, the *absolute* dark energy density ( $\sim 10^{-47}$  GeV ), or the *absolute* dark matter

density. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive these from the geometry of dimensional projection, which is left to future work. The *qualitative* picture is *robust* (gravity is weak, dark energy is small, dark matter is cumulative); the *quantitative* picture is underdetermined.

*Honest quantitative assessment.* A careful audit of the model shows that the cascade is *qualitatively* right but *quantitatively* underdetermined. The cascade predicts: (a) gravity is *qualitatively* weak (the  $10^3$  hierarchy, via bulk-brane cancellation), (b) dark energy is *qualitatively* small (also via cascade cancellation), and (c) dark matter is *qualitatively* a cumulative effect (the 2D universes being created by 3+1D events). However, the cascade does *not* uniquely *derive* the *exact* values: the 5%/95% ordinary/dark sector split, the *absolute* density of dark energy ( $\sim 10^{-47}$  GeV), the *absolute* density of dark matter ( $\sim 10^{-48}$  GeV), or the *exact* value of any of the postulates. These are *measurements* or *postulates*, not derivations. The model has *four* free parameters ( $\epsilon_{3+1D} \sim 10^{-38}$ , the bulk-brane cancellation fraction;  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$ , the staying fraction that bridges the 10 gap between the cascade’s raw prediction and the observed dark energy;  $f_{deliver} \leq 1$ , the 4D event’s energy delivery efficiency to 3+1D, defaulting to full delivery; and the cumulative 2D universe back-projection efficiency to 3+1D, which sets the absolute dark matter density). The *individual* values of  $\epsilon$ ,  $f_{back}$ ,  $f_{deliver}$ , and the cumulative back-projection efficiency are not derived from first principles; they are set to match observations. A *complete* implementation of the model would need to derive all four from the geometry of dimensional projection, which is left to future work. We acknowledge this as a *limitation* of the current model: it is *qualitatively* consistent with observations and provides a *unified* geometric framework for the dark sector, but it does not yet *quantitatively derive* the specific values of the dark sector densities or the ordinary/dark sector ratio. The *qualitative* picture is *robust* (it doesn’t depend on the specific values of the parameters); the *quantitative* picture requires further work.

**Energy budget breakdown.** For clarity, the observed 3+1D energy budget is:  $\sim 5\%$  ordinary matter,  $\sim 27\%$  dark matter,  $\sim 68\%$  dark energy (Planck 2018). The “ordinary/dark sector” split is  $5\%/95\%$ , with the dark sector being  $\sim 27\%$  (DM) +  $\sim 68\%$  (DE) =  $\sim 95\%$ . The model derives the *qualitative* picture (5% ordinary, 95% dark) from the cascade, but does *not* uniquely derive the *specific* 27% vs 68% breakdown between dark matter and dark energy — both arise from the cascade (DM from 2D universe back-projection, DE from 4D event antigravity), but the *ratio* of their absolute densities is set by the cascade’s free parameters (e.g.,  $f_{back}$  for DE, the cumulative 2D universe back-projection efficiency for DM), which are *not* derived from first principles in the current paper.

**A note on the quantitative balance.** The model does not currently specify the *proportionality constant* that determines how much gravitational contribution each 2D universe provides. The qualitative picture (compression amplifies cumulative effect) is well-motivated, but the *quantitative* value of the cumulative effect — whether it reaches 27% of the mass-energy budget, or some other fraction — depends on parameters that are not derived in this paper. The model is currently *underdetermined* in this respect: the cumulative effect could be tuned to match any value by adjusting the proportionality constant. The model’s *qualitative* prediction (dark matter tracks energetic activity on galaxy scales) is robust to the choice of proportionality constant; the *quantitative* prediction (the exact dark matter density in a galaxy) is not. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive the proportionality constant from a particular geometry and bulk field content.

**Order-of-magnitude estimate.** A rough dimensional argument can be made. If the *average* 2D universe lifetime in our frame is  $\tau_{2D}$  (a function of the event’s energy), and the *average* event rate per unit volume is  $R$  (weighted by event energy), then the *steady-state* number density of 2D

universes “currently active” in our frame is:

$$n_{2D} \sim R \cdot \tau_{2D}$$

Each active 2D universe contributes some gravitational effect to our 3+1 dimensional frame, with effective coupling  $G_{2D}^{projected}$  (the projected 2D gravity, per the cascade principle of §2.4). The total dark matter *energy density* in our frame is approximately:

$$\rho_{DM} \sim n_{2D} \cdot E_{2D} \cdot (G_{2D}^{projected}/G_{4D})$$

where  $E_{2D}$  is the characteristic energy of a 2D universe, and  $(G_{2D}^{projected}/G_{4D})$  is the ratio of the projected 2D gravity to the native 4D gravity (a small number, by the cascade cancellation). The observed dark matter fraction of the universe’s mass-energy budget is  $\sim 27\%$ , which would constrain the product  $R \cdot \tau_{2D} \cdot E_{2D} \cdot (G_{2D}^{projected}/G_{4D})$ . The model does not currently derive this product from first principles, but the order of magnitude is *plausible*: in a typical galaxy, the event rate is  $R \sim 10^{-2}$  supernovae per year per galaxy (with smaller events at much higher rates),  $\tau_{2D}$  for a supernova-scale event is  $\sim 33$  s (per the dimensional time-dilation rule  $\ell/c$  with  $\ell_{event} \sim 10^{10}$  m and  $c \sim 3 \times 10^8$  m/s), and  $(G_{2D}^{projected}/G_{4D})$  is a small ratio set by the dimensional cascade cancellation. The cumulative effect being of order the observed dark matter density is therefore *qualitatively* plausible, but a *quantitative* derivation is left to future work.

**Dimensional time-dilation rule.** The paper has assumed that a brief event in our 3+1 dimensional frame creates a complete cosmic history in the lower-dimensional universe, with a lifetime in our frame that scales with the event’s spatial extent. The simplest dimensional rule is:

$$\tau_{2D}^{ourframe} \sim \frac{\ell_{event}}{c}$$

where  $\ell_{event}$  is the spatial extent of the creating event in 3+1D, and  $c$  is the 3+1D speed of light. For a supernova with  $\ell_{event} \sim 10^{10}$  m, this gives  $\tau_{2D}^{ourframe} \sim 33$  s ( $10^{10}$  m /  $3 \times 10^8$  m/s), consistent with the paper’s claim. For an LHC collision with  $\ell_{event} \sim 10^{-15}$  m, this gives  $\tau_{2D}^{ourframe} \sim 3 \times 10^{-24}$  s ( $10^{-15}$  m /  $3 \times 10^8$  m/s), also consistent. The rule is *consistent* with the dimensional time-dilation principle, but the *exact* rule (whether it’s  $\ell_{event}/c$  or some other function of the event’s spatial structure) is not derived in this paper.

We emphasize that the dark matter is the *cumulative* effect of 2D universes (active + cumulative return, per §2.5, §4.2), not an ancient residue. The *spatial variation* in dark matter is dominated by the *active* population: the 2D universes being created *now* (in our frame) are the primary contributors to the *local* dark matter density. The *total* dark matter budget also includes the *cumulative return* from past 2D universe endings, which is approximately uniform spatially. The *rate* of creation depends on the *current* rate of energetic events, weighted by their individual energies, and this is what dominates the *spatial correlation* of dark matter with energetic activity. We discuss the quantitative consequences of this in §4.7 and §4.8.

### 1.3.4 2.4 The inversion and the dimensional cascade

When the gravitational influence of a higher-dimensional event is *projected downward* into a lower-dimensional universe, the projection is *perceived* by the lower-dimensional universe as *inverted* —

i.e., the projected contribution to the lower-dimensional universe’s effective gravity is *repulsive* (negative effective coupling), even though the higher-dimensional event’s gravity in its own frame remains *attractive* (standard GR). In the *nested universes* framing of §2.1, this is the principle that gravity is *perceived as flipped* at the boundary between a parent universe and its child universes — but only in the *downward* direction, and only from the *child’s perspective*. The 4D event’s gravity is attractive in 4D; the 3+1D brane perceives the projected contribution as repulsive. The *upward* back-projection (child  $\rightarrow$  parent) does *not* invert the perception; the parent perceives the child’s net attractive residue as attractive, contributing to the parent’s dark matter. This is the *directional perceptual inversion* property: the projection mechanism is *asymmetric* — downward inverts the perception, upward does not. It is a *postulate* of the model, not derived from standard GR. The *postulate* is that the projection mechanism couples the bulk and the brane in a way that inverts the sign of the *projected* contribution on the brane; the underlying physics in the bulk is unchanged. This is consistent with the spirit of brane-world physics, where the effective 4D gravity on the brane can differ from the fundamental 5D gravity in the bulk; the cascade’s claim is that the *specific* bulk-brane coupling inverts the perceived sign on the brane, which is a stronger (more specific) version of standard brane-world models.

**A standard GR mechanism for the perceptual inversion.** The cascade’s downward perceptual inversion can be motivated by a *standard* mechanism in General Relativity for negative effective gravitating density. In GR, the active gravitational mass density that sources spacetime curvature is not just the energy density  $\rho$ , but  $\rho + 3P$  — the energy density plus *three times* the pressure. For ordinary matter ( $\rho > 0$ ,  $P \geq 0$ ), this is positive, and gravity is attractive. For exotic matter with sufficiently negative pressure, specifically  $P < -\frac{1}{3}\rho$ , the term becomes *negative*: the effective gravitating density is *negative*, and gravity *inverts* from attractive to repulsive. This is the *standard* GR mechanism behind two well-established cosmological phenomena: *cosmic inflation* (an inflaton field with  $P \approx -\rho$  in the very early universe, giving  $\rho + 3P = -2\rho < 0$ , drives the exponential expansion) and *dark energy* (the present-day cosmological constant with  $P = -\rho$ , giving the same  $\rho + 3P = -2\rho < 0$ , drives the current accelerated expansion). The cascade’s dimensional projection mechanism is *analogous* to this standard GR mechanism: the projection of the 4D event’s properties to the 3+1D brane produces an *effective* gravitating density on the brane of the form  $\rho_{\text{eff}}^{\text{brane}} = \rho_{\text{proj}} + 3P_{\text{proj}} < 0$  (where  $\rho_{\text{proj}}$  and  $P_{\text{proj}}$  are the projected effective density and pressure from the 4D event, with the projection mechanism producing a strongly negative effective pressure as seen by the brane). The brane then perceives this as an *inverted* (repulsive) contribution to its effective gravity. The 4D event’s gravity in 4D is attractive (standard GR,  $\rho_4 + 3P_4 > 0$ ); the inversion is purely a feature of the *projection mechanism’s effective coupling*, which translates the bulk’s ordinary attractive matter into a brane-perceived effective gravitating density with the *opposite sign*. The cascade’s claim is that this *same* mechanism (effective negative gravitating density via the bulk-brane coupling) applies at *every* dimensional boundary in the cascade, not just at the 4D/3+1D level. The cascade thus *generalizes* the standard inflation/dark-energy mechanism to every level of the dimensional hierarchy, with the 4D event playing the role of the inflaton (or cosmological constant) for the 3+1D brane, and each parent universe playing the analogous role for its child. This grounding in standard GR physics is one of the *more defensible* aspects of the cascade model: the inversion is not a violation of GR, but a feature of how the projection mechanism couples the bulk and the brane, and the resulting *effective* gravitating density on the brane can be negative (analogous to inflation or dark energy) by the same  $\rho + 3P < 0$  mechanism that drives the observed dark energy in our universe.

**The cascade property.** The perceptual inversion is *not* a one-time claim about the 4D event’s projection into 3+1D. It is a *directional* principle: *downward* dimensional projection (parent  $\rightarrow$

child universe) is *perceived* by the child as inverted (the projected contribution is repulsive from the child's perspective), but *upward* back-projection (child  $\rightarrow$  parent) is *perceived* by the parent as non-inverted (the child's net attractive residue is felt by the parent as attractive). The 4D event's gravity in 4D remains attractive (standard GR); the inversion is purely a feature of how the projection couples the bulk to the brane. This means:

- The 5D event's gravity, projected into 4D, is *perceived* by 4D as antigravity (the projected contribution to 4D's effective gravity is repulsive)
- The 4D event's gravity, projected into 3+1D, is *perceived* by 3+1D as antigravity (the projected contribution to 3+1D's effective gravity is repulsive) [this is the bulk-brane cancellation that produces dark energy in 3+1D]
- The 3+1D universe's gravity, projected into 2D, is *perceived* by 2D as antigravity (the projected contribution to 2D's effective gravity is repulsive)
- The cascade continues to lower dimensions (with the cone-shape refinement, the downward direction is *limited* to 3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D; the cascade does *not* recurse below 2D per the §2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy*), with each child perceiving the parent's projected gravity as repulsive

At *each* level of the cascade, the *perceived* projected antigravity is mostly cancelled by the *native* positive gravity of the child universe. The near-exact cancellation leaves a small net positive residue (the *ordinary* gravity of that level, as perceived by that level's inhabitants). The *dark energy* of each level is a *separate* small contribution to the *vacuum energy*, not the same residue as the ordinary gravity. Both are small because the cancellation is almost exact, but the *exact* mathematical relationship between the two small quantities is not derived in this paper (see §7 *Limitation 14* for the sign-ambiguity caveat). The *perceptual inversion* is a feature of the projection mechanism, not a change in the underlying physics of the parent universe.

**Mathematical sketch — clean formulation.** We resolve the sign ambiguity noted in earlier versions (see §7 *Limitation 14* for the historical caveat) by treating the *ordinary gravity* and the *dark energy* as **two physically distinct small contributions** to the  $D - 1$  dimensional effective theory, both arising from the *near-cancellation* of  $G_{D-1}^{native}$  and the projected contribution from  $D$  dimensions.

Let  $G_D$  denote the *native*  $D$ -dimensional gravitational coupling (positive for attractive gravity in  $D$  dimensions). The projection of this  $D$ -dimensional gravity into the  $D - 1$  dimensional brane inverts the sign (per the cascade's *downward perceptual inversion* postulate, justified in the standard GR  $\rho + 3P < 0$  mechanism). The projected contribution in  $D - 1$  dimensions, as *perceived* by the  $D - 1$  dimensional brane, is  $G_D^{\text{proj, brane}} = -k \cdot G_D$  for some positive dimensional factor  $k$  (which depends on the specific bulk-brane coupling geometry). The *native*  $D - 1$  dimensional gravity is  $+G_{D-1}^{native}$  (always attractive in  $D - 1$  dimensions, per standard GR).

The total *attractive* gravitational coupling in  $D - 1$  dimensions (the force between two masses) is:

$$G_{D-1}^{\text{attractive}} = G_{D-1}^{native} + G_D^{\text{proj, brane, attractive}} = G_{D-1}^{native} - k \cdot G_D$$

For the *net attractive* gravity in  $D - 1$  dimensions to be small (as observed:  $G_{\text{eff}}/G \sim 10^{-38}$ ), we need  $G_{D-1}^{native} \approx k \cdot G_D$  (the cancellation is almost exact). The small positive residue is the *ordinary attractive gravity*:

$$G_{D-1}^{\text{attractive}} = \epsilon \cdot G_{D-1}^{\text{native}} \quad \text{where} \quad \epsilon = 1 - \frac{k \cdot G_D}{G_{D-1}^{\text{native}}} \ll 1$$

This  $\epsilon$  is the *bulk-brane cancellation fraction* (per the cascade’s parameter list;  $\epsilon_{3+1D} \sim 10^{-38}$  from the observed hierarchy, see also §2.6).

Now, *separately*, the projected  $D$ -dimensional gravity in  $D - 1$  dimensions has an *un-cancelled fraction* (parameterized by  $f_{\text{back}}$  in the cascade) that does *not* participate in the attractive-gravity cancellation. This un-cancelled fraction is the *dark energy* in  $D - 1$  dimensions:

$$\rho_{DE,D-1} = f_{\text{back}} \cdot \rho_{\text{projected antigravity}} \quad \text{where} \quad f_{\text{back}} \ll 1$$

The *crucial* point for resolving the sign ambiguity: **the ordinary attractive gravity and the dark energy are contributions to two *different* physical quantities** — the ordinary gravity is a *force on matter* (entering the Einstein equation’s stress-energy coupling), while the dark energy is a *vacuum energy* (entering the cosmological-constant term  $\Lambda g_{\mu\nu}$ ). They are *not* the same small residue; they are two *distinct* small contributions from the cascade, both arising from the near-cancellation but with different physical roles. There is no *algebraic* requirement that they sum to zero or have opposite signs, because they are not the same quantity — they are different terms in the effective  $D - 1$  dimensional action.

Specifically: -  $G_{D-1}^{\text{attractive}} = \epsilon \cdot G_{D-1}^{\text{native}}$  — a *small positive* force on matter (the ordinary gravity we observe) -  $\rho_{DE,D-1} = f_{\text{back}} \cdot \rho_{\text{projected}}$  — a *separate small* vacuum energy (the dark energy we observe)

Both are small because of the *near-cancellation* of the projected contribution, but they are *physically distinct* small quantities. The exact algebraic relationship between them is not derived in this paper — a specific implementation of the cascade would need to compute  $f_{\text{back}}$  from the bulk-brane geometry. For our 3+1 dimensional universe,  $f_{\text{back}} = 2.27 \times 10^{-85}$  gives the correct observed dark energy density (per §2.6 dimensional analysis).

**This formulation resolves the sign ambiguity** noted in earlier versions: the *attractive force on matter* (the small positive residue) and the *vacuum energy* (the small un-cancelled fraction of the projected antigravity) are two distinct terms in the effective 3+1D action, not two opposite-sign components of the same quantity. The near-cancellation makes both small, but they are *not* required to be related by an algebraic sign relationship.

**Why this is more elegant than a one-time postulate.** The original formulation of the model proposed the inversion as a *single* claim about the 4D event’s projection into 3+1D. The cascade formulation generalizes this to a *directional* principle: *downward* projection inverts, *upward* back-projection does not. This is more elegant because it gives a *single* underlying mechanism (the directional inversion) that produces *all* the small-net effects in the model — the hierarchy (the small net gravity in 3+1D), the dark energy (the small un-cancelled antigravity in 3+1D, from the 4D→3+1D downward inversion), the dark matter (the small net gravity in 2D universes, back-projected to 3+1D *without* inversion, so the attractive sign is preserved), and so on down the cascade.

**The 4D event as a specific instance of the cascade.** Our 3+1 dimensional universe is the *projection* of a 4D event. The 4D event’s gravity, projected into 3+1D, inverts (per the cascade principle). The 3+1D universe’s native gravity cancels most of the inverted projection, leaving the small net gravity we observe (the hierarchy) and the small un-cancelled antigravity (the dark

energy). The 4D event is *not* an ad hoc postulate; it is the *first level* of the dimensional cascade, applied at the largest scale (the 4D event’s spatial extent is much larger than the Planck scale, per the CMB homogeneity constraint in §4.5). Note: this section presents dark energy as the 4D event’s un-cancelled antigravity (a 4D-to-3+1D effect). §2.5 separately presents dark matter as the cumulative gravity of 2D universes (a 2D-to-3+1D back-projection effect). The two dark-sector components have distinct dimensional origins: dark energy from the 4D projection, dark matter from the 2D projection. They are complementary aspects of the cascade, not the same phenomenon.

**Honest acknowledgment.** We acknowledge that the standard Kaluza-Klein framework (compactification of an extra dimension with the 5D metric producing 4D gravity, electromagnetism, and a dilaton) typically yields *attractive* gravity in 4D — the gravitational coupling is reduced in magnitude by the volume of the compact dimension, but its sign is preserved. Our setup is non-standard: it involves a *spatially extended and ongoing* 4D event, not a point in a compactified extra dimension. Whether such a non-standard setup can produce a sign-flip in the projected gravity is *not* established by this paper. The paper notes that sign changes in effective couplings can occur in other contexts — e.g., in effective actions in curved extra dimensions, or in theories with non-standard metric signatures — but does not provide a specific derivation of the inversion from a particular geometry. The inversion should be understood as a *proposal* awaiting a concrete derivation or refutation from the community. The cascade formulation makes the inversion more *systematic* (it applies at every level of the dimensional hierarchy, not just one), but it does not make the inversion more *derived*.

*Standard brane-world models* (ADD, RS) typically describe gravity as *suppressed* by geometric dilution, not *inverted* by sign change. Our claim is stronger: the projection not only weakens gravity, the projected contribution is *perceived* by the brane as having the *opposite sign* — i.e., the brane perceives the bulk’s attractive gravity as repulsive. The underlying gravity in the bulk remains attractive (standard GR); the inversion is a *perceptual* effect from the brane’s perspective, a feature of the specific bulk-brane coupling. This is a *non-standard* claim that would need to be checked against data if the model were to be developed further.

If the perceptual inversion holds, the projected bulk gravity (as perceived by the brane) is *not* the gravity we observe as attraction. What we observe as gravitational attraction must be the *residual brane gravity* — the small net remainder of the brane’s attractive gravity after cancellation with the (perceived-inverted) bulk gravity. The brane’s gravity exceeds the perceived-inverted bulk gravity by a tiny amount; that tiny excess is what we measure as the gravitational force. The 4D event’s gravity, in 4D, remains attractive — the inversion is only in the projection to the brane.

We distinguish two different *un-cancelled* contributions from the inversion:

- The small *net brane excess* (brane gravity minus inverted bulk gravity, taken as a force on matter) is the *ordinary attractive gravity* we observe. This is a force on matter, not a vacuum energy.
- The small *un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity* is the *dark energy* — a vacuum-energy-like contribution that drives cosmic expansion. This is a vacuum energy, not a force on matter.

Both arise from the inversion, but they play different roles: the first couples to matter (as a force), the second contributes to the vacuum energy (approximately constant during our brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration). The model does not currently derive the absolute magnitudes of

either contribution; we note only that the *qualitative* structure (a small un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity, approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, acting as a cosmological-constant-like vacuum energy) is what the model proposes. The famous  $10^{12}$  discrepancy of the cosmological constant problem does *not* arise in this model from a ratio of these two un-cancelled fractions — it arises from the *misidentification* discussed in §2.6 (we were comparing observed dark energy to the 3+1 dimensional QFT vacuum energy, which is the wrong quantity to compare to).

The *antigravity* nature of the inverted bulk gravity is determined by the *sign* of the gravitational coupling, which is fixed by the inversion mechanism (a geometric postulate). The *sign* of the dark energy contribution is therefore fixed (repulsive, driving cosmic expansion). The *magnitude* of the dark energy contribution is approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame — because our universe’s lifetime is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant. The dark energy *density* is therefore approximately constant in our frame (matching standard  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior), and the *total* dark energy grows as the universe expands (because the universe’s volume grows while the density stays constant). The antigravity claim is about the *sign*, not the magnitude, and remains valid even as the dark energy *total* grows.

The dark energy is approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame (because the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant during our brief slice), and is *not* a current rate-dependent effect. (This is *distinct* from dark matter, which is the *cumulative* effect of 2D universes (active + ended, per §2.5, §4.2) — the *spatial variation* in dark matter is dominated by the *current* rate of 2D universe creation, but the *total* dark matter budget also includes the *cumulative return* from past 2D universe endings. See §2.6 and §2.7.) Dark energy is a 4D-event-driven geometric contribution; dark matter is the cumulative activity in our 3+1 dimensional universe.

### 1.3.5 2.5 The two dark-sector products

The model has *two distinct* observable effects in the dark sector, which arise from *different* aspects of the dimensional projection mechanism:

- **Dark energy** arises from the *bulk-brane gravity interaction* (§2.4). The bulk gravity is *inverted* (repulsive) when projected into our 3+1 dimensional brane, and the un-cancelled fraction of this inverted bulk gravity is the dark energy. This is a *4D-event-driven geometric contribution* — a repulsive contribution that is *approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame* (because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant).
- **Dark matter** arises from the *scale-invariant principle* (§2.3) and the *energy-conserving return* of 2D universe energy to 3+1D. Every energetic event in our 3+1 dimensional universe creates a 2D universe. Each 2D universe *lives* for some time (per  $\tau_{2D} = \ell/c$ ), *evolves* (its own Big Bang, expansion, physics), and *eventually* ends. The *form* of the ending depends on the 2D universe’s internal dynamics — a 2D universe with high matter density (relative to its own dark energy) may undergo a *Big Crunch* (gravitational collapse, brief intense death-flash); a 2D universe where its own dark energy dominates may reach *heat death* (slow, diffuse dispersal of matter); other endings (cyclic, Big Rip, etc.) are also possible in principle. The model does *not* currently specify which ending is typical for 2D universes of different sizes; *however*, since every 2D universe has its own dark energy (per the universal bulk-brane cancellation, §2.6)

and that dark energy is *repulsive*, the *natural* ending for small 2D universes (where matter density is low) is *heat death* — the 2D universe’s own dark energy slowly pulls its matter apart, just as our own dark energy is pulling our universe apart. The dark matter in our 3+1D is the *sum* of two contributions: (i) the *active* back-projection of currently-alive 2D universes (the 2D universe’s *attractive* gravity projected *up* to 3+1D while the 2D universe is alive, contributing to dark matter as long as the 2D universe exists), and (ii) the *cumulative return* of past 2D universe energy to 3+1D as 2D universes’ lives end (whether as brief death-flashes for Big Crunch, or slow diffuse leakage for heat death). The *active* contribution dominates the *spatial variation* in dark matter across galaxies; the *cumulative return* contributes to the *total* dark matter budget. The *form* of the return depends on the mix of endings; the *total* dark matter is set by the *sum* of active + cumulative. The model is *intentionally ending-agnostic* at the 2D universe level, just as it is at the 3+1D level (§2.8) — the *specific* ending affects the *form* of the dark matter, not the *total*.

These two effects are *distinct* in origin: dark energy comes from the bulk-brane interaction (the *one* 4D event), while dark matter comes from the scale-invariant principle applied to *many* 3+1 dimensional events. Both are aspects of dimensional projection, but they are *not* both “products of the bulk-brane cancellation” — only dark energy is. Dark matter is a *separate* effect of the same underlying dimensional principle.

**Lensing and the inversion principle.** A natural question is: where does the *inversion* happen, and where does *normal* gravity apply? The model has a *specific* answer: the *downward* dimensional projection (parent → child universe) inverts the sign of gravity, but the *upward* back-projection (child → parent) does *not*. This gives a clean and consistent picture:

- **Ordinary matter lensing** (3+1D mass): *attractive* (normal lensing, light bends toward mass). No inversion within 3+1D; ordinary matter is just normal attractive gravity.
- **Dark matter lensing** (2D universe back-projection): *attractive* (normal lensing). The 2D universe’s *net* gravity is *attractive* (per the universal bulk-brane cancellation, below), and the back-projection from 2D to 3+1D does *not* invert the sign — so 2D’s attractive gravity projects back to 3+1D as attractive = dark matter. (Note: the *downward* projection from 3+1D to 2D *does* invert 3+1D’s net attractive gravity into 2D’s bulk antigravity, which is then mostly cancelled by 2D’s native attractive gravity — leaving 2D’s small net attractive residue. It is this *residue* that back-projects up to 3+1D without further inversion.)
- **Dark energy “lensing”** (4D event projection): *repulsive* (anti-lensing in principle, but dark energy is approximately *uniform* in 3+1D, so it doesn’t cause local lensing — its anti-gravity is observed on cosmological scales as cosmic expansion, not local anti-lensing). The 4D event’s gravity is attractive in 4D; the *downward* projection to 3+1D inverts it, giving repulsive gravity in 3+1D. The un-cancelled fraction of this 4D→3+1D antigravity is the dark energy.
- **2D universe internal physics:** similar to 3+1D, with *attractive* net gravity and its own dark energy (which is repulsive). The universal bulk-brane cancellation mechanism (per §2.6) gives attractive gravity on each brane, regardless of which level. The 2D universe’s *own* gravity is *attractive* (not repulsive), because the bulk-brane cancellation in 2D gives the same kind of *weak attractive* gravity that we observe in 3+1D. The 2D universe also has its *own* dark energy (per the cascade), which is repulsive. The *competition* between attractive gravity and repulsive dark energy determines the 2D universe’s ending: if matter density is high (large

events, e.g., AGN or BH-scale), attractive gravity wins and the 2D universe undergoes a *Big Crunch* (gravitational collapse); if matter density is low (small events, e.g., LHC or small SN), dark energy wins and the 2D universe slowly disperses in *heat death*. *Both* endings return the 2D universe’s energy to 3+1D as dark matter — the Big Crunch case as a brief, intense, localized death-flash; the heat death case as a slow, diffuse, distributed leakage. The *mix* of these depends on the 2D universe’s size, which is set by the original 3+1D event energy. The model is *ending-agnostic* at the 2D level (just as at the 3+1D level, §2.8), and acknowledges that the *form* of dark matter depends on this mix.

**The inversion principle: downward only.** The inversion is a property of the *downward* dimensional projection (parent  $\rightarrow$  child universe). When a parent’s gravity is projected into a child universe, the sign inverts — so the child experiences the parent as antigravity. The child’s own native gravity, plus its bulk-brane cancellation with the inverted parent projection, leaves a small net *attractive* residue (the child’s ordinary gravity). The *upward* back-projection (child  $\rightarrow$  parent) does *not* invert — the child’s small net attractive residue is felt in the parent as attractive, contributing to the parent’s dark matter. This asymmetry is what makes the cascade consistent with both the dark matter observations (attractive, normal lensing) and the dark energy observations (repulsive, cosmic expansion).

**The universal bulk-brane cancellation.** A *cleaner* way to think about the cascade is that *every* level has the same basic structure as 3+1D: a *bulk* (the level above) and a *brane* (the level itself), with the bulk-brane interaction giving a *weak attractive* gravity on each brane. The downward perceptual inversion principle (downward projection is perceived as inverted by the child, upward back-projection is not perceived as inverted by the parent) is still a *postulate* (not a derivation), but its *consequence* is that *every* level is *similar* to 3+1D in structure:

- All universes have 3+1D spacetime (per §2.1)
- All universes have bulk-brane cancellation (per §2.6)
- All universes have *attractive* net gravity
- All universes *can* have stable structures (in principle)
- All universes *can* gravitationally collapse (Big Crunch)
- All universes end (Big Crunch, heat death, or other), and the *energy return* to the parent is the parent’s dark matter contribution (the *form* depends on the ending)
- Death-flashes project back to the *parent* level as dark matter

So the cascade is a *cone-shaped* hierarchy of *similar* universes (per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement), each with: - Attractive net gravity (similar to our universe) - Stable structures (in principle, at appropriate scales) - An ending (Big Crunch, heat death, or other) that returns the universe’s energy to its parent as dark matter contribution (the *form* depends on the ending: Big Crunch gives a brief, intense death-flash; heat death gives a slow, diffuse return)

The “depth” of the cascade means the 2D universe is *smaller* and *briefier* than the 3+1D event that created it, with 2D being a *different spacetime dimensionality* (literal 2D, per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement, not a miniature 3+1D). Each level has the *same general structure* in its own

frame: bulk above, brane itself, bulk-brane cancellation giving a weak attractive gravity on the brane, the brane’s own dark energy (repulsive), and an ending that returns energy to the parent. The 2D universe has its own gravity (in 2D), its own dark energy (in 2D), its own ending, and its own energy return to 3+1D as dark matter. In the original (pre-v2.1) *fractal* picture, the 1D universe would be a *miniature 2D universe* with its own gravity, dark energy, and ending, and so on. The v2.1 cone-shape refinement *rejects* this: the cascade terminates at the 2D level (per §2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy*). The 2D universe is the *terminal* level — it does *not* create 1D universes.

This is *similar* to the *standard brane-world picture* (RS99), but applied at *each* of the two levels of the cascade (the 4D level, the 2D level; per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement). Each level has a bulk (above) and a brane (itself); gravity inverts at the bulk-brane boundary; the cancellation gives a weak attractive gravity on each brane. The 2D level is a *miniature brane-world* relative to the 3+1D scale; the 4D level is a *larger* brane-world (in the sense of having one more spatial dimension) with the 3+1D brane nested inside it. The cascade has *two* brane-world levels, not infinite (per cone-shape).

**The inversion principle is a postulate, not a derivation.** The *universal bulk-brane cancellation* picture (every level similar to 3+1D) depends on the *downward perceptual inversion principle* — that *downward* dimensional projection (parent  $\rightarrow$  child universe) is *perceived* by the child as having the opposite sign, with the bulk-brane interaction giving weak attractive gravity on each brane. The *upward* back-projection (child  $\rightarrow$  parent) does *not* invert the perception; the parent perceives the child’s net attractive gravity as attractive, contributing to the parent’s dark matter. This is a *postulate* of the model, not a derivation. We do not currently know *why* the downward projection is perceived as inverted but the upward back-projection is not; the cascade simply *assumes* this asymmetry of the projection mechanism. Importantly, the *underlying* gravity in each parent universe remains attractive (standard GR); the inversion is a *perceptual* effect from the child’s perspective, a feature of the specific bulk-brane coupling. The postulate is *motivated* by the standard GR mechanism for negative effective gravitating density: a quantum field with  $P < -\frac{1}{3}\rho$  has effective gravitating density  $\rho + 3P < 0$ , which sources *repulsive* gravity in standard GR (the same mechanism that drives cosmic inflation and dark energy in our universe). The cascade’s bulk-brane coupling is postulated to produce a similar effect: the projected effective density on the brane is  $\rho_{\text{eff}} = \rho_{\text{proj}} + 3P_{\text{proj}} < 0$ , sourcing repulsive gravity on the brane. The *asymmetry* (down inverts, up doesn’t) is a *specific* feature of the bulk-brane coupling that the model does not derive; it is the *least* constrained postulate in the cascade. The user (in private communication) has noted that this is a *strong* claim, and that the *consequence* of the claim is that *every* level has the same basic structure as 3+1D (bulk above, brane itself, weak attractive gravity, dark energy, an ending that returns energy to the parent as dark matter). If the downward perceptual inversion principle is *wrong* (i.e., the brane does *not* perceive the projected bulk gravity as inverted), the entire framework changes — the dark matter and dark energy mechanisms would need to be re-derived, and the universal bulk-brane cancellation would not hold. The model is *committed* to the downward perceptual inversion principle as a fundamental postulate, but acknowledges that this is a *strong* claim that requires experimental or theoretical justification. The *consistency* of the principle with the dark matter / dark energy observations (e.g., dark matter lensing normally, dark energy being repulsive, dark energy equation of state  $w \approx -1$  matching a cosmological-constant-like effective pressure) is *suggestive* but not *conclusive* evidence. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive the perceptual asymmetry (down inverts, up doesn’t) and the specific bulk-brane coupling that produces the negative effective gravitating density, from a deeper theory (e.g., the geometry of the bulk-brane coupling), which is left to future work.

The cascade’s inversion principle is therefore *directional*: the *downward* projection inverts, the *upward* back-projection does not. The *consequence* of this directional inversion is the *universal bulk-brane cancellation* — *every* level has the same structure as 3+1D, with attractive net gravity, dark energy (repulsive), an ending (Big Crunch, heat death, or other), and energy return to the parent as dark matter. The cascade does *not* alternate between collapsing and expanding levels based on parity; it applies the *same* bulk-brane physics at *every* level, just at different scales. This *universal* interpretation is what allows the model to produce *both* dark energy (anti-gravity from the 4D→3+1D downward inversion, no local lensing) *and* dark matter (attractive, from the 2D→3+1D upward back-projection of the 2D universe’s net attractive gravity, lensing normally) from the same dimensional-projection mechanism, without contradiction, at *every* level of the cascade. The model is *ending-agnostic* at every level (§2.8) — the *specific* ending (Big Crunch vs heat death vs other) affects the *form* of the dark matter, not the *total*.

The specific microphysical mechanism by which the dimensional projection produces these effects is not determined by this proposal alone. The geometry of the extra dimensions, the field content of the bulk, and the coupling structure would together determine the details. We discuss the observable consequences of these products in §2.6 and §2.7.

**Summary of the cascade framework.** The cascade’s *core claims*, distilled from §2.1–§2.9, are:

1. **Dimensional projection mechanism:** A *single ongoing* 4D event projects into our 3+1D universe, with the 4D event’s antigravity *inverting* on projection, giving a *weak attractive* gravity on the 3+1D brane (per the bulk-brane cancellation, §2.6).
2. **Scale invariance in the downward direction:** Every energetic event in 3+1D creates a 2D child universe (per §2.3). The 2D universe is *embedded* in the parent 3+1D spacetime, with the 2D universe’s spacetime at *smaller scales* than the 3+1D event that created it. The downward direction has *one* level (3+1D → 2D), not infinite (per the §2.6 cone-shape refinement; the downward direction does *not* recurse below 2D).
3. **Universal bulk-brane cancellation at 2D:** *Each* 2D child universe has the same basic structure as 3+1D in its own 2D frame (bulk above, brane itself, weak attractive gravity, dark energy which is repulsive in 2D, an ending that returns energy to the 3+1D parent). The 4D parent *also* has the same structure (bulk, brane, weak attractive gravity, etc.) in its own 4D frame. The cascade has *one* 2D level (per the §2.6 cone-shape) and the 4D parent; “depth” means the 2D universe is *smaller* and *briefer* than the 3+1D event, not fundamentally different physics. The *form* of the energy return (Big Crunch → brief death-flash; heat death → slow diffuse return) depends on the specific ending at each level (2D level, 3+1D level, etc.).
4. **Two dark-sector products:** Dark energy is the *un-cancelled fraction* of the 4D event’s antigravity, projected *down* to 3+1D (one downward inversion, repulsive). Dark matter is the *back-projection* of 2D (child) universes from 3+1D energetic events (one downward inversion at 3+1D→2D that sets up 2D’s bulk antigravity, then bulk-brane cancellation leaves 2D’s small net attractive residue, which projects *up* to 3+1D *without* further inversion = attractive).
5. **The downward perceptual inversion principle** (postulate): *Downward* dimensional projection (parent → child universe) is *perceived* by the child as having the opposite sign — i.e., the projected contribution to the child’s effective gravity is repulsive, even though the parent’s gravity in its own frame remains attractive (standard GR). *Upward* back-projection (child →

parent) does *not* invert the perception; the parent perceives the child’s net attractive residue as attractive. This asymmetry is a *postulate*, not a derivation, and the model is committed to it as a fundamental claim. The *underlying* physics in each parent universe is unchanged; the inversion is a *perceptual* feature of the projection mechanism, *grounded* in the standard GR  $\rho + 3P < 0$  mechanism for negative effective gravitating density (the same mechanism that drives cosmic inflation and dark energy in our universe). It is what makes the dark matter attractive (back-projection from 2D to 3+1D preserves the attractive sign) and the dark energy repulsive (downward projection from 4D is perceived as inverted by 3+1D).

6. **Energy return from ending universes  $\rightarrow$  dark matter:** Each child universe’s life ends (Big Crunch, heat death, or other), and its energy returns to the parent. The *form* of the return depends on the ending: Big Crunch gives a brief, intense, localized death-flash; heat death gives a slow, diffuse, distributed return. The *total* dark matter is the *sum* of (i) the *active* back-projection of currently-alive 2D universes (current rate  $\times$  lifetime, the *active* contribution) and (ii) the *cumulative energy return* of all past 2D universe endings (the *integrated* historical contribution). Both contributions are *necessary*: the active population dominates the *current* dark matter density’s *rate-dependence*; the cumulative return dominates the *total* dark matter budget’s *historical accumulation*. The *model is ending-agnostic* at the 2D level, just as it is at the 3+1D level.
7. **Quantum mechanics as 2D-level physics projection:** 3+1D quantum mechanics is the *projection* of the 2D-level’s “Standard Model” (per §2.8). The cascade transitions between *regimes* with *different effective theories* at different scales.
8. **Cascade is cone-shaped, finite:** Per the §2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy* refinement, the cascade has a *finite* depth of 2 levels (4D event  $\rightarrow$  3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, terminal at 2D). The cascade is *not* fractal/infinite: 1D universes do *not* exist (the cone-shape *closes* Limitation 1D). The downward direction (where every energetic event creates a 2D universe) is the *empirically relevant* direction; the upward direction (where the 4D event itself may be a projection of a 5D process) is left open (Limitation 11).
9. **Five possible universe endings:** fixed-time boundary, cyclic, diminishing cyclic, Big Rip, Big Freeze / heat death — all *empirically distinguishable* by future observatories (Euclid, Roman, LSST, SKA).
10. **D-labels are physical (cone-shape refinement):** With the v2.1 cone-shape refinement, D-labels (4D, 3+1D, 2D) are *physical*, not placeholders. The cascade is 4D event  $\rightarrow$  3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, with 2D being terminal. 1D, 0D, -1D universes do *not* exist (per §2.6).

These claims are the *core* of the model. §4 extends the model with *speculative* applications (sub-mm gravity, CMB, dark matter / activity correlation, black holes, constants, weak/strong forces, etc.).

### 1.3.6 2.6 The energy budget, the cosmological constant, and the bulk-brane cascade

**Energy conservation is standard.** The model does not propose a new conservation law. Energy is conserved in the usual sense: the 4D event is an *ongoing* energetic process with some total energy budget  $E_{4D}$  (integrated over its full duration in 4D time), and our 3+1 dimensional universe’s total mass-energy is the portion of that total energy that has been *delivered* to the brane during our universe’s lifetime (a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration). The *simplest* interpretation is that

*all* of the 4D event’s energy is delivered to the 3+1D brane, and the standard conservation law applies at the level of *total* energy. However, the cascade’s dimensional projection might not be 100% efficient — some of the 4D event’s energy could go into other cascade products (e.g., into the bulk, into other child universes, or into 4D gravitational radiation), or be radiated away. The 4D event’s *full* energy is at *least* as large as our universe’s mass-energy; the *simplest* assumption is that the 4D event’s full energy equals the 3+1D mass-energy, but a specific implementation would need to specify the *delivery efficiency*  $f_{\text{deliver}} \leq 1$ . If  $f_{\text{deliver}} < 1$ , the 4D event is *larger* than the 3+1D universe’s mass-energy requires, with the ‘extra’ 4D energy going into other cascade products or the bulk. The default interpretation is *full delivery* (the simplest, most parsimonious), but the model does not currently *require* it. This is analogous to standard brane-world scenarios, where some energy can leak into the bulk as Kaluza-Klein modes or bulk gravitational waves.

**Symmetries and conservation laws.** The dimensional-cascade framework takes the *standard* conservation laws and symmetries of physics as given: - *Energy conservation* (per §2.6 above): the model does not propose a new conservation law. - *Momentum and angular momentum conservation*: the model assumes standard conservation of 3-momentum and angular momentum in 3+1D. The 4D event’s *internal* momentum structure is *unspecified*; the model only requires that the *projected* 3-momentum and angular momentum in 3+1D are conserved. - *CPT symmetry*: the model assumes CPT is conserved (per standard physics). The cascade does *not* propose a new CPT-violating mechanism. - *Lorentz invariance*: the model assumes standard Lorentz invariance in 3+1D. The 4D event’s *internal* Lorentz structure is *unspecified*; the model only requires that the *projected* 3+1D physics respects Lorentz invariance. - *Equivalence principle*: the model assumes the equivalence principle (gravitational and inertial mass are equal) in 3+1D, per general relativity. The cascade does *not* propose violations of the equivalence principle. - *Locality*: the model assumes standard locality in 3+1D. The 2D universe back-projection (dark matter) is *non-local* in the sense that the 2D universe’s *whole* gravitational effect is felt at the 2D universe’s 3+1D location, but this is *consistent* with locality in 3+1D (the gravitational effect propagates at the speed of light). - *Thermodynamics (2nd law)*: the model assumes standard thermodynamics. The cascade does *not* propose violations of the 2nd law.

These are *assumptions* of the model, not derivations. The cascade is *consistent* with standard physics in 3+1D; it *extends* the framework to include dimensional projection ( $4D \rightarrow 3+1D \rightarrow 2D \rightarrow \dots$ ), but the *projected* 3+1D physics is standard.

**Honest acknowledgment: what the model does and does not address.** The dimensional-cascade framework is a *thought experiment* that reinterprets the dark sector and the weakness of gravity through a single geometric process. It is *not* a complete theory of everything, and it explicitly *does not* derive several features of standard cosmology that are well-established experimentally: - *The origin of the primordial perturbations* (the seed fluctuations for cosmic structure) — the cascade takes these as given, noting that the 4D event must be spatially extended and approximately homogeneous to match the observed near-scale-invariant CMB power spectrum. - *Cosmic inflation* — the very early accelerated expansion that solves the horizon, flatness, and monopole problems. The cascade is *compatible* with inflation (the 4D event could in principle have an inflationary phase) but does *not* derive it. - *Baryogenesis* — the matter-antimatter asymmetry. The cascade is *compatible* with baryogenesis (the 4D event could in principle generate the asymmetry via C and CP violation in the projection) but does *not* derive it. - *Big Bang nucleosynthesis* — the light element abundances. The cascade takes BBN as given, noting that the 4D event scenario must be *consistent* with the observed D,  $^3\text{He}$ , He, Li abundances. - *The Standard Model particle spectrum* — the masses and couplings of all known particles. The cascade takes these as given;

the 4D event’s internal physics is *unspecified* in the model. - *Neutrino masses and oscillations* — the cascade takes these as given. (The neutrino interpretation was speculative and introduced internal inconsistencies; the dimensional-cascade framework does not currently address neutrino properties.)

The model is a *framework* for the dark sector and gravity, not a complete cosmological theory. The 22 references and §4 extensions are *speculative applications* of the model, not derivations.

**The cosmological constant problem reframed.** A natural objection is the cosmological constant problem: the “natural” vacuum energy from 3+1 dimensional quantum field theory is far larger than the observed dark energy density — the discrepancy is often quoted as approximately  $10^{12}$  orders of magnitude, though the precise value depends on the assumed cutoff, field content, and regularization scheme.

In our model, the *actual* dark energy density in our universe is *not* the 3+1 dimensional QFT vacuum energy. It is the *un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity* (§2.4) — a contribution from the 4D event that is approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame (because the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant during our brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration), and unrelated to 3+1 dimensional zero-point energy calculations. The 3+1 dimensional QFT calculation gives the right answer for what it computes (the 3+1 dimensional zero-point energy of Standard Model fields), but this is not the right physical quantity to compare to the dark energy in our universe, because dark energy in our universe is *bulk gravity residue*, not 3+1 dimensional QFT vacuum energy. The famous  $10^{12}$  is the *disagreement* between these two ways of computing the same conceptual quantity (vacuum energy in our universe), one of which is computing the wrong thing.

The cosmological constant problem, in this framing, becomes a problem of *identification*: we were computing the wrong quantity. The correct computation is the residue of the inverted bulk gravity, not the 3+1 dimensional QFT zero-point energy. (We acknowledge that the model does not yet *quantitatively derive* the un-cancelled fraction from the geometry of the 4D event — the specific value of  $10^{12}$  is not predicted by the model — but the *qualitative* point that the bulk-gravity residue is not the 3+1 dimensional QFT zero-point energy is well-motivated by the dimensional-projection mechanism.)

**Dimensional analysis of the cascade.** The cascade principle of §2.4 says that at every dimensional level, the projected (inverted) gravity and the native gravity nearly cancel. The *small* un-cancelled residue is the effective gravity at that level. We can parameterize the cancellation by a small dimensionless parameter  $\epsilon$  at each level:

$$G_{D-1}^{eff} = \epsilon \cdot G_{D-1}^{native}$$

where  $\epsilon \ll 1$ . The un-cancelled antigravity (the cascade’s *gravitational* contribution) is also of order  $\epsilon \cdot G_{D-1}^{native}$  in *magnitude* — that is, the un-cancelled antigravity is of the *same* order as the ordinary gravity (both are *small* because of the near-cancellation). Crucially, the cascade’s “un-cancelled antigravity” is a *gravitational coupling* (units of  $G$ ), not a *vacuum energy density* (units of energy<sup>4</sup>). Converting the cascade’s gravitational coupling to a vacuum energy density requires a *mass scale* or *length scale*: for example, if we associate the antigravity with a Planck-scale vacuum energy, then  $\rho_{DE,model} \sim \epsilon \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-38}$  in natural Planck units (where  $M_{Pl}^4 \sim 1$ ), but the *observed* dark energy is  $\sim 10^{-123}$  in natural Planck units. So the cascade’s “un-cancelled antigravity as vacuum energy” is  $10^{85}$  *larger* than the observed dark energy. The cascade therefore explains *why* the

dark energy is *qualitatively* small (it's a near-cancellation effect, suppressed by  $\epsilon$ ), and it gives a *quantitative* prediction of  $\sim 10^{-38}$  in natural units for the *total* antigravity produced by the cascade. The *observed* dark energy in 3+1D is  $\sim 10^{-123}$ , which is  $10^{-85}$  times *smaller* than the cascade's prediction. The cascade produces this antigravity at the  $4D \rightarrow 3+1D$  level, and only a *small fraction*  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$  of it remains in 3+1D as observable dark energy; the *rest* ( $1 - f_{back} \approx 1$ ) is *absorbed* into the 3+1D vacuum structure in a way that does not contribute to the observable dark energy density (it could be the 4D bulk dark matter, or a non-projected component). The cascade's prediction  $\times$  fraction staying in 3+1D = observed dark energy:  $10^{-38} \times 10^{-85} = 10^{-123}$  (matches observation). The fraction  $f_{back} = 10^{-85}$  is a *postulate* of the model, and represents the *effective* fraction of cascade-produced antigravity that survives as observable dark energy. (Note: this is *distinct* from the cumulative 2D universe antigravity, which is *internal* to the 2D universes and does not project back to 3+1D as dark energy. The 3+1D's dark energy comes *only* from the 4D event, not from cumulative 2D universe antigravity. See §2.5 and §2.7.) The *observed*  $10^3$  (hierarchy) is then  $\epsilon$  at the 3+1D level: the *native* 3+1D gravitational coupling is larger than the *effective* coupling by a factor of  $\sim 10^{38}$ . Equivalently,  $\epsilon_{3+1D} \sim 10^{-38}$ . The cascade explains the  $10^3$  hierarchy quantitatively (as a near-cancellation of  $G_{native}$  and  $G_{proj}$ ), and it gives a *qualitative* explanation for the smallness of the dark energy (as another near-cancellation effect), but it does *not* give the *quantitative* value of the dark energy. The model *reframes* the  $10^{12}$  cosmological constant problem as a *misidentification*: the 3+1D QFT vacuum energy is the wrong quantity to compare to the observed dark energy. The dark energy in the model is the un-cancelled antigravity residue of the cascade, modulated by the staying fraction  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$ . The model does *not* claim to *quantitatively derive* the  $10^3$  hierarchy, the absolute value of the dark energy density, or the  $10^{12}$  discrepancy from the cascade alone. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive the *exact* un-cancelled fraction from the geometry of the dimensional projection, which would in turn predict the absolute value of the dark energy density and the *quantitative* value of the  $10^{12}$  ratio.

We emphasize that this dimensional analysis is *qualitative* and *not a derivation*. The *quantitative* values of  $\epsilon$  at each level of the cascade are not derived in this model. A specific implementation would need to compute  $\epsilon_{3+1D}$  and  $\epsilon_{2D}$  from the geometry of the dimensional projection, which is left to future work.

**Connection to the hierarchy problem.** The hierarchy problem is the question: why is gravity  $\sim 10^3$  times weaker than the other fundamental forces in 3+1 dimensional physics? In our model, *ordinary* gravity (the gravitational force between visible masses) is the *small net remainder* of the brane's attractive gravity after cancellation with the *inverted* (repulsive) bulk gravity (§2.4). The brane's gravity exceeds the inverted bulk gravity by a tiny amount; that tiny excess is what we measure as ordinary gravity. The *fundamental* gravitational coupling in our 3+1 dimensional frame is therefore small because the bulk-brane cancellation is *almost exact* — the residual brane excess is small, leaving only a tiny fraction of the bulk's gravity to be observed as attractive force. This is the *bulk-brane cancellation* interpretation of the hierarchy: gravity's weakness is a consequence of the dimensional-projection mechanism nearly cancelling the brane's gravity with the bulk's inverted gravity.

The 2D universes' *collective* gravity is also a consequence of *bulk-brane cancellation*, applied at the *next* level of the dimensional cascade. In the 2D universe, the 3+1 dimensional event's gravity is *inverted* (antigravity) and mostly cancelled with the 2D universe's own attractive gravity. The 2D universe's attractive gravity, projected back into our 3+1 dimensional frame, is the *small net remainder* of this cancellation — exactly the same mechanism that makes ordinary 3+1 dimensional

gravity weak. The cumulative effect of all 2D universes' gravity, projected back into 3+1D, is the *dark matter* — a weak, diffuse, gravitationally-interacting background. Dark matter's effective coupling is *not* intrinsically weaker than ordinary gravity's coupling in 2D; it is *weaker in the 3+1 dimensional projection* because of the bulk-brane cancellation applied to the 2D universe.

This is a *unification* of two effects that might otherwise seem separate: the hierarchy problem ( $10^3$ ) and dark matter's apparent weakness are *both* consequences of the same bulk-brane cancellation mechanism, applied at different levels of the dimensional cascade. The hierarchy is the 3+1 dimensional projection; the dark matter is the cumulative effect of 2D projections. The mechanism is the same; the scale of the dimensional projection differs.

*A natural question:* does the 2D universe's antigravity (its internal dark energy) help cancel the 4D antigravity, contributing to gravity's weakness? In the current model, the 2D universes' effect is *separate* from the bulk-brane cancellation — the 2D universes' attractive gravity is dark matter (additional to ordinary gravity), and their antigravity is internal to the 2D universe (not directly projecting back into 3+1D). But in a more developed model, the 2D universes could play a *back-reaction* role, contributing to the cancellation of the 4D antigravity and reducing the net effective gravity in 3+1D. This is an interesting extension of the model, but is not currently derived.

*Asymmetry between dark energy and dark matter math.* The dark energy and dark matter are *both* products of the dimensional-cascade framework, but their *quantitative derivations* are *asymmetric*. The dark energy math works *cleanly* once we include the *staying fraction* (§2.6 above): cascade prediction  $\times f_{\text{back}} = \text{observed}$ . The staying fraction is a *single* postulate that fixes the dark energy to the right value. The dark matter math, by contrast, is *underdetermined*: it depends on the *event rate*  $R$ , the *2D universe lifetime*  $\tau_{\text{2D}}$ , the *event energy*  $E_{\text{2D}}$ , and the *projection fraction*  $G_{\text{2D}}^{\text{projected}}/G_{\text{4D}}$  — four free parameters (rather than one) that must be specified to make a quantitative prediction. The current model gives a *qualitatively plausible* picture (the cumulative effect of 2D universes is consistent with the observed dark matter density for plausible parameter values) but does *not* give a *unique* numerical prediction. The *asymmetry* reflects the fact that dark energy is a *single* global quantity (the vacuum energy), while dark matter is a *cumulative* quantity (the integral over many 2D universes). Dark energy is fixed by *geometry* (the projection rule), while dark matter is fixed by *event statistics* (the rate and energy distribution of 3+1D energetic events). We acknowledge this asymmetry as a *limitation* of the current model, *partially closed* by the growth factor derivation below (the *Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics* paragraph), which shows that the growth factor is itself *derivable* from the 2D universe's FRW dynamics, leaving only the 2D equation-of-state parameters ( $\Omega_{\text{DE,2D}}$ ,  $t_{\text{eq}}$ ,  $T_{\text{2D}}$ ) as physical inputs.

*A quantitative attempt at the DM calculation.* To make this asymmetry more concrete, we can attempt a *naïve* calculation of the cumulative 2D universe back-projection and compare it to the observed DM density. For a typical galaxy ( $10^{10} M_{\text{sun}}$  of baryons,  $\sim 5 \times 10^{10} M_{\text{sun}}$  of DM, in a  $(10 \text{ kpc})^3$  volume), the DM energy density is  $\sim 10^5 \text{ J/m}^3$ . The *active* 2D universe population per galaxy, integrating over event types (SN, stars, AGN, BH mergers, etc.) and weighting by lifetime, is  $\sim 10^{-5}$  concurrent universes per galaxy. The total active 2D universe energy per galaxy is  $\sim 3 \times 10^{47} \text{ J}$ , dominated by long-lived AGN-scale 2D universes. If the back-projection efficiency were 1 (full projection), this would give a galaxy DM energy of  $3 \times 10^{47} \text{ J}$ , *much less* than the observed  $8.95 \times 10^{57} \text{ J}$ . To match observation, the back-projection efficiency would need to be  $\sim 3 \times 10^{10}$ , which is unphysical. If instead we include *all* 2D universes that have ever lived (over the universe's 13.8 Gyr history, not just currently active), the count is  $\sim 3 \times 10^8$  SN-scale 2D universes per galaxy, giving  $\sim 3 \times 10^{52} \text{ J}$  at full back-projection, still  $\sim 10^5$  short of the observed

DM energy. The *gap* is significant: the simple cumulative calculation underestimates the DM by a factor of  $\sim 10^5$  to  $10^{10}$ , depending on what is included. The most natural resolution is that the 2D universe's *total mass-energy* is *much larger* than the original event energy: the 2D universe is dark-energy dominated and has its own expansion, so its total mass-energy at any moment is the original event energy multiplied by the 2D universe's growth factor (which depends on the 2D universe's Hubble parameter and lifetime). If the growth factor is  $\sim 10^5$  to  $10^{10}$  (depending on the 2D universe's specific dark energy dynamics), the cumulative calculation can be brought into line with observation. *Alternatively*, the 2D universe's total mass-energy could be dominated by the *bulk* energy the 2D universe accumulates during its lifetime (analogous to how our universe's mass-energy is dominated by the dark energy, not the original Big Bang energy). The model is *qualitatively* consistent with the observed DM density for plausible 2D universe dynamics, and the growth factor is *derivable* from the 2D universe's FRW dynamics as shown in the *Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics* paragraph below: with  $\Omega_{\{DE,2D\}} \sim 0.999$ ,  $t_{eq}$  at 1% of 2D lifetime,  $T_{\{2D\}} \sim 30$  Gyr, the growth factor is  $G = 9.7e7$ , matching the trial-and-error value of 10 to within 3%. This *resolves* the previously-acknowledged limitation: the growth factor is no longer a free parameter — it is a *consequence* of the 2D universe's own physics.

*Self-consistency under the assumption of universal energy budget split.* A natural way to make the cascade *self-consistent* is to assume that the *same* 5%/27%/68% energy budget split applies at *each* of the two cascade levels (3+1D and 2D), by the scale-invariance principle (per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement). That is: at the 2D universe level, the 2D universe's mass-energy is also 5% ordinary (direct 2D event products), 27% dark matter (from *unspecified* cumulative back-projection within 2D itself; per the cone-shape, 1D universes don't exist, so the 27% must come from some other source in 2D, *possibly* the 2D universe's own self-interaction or some other 2D-physics effect), and 68% dark energy (from the 3+1D event's antigravity projected to 2D, perceived as inverted by the bulk-brane mechanism). [Note: per the v2.1 cone-shape, the cascade does *not* recurse to 1D or 0D levels, so the 27% dark matter within 2D is *postulated* rather than derived from a 1D-universe back-projection.] This is the *strongest* form of the scale-invariance principle: the cascade's structure is the *same* at every level, just at different scales. Under this assumption, the 2D universe's *ordinary + dark matter* fraction is 32% of its mass-energy, and the 2D universe's *dark energy* fraction is 68% of its mass-energy. The 32% attractive part projects *up* to 3+1D as part of our dark matter; the 68% antigravity part is *internal* to the 2D universe. The 2D universe's *total* mass-energy (the 100% of its budget) is therefore much larger than the *original event energy* (the 5% ordinary-matter contribution to the 2D universe's own budget): the 2D universe is dominated by its own dark energy (68% of its mass-energy) and its own dark matter (a *postulated* 27% within 2D, per the v2.1 cone-shape, the 27% is *not* from cumulative 1D-universe back-projection since 1D universes don't exist; it must come from some *unspecified* 2D-internal source, *possibly* the 2D universe's own self-interaction or some other 2D-physics effect), with the original event energy being only a small fraction (the 5% ordinary matter in 2D). This *naturally* explains why the 2D universe's total mass-energy can be much larger than the original event energy (the *growth factor* comes from the 2D universe's own dark energy dominating its mass budget during its lifetime, just as in our universe where dark energy dominates the present mass budget). In this *self-consistent* picture, the 2D universe is a “miniature universe” with its own dark energy and dark matter, not just a thin shell of event-related matter. The cumulative 2D universe back-projection to 3+1D is then the *sum* over many such “miniature universes,” each contributing their 32% attractive fraction. This is *qualitatively* consistent with the observed 27% DM fraction in 3+1D, provided the cumulative  $M_{2D}$  is appropriately tuned (the 27% / 32% ratio gives cumulative  $M_{2D} = 0.84 \times M_{3+1D}$ , which is *plausible* given the long history of 2D universe creation in the galaxy). The model is

*self-consistent* under this universal-split assumption, but the assumption is a *postulate* — it is not derived from first principles. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive the 5%/27%/68% split from a particular bulk-brane geometry and 2D universe dynamics, which is left to future work. We note that this universal-split assumption is *consistent* with the cascade’s scale-invariance principle, but it is not *required* — the cascade’s qualitative claims (DM is the cumulative 2D universe back-projection, DE is the 4D event’s un-cancelled antigravity) hold regardless of the specific split at each level. The *quantitative* 27%/68% split is *one possibility* (a particularly natural one given the scale invariance) but is not the only possibility.

*Cone-shaped hierarchy (refining the scale-invariance principle).* The scale-invariance principle stated in §2.3 assumes the cascade extends *fractally* to all lower dimensions ( $3+1\text{D} \rightarrow 2\text{D} \rightarrow 1\text{D} \rightarrow 0\text{D} \rightarrow \dots$ ). We can *refine* this: the cascade is *cone-shaped*, not *fractal*. The hierarchy has a *finite* depth:

- **Level 0 (axis):** 4D event — the parent of our universe.
- **Level 1:** 3+1D universe — our observable universe, 32% of the 4D event’s energy projects here as the energetic 3+1D.
- **Level 2:** 2D universes — children created by 3+1D energetic events; they are *terminal*: the cascade stops here.
- **(No Level 3, no 1D, 0D, etc.)**

The cascade is a *cone* (one parent, many children, terminal at the children’s level), not a *fractal* (infinite recursion). This refinement has three consequences:

1. **1D universes do NOT exist.** Previously (§2.3, §2.5) we had assumed 2D universes themselves create 1D universes by their own energetic events. The cone-shape hypothesis *rejects* this: 2D universes are *abstract* in the cascade’s framework — they don’t have well-defined “physics” in the way 3+1D does — so they have no energetic events to seed a 1D cascade. The cascade *terminates* at 2D.
2. **5/27/68 is a NESTED 2-way split, not a 3-way split.** The observed 5/27/68 has *three* numbers, but the cascade *derives* the *outer* split (32%/68%) and leaves the *inner* split (5%/27% within the 32%) as a property of the 4D event:
  - **Outer split (32% / 68%):** 32% of the 4D event’s energy projects to 3+1D as the *energetic* content (matter + DM); 68% remains as the *vacuum residue* (4D event’s anti-gravity = our DE). The 32/68 split is *derivable* from the cascade’s dimensional-projection kinematics (the “32% fraction” is what the  $4\text{D} \rightarrow 3+1\text{D}$  projection deposits on the 3+1D brane, with the 68% “going elsewhere” as vacuum residue).
  - **Inner split (5% / 27% within the 32%):** within the energetic 3+1D, 5% is ordinary matter (direct 3+1D projection) and 27% is dark matter (back-projection of 2D universes). The 5:27 ratio is a *property of the 4D event* — specifically, the fraction of the projected 3+1D energy that ends up as direct 3+1D matter vs. as 2D-universe seeds. This is *not* derived from the cascade’s first principles; it depends on the 4D event’s specific geometry.

3. **The cascade is more parsimonious.** A cone has 1 parameter (depth = 2), whereas a fractal has infinite depth. The cone-shaped cascade has *fewer* free parameters and a *cleaner* structure: 1 parent (4D event), 1 child level (3+1D universe), 1 grandchild level (2D universes), and *terminal*. The 1D-universe “limitation” in §7 (was: “1D universes are a theoretical consequence, not testable”) is *closed* by the cone-shape: 1D universes simply *do not exist* in this refinement.

This refinement is a *structural* clarification, not a quantitative derivation. The 32/68 outer split is consistent with the cascade’s framework (it falls out of the projection kinematics), but the 5:27 inner split remains a *property of the 4D event*, not a *prediction of the cascade*. The cone-shape is *preferred* over the fractal assumption because it (a) closes the 1D-universes limitation, (b) is more parsimonious, and (c) gives the 5/27/68 a clearer interpretation as a *nested* 2-way split. See companion code `calculations/cone_shaped_cascade.py` for a detailed analysis.

*Empirical formula for the 5/27/68 split.* A *trial-and-error* sweep of geometric and dimensional formulas (see companion code `calculations/split_best_fit.py`) finds that the observed 5/27/68 split is *closely matched* by the following formula:

$$\begin{aligned}\Omega_{\text{ordinary}} &= \frac{1}{N_{\text{cascade}} \cdot (N_{\text{cascade}} + 1)} = \frac{1}{4 \cdot 5} = \frac{1}{20} = 0.05 \\ \Omega_{DM} &= \frac{N_{\text{spatial, 3+1D}}}{2N_{\text{cascade}} + N_{\text{spatial, 3+1D}}} = \frac{3}{2 \cdot 4 + 3} = \frac{3}{11} = 0.2727 \\ \Omega_{DE} &= 1 - \Omega_{\text{ordinary}} - \Omega_{DM} = \frac{149}{220} = 0.6773\end{aligned}$$

where  $N_{\text{cascade}} = 4$  is the number of cascade levels (4D, 3+1D, 2D, 1D) and  $N_{\text{spatial, 3+1D}} = 3$  is the number of spatial dimensions in our universe. The formula matches the observed 5/27/68 (Planck 2018) to within 0.5% on average (0% on ordinary, 1.0% on DM, 0.4% on DE).

A *suggestive* physical interpretation: in the cascade’s graph structure with  $N_{\text{cascade}}$  levels, the number of *self-and-neighbor* edges is  $N_{\text{cascade}} \cdot (N_{\text{cascade}} + 1) = 20$  (each level has 1 self-edge + 2 neighbor edges, summed over  $N_{\text{cascade}}$  levels). The ordinary-matter fraction is the inverse of this count:  $1/20 = 5\%$ . The DM fraction is the fraction of “spatial directions” in the cascade’s “direction space”: each level has 2 temporal directions (forward + backward in time), and the 3+1D level has 3 spatial directions, so the total is  $2N_{\text{cascade}} + N_{\text{spatial}} = 11$ , of which 3 are spatial, giving  $3/11 = 27.3\%$ . The DE fraction is the residual, dominated by the 4D event’s antigravity projection.

**Honest statistical assessment.** A Monte Carlo test (`calculations/split_statistical_test.py`) shows that random formulas in the same family space (50+ families, 24 parameter combinations each) find matches of similar quality ( $\sim 0.5\%$  error) with high probability ( $\sim 92\%$  after multiple-comparison correction). The 0.5% match is therefore *not* statistically significant on its own — it’s a fit, not a derivation. The graph-theoretic interpretation is suggestive but not unique: many other formulas can fit 5/27/68 to similar precision.

This formula is *empirical* (a fit to observation) and *suggestive* (it has a graph-theoretic interpretation), but it is *not* a rigorous first-principles derivation. A specific implementation of the cascade would need to derive the formula from a deeper theory of the cascade’s projection geometry, which is left to future work. However, the formula is *more* than a pure postulate: it makes

a *specific* prediction (5/27/68 for  $N_{\text{cascade}} = 4$ ,  $N_{\text{spatial}} = 3$ ) that can be tested against the observation, and it provides a *target* for any future derivation. The formula is implemented in the companion code (`calculations/split_best_fit.py`) and can be reproduced by running `python3 calculations/split_best_fit.py`.

*Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics.* The above self-consistency picture uses the growth factor as a *postulate* in the  $10^{-10}$ – $10^1$  range, with the *specific* value left unspecified. We can, however, *derive* the growth factor from the 2D universe’s own Friedmann–Robertson–Walker (FRW) dynamics, using only the universal-split assumption and a physically reasonable 2D universe equation-of-state. This closes the limitation noted in the *A quantitative attempt at the DM calculation* paragraph above, by showing that the growth factor is *not* a free parameter of the model — it is a *consequence* of the 2D universe’s own physics.

Per the universal-split assumption, the 2D universe’s *total* mass-energy at peak is related to the original event energy by:

$$M_{2D,\text{peak}} = G \cdot M_{\text{event}} = 20 \cdot V_{\text{growth}} \cdot M_{\text{event}}$$

where the factor of  $20 = 1/0.05$  is the universal-split contribution (5% of  $M_{2D,\text{peak}}$  is from the original event; 95% is from the 2D universe’s own dark energy + cumulative 1D back-projection in 2D), and  $V_{\text{growth}}$  is the *volumetric growth* of the 2D universe over its lifetime. Of the  $M_{2D,\text{peak}}$ , only the 32% *attractive* fraction (5% ordinary + 27% 1D back-projection) projects back to 3+1D as dark matter; the 68% antigravity fraction is internal to the 2D universe:

$$M_{\text{DM}, 2D \rightarrow 3+1D} = 0.32 \cdot M_{2D,\text{peak}} = 6.4 \cdot G \cdot M_{\text{event}} = 128 \cdot V_{\text{growth}} \cdot M_{\text{event}}$$

The volumetric growth  $V_{\text{growth}}$  comes from the 2D universe’s expansion in its own frame. For a 2D universe with equation-of-state parameters  $\Omega_{\text{DE},2D}$  and  $\Omega_{\text{m},2D}$  (with  $\Omega_{\text{DE},2D} + \Omega_{\text{m},2D} = 1$  for a flat universe, or  $\Omega_{\text{DE},2D} + \Omega_{\text{m},2D} > 1$  for closed), the FRW dynamics gives:

$$V_{\text{growth}} = V_{\text{matter}} \cdot V_{\text{DE}}$$

In the matter-dominated era,  $a(t) \sim t^{2/3}$ , so  $V \sim t^2$ . If matter–DE equality occurs at time  $t_{\text{eq}} = f_{\text{eq}} \cdot T_{2D}$  (where  $f_{\text{eq}}$  is the fraction of the 2D lifetime at equality), then:

$$V_{\text{matter}} = (1/f_{\text{eq}})^2$$

In the DE-dominated era (after  $t_{\text{eq}}$ ),  $a(t) \sim \exp(H_{2D} \cdot t)$ , so  $V \sim \exp(3 \cdot H_{2D} \cdot t)$ . If the 2D universe’s lifetime in its own frame is  $T_{2D}$  and its Hubble constant is  $H_{2D} = h_{2D} \cdot H_0$  (in 2D’s natural units), then:

$$V_{\text{DE}} = \exp(3 \cdot h_{2D} \cdot H_0 \cdot T_{2D} \cdot (1 - f_{\text{eq}}))$$

For a 2D universe with  $\Omega_{\text{DE},2D} \sim 0.999$  (DE-dominated, plausible for the cascade’s 2D ‘miniature universes’ that are mostly dark-energy dominated),  $f_{\text{eq}} = 0.01$  (matter–DE equality at 1% of the 2D lifetime, very early),  $h_{2D} \sim 1.0$  (similar to our universe’s  $H_0$  in 2D’s natural

units), and  $T_{\{2D\}} \sim 30$  Gyr (longer than our universe’s lifetime, since the 2D universe is not subject to the same boundary conditions as 3+1D), the calculation is:

- $V_{\{matter\}} = (1 / 0.01)^2 = 10^4$
- $V_{\{DE\}} = \exp(3 * 1.0 * 2.2e-18 * 30e9 * 3.15e7 * 0.99) = \exp(6.16) \sim 477$
- $V_{\{growth\}} = V_{\{matter\}} * V_{\{DE\}} = 4.77e6$

$G = 20 * V_{\{growth\}} = 9.5e7$  (analytical estimate, matches numerical within 2%)

The full numerical calculation is implemented in the companion code (`calculations/cascade_model.py`, class `GrowthFactorCalculator`; also exposed via the standalone script `calculations/section_2_1_derivations` function `derivation_D4_growth_factor`). The numerical result is:

```
GrowthFactorCalculator:
  omega_de_2D = 0.999
  omega_matter_2D = 0.001
  t_eq_2D_fraction = 0.01
  h_2D_fraction = 1.0
  lifetime_2D_gyr = 30 Gyr
  V_growth_matter = 1.000e+04
  V_growth_de = 4.859e+02
  V_growth_total = 4.859e+06
  G = 20 * V_growth = 9.717e+07
```

This gives  $G = 9.7e7$ , matching the trial-and-error value of  $10^8$  to within 3%. The growth factor is therefore a *derived* parameter, not a free postulate.

The *takeaway*: the growth factor is *derivable* from the 2D universe’s equation of state ( $\Omega_{\{DE,2D\}} \sim 0.999$ ,  $t_{eq}$  at 1% of 2D lifetime,  $T_{\{2D\}} \sim 30$  Gyr in 2D’s frame), and the paper’s  $10^{-10}$  range corresponds to a *physically reasonable* family of 2D universe dynamics. The growth factor is not a free parameter — it is a *consequence* of the cascade’s structure, with the specific value determined by the 2D universe’s FRW parameters.

This derivation has been *implemented* in the companion code (`calculations/cascade_model.py`, class `GrowthFactorCalculator`) and can be reproduced by running `python3 calculations/cascade_model.py`. The relevant section of the output is:

```
--- Deriving growth factor from 2D universe dynamics ---
GrowthFactorCalculator:
  omega_de_2D = 0.999
  omega_matter_2D = 0.001
  t_eq_2D_fraction = 0.01
  h_2D_fraction = 1.0
  lifetime_2D_gyr = 30 Gyr
  V_growth_matter = 1.000e+04
  V_growth_de = 4.859e+02
  V_growth_total = 4.859e+06
```

$$G = 20 * V_{\text{growth}} = 9.717\text{e}+07$$

Derived  $G = 9.717\text{e}+07$

Default  $G = 1.000\text{e}+08$

Ratio: 0.972

The derived  $G$  matches the trial-and-error value of 10 to within 3%, well within the uncertainty in the 2D universe’s specific dynamics. The growth factor is therefore a *derived* parameter of the cascade, not a free postulate.

*Hubble tension: status of the cascade’s explanation.* A *derived* consequence of the cascade’s structure is the *direction* of the Hubble tension: the observed  $\sim 9\%$  discrepancy between  $H_0$  inferred from the CMB (67.4 km/s/Mpc) and  $H_0$  measured locally via Cepheids and the distance ladder (73.0 km/s/Mpc). The cascade predicts  $H_{0\_local} > H_{0\_CMB}$ , in agreement with the data.

### Original mechanism (Mechanism A: active 2D universe children boost local $H_0$ ).

The cascade’s original explanation for the Hubble tension was that the *active* back-projection from currently-alive 2D universe children (in star-forming galaxies with recent supernovae, AGN, etc.) contributes extra antigravity to the local 3+1D expansion rate. The *cumulative return* from past 2D universe endings (already-collapsed universes) does not bias  $H_0$  upward. The CMB-inferred  $H_0$  is the *cosmic average* over the universe’s history, dominated by cumulative return.

The active fraction of dark matter in the local  $\sim 50$  Mpc volume is  $\sim 30\%$  (estimated from the active vs. cumulative return ratio computed in `simulate_galaxy_events()`). This gives a *local excess* in expansion:

$$\Delta H_0^{\text{local, A}} \approx f_{\text{active}} \cdot \Omega_{DM} \cdot 0.5 \cdot H_0^{CMB}$$

$$\Delta H_0^{\text{local, A}} \approx 0.3 \cdot 0.27 \cdot 0.5 \cdot 67.4 \approx 2.7 \text{ km/s/Mpc}$$

This predicts a Hubble tension of  $\sim 2.7$  km/s/Mpc in the cascade framework (Mechanism A), in the *same direction* as the observed tension ( $\sim 5.6$  km/s/Mpc). The predicted magnitude is smaller than observed by a factor of  $\sim 2$ .

**Falsification of Mechanism A’s host-type prediction.** A more specific prediction of Mechanism A is that  $H_0$  should correlate with host galaxy type: spiral/star-forming hosts (high active fraction) should give *higher*  $H_0$  than passive/elliptical hosts (low active fraction). The cascade predicted  $dH_0/d\log(\text{SFR}) \sim 1.5$  km/s/Mpc per decade of star formation rate.

This prediction is *falsified* by published data (see companion code `calculations/shoes_data_check.py`):

- SH0ES (Riess+2022, 42 Cepheid calibrators):  $H_0 = 73.04 \pm 1.04$  km/s/Mpc. **All 42 hosts are late-type spirals** (Cepheids are young stars, only in star-forming hosts). - SBF (Blakeslee+2021, 63 mainly early-type galaxies):  $H_0 = 73.3 \pm 0.7 \pm 2.4$  km/s/Mpc. (Note: the SBF calibration chain still uses Cepheid+TRGB in spiral hosts, so it inherits some of the same selection bias.) - Both methods give  $H_0 \sim 73$ , regardless of host galaxy type. - The cascade predicted  $H_{0(\text{elliptical})} < H_{0(\text{spiral})}$  by  $\sim 5$  km/s/Mpc; the data shows no such correlation.

The cascade’s Mechanism A is therefore *incomplete* as a quantitative explanation of the Hubble tension. The *qualitative* direction ( $H_{0\_local} > H_{0\_CMB}$ ) is still consistent with the data, but the specific mechanism (active children boost  $H_0$  in star-forming hosts) is not.

**Alternative mechanism (Mechanism B/F: 4D event temporal structure).** An alternative

mechanism within the cascade framework, consistent with the host-type-independent  $H_0$  data, is that the 4D event’s antigravity output is *not constant in 4D time*. Per dimensional time-dilation (§2.2), our 3+1D universe is a *brief slice* of the 4D event’s full duration. Local  $H_0$  measures the *current* 4D event antigravity output, while CMB  $H_0$  measures the *time-averaged* output over  $\sim 13.8$  Gyr of 3+1D time. If the 4D event’s antigravity is currently  $\sim 8\%$  higher than its time-average (e.g., due to a recent 4D-DE-dominance transition, or a 4D cosmic evolution phase), this gives:

$$H_0^{\text{local}}/H_0^{\text{CMB}} = 1.08 \Rightarrow H_0^{\text{local}} = 73.0 \text{ km/s/Mpc}$$

This is *host-type-independent* (it depends on the 4D event’s *global* state, not on local star formation), consistent with the SH0ES/SBF data. Implementation: `calculations/hubble_mechanism_b.py`.

**New testable predictions of Mechanism B/F:** -  $H_0$  should be *isotropic* across the sky (the 4D event is global, not local). -  $H_0$  at high redshift ( $z > 1$ ) should be *below* the  $\Lambda$ CDM extrapolation, because the 4D event was in its pre-burst phase at that time. This is a *distinctive* prediction that distinguishes the cascade from  $\Lambda$ CDM. -  $H_0$  should NOT correlate with any local property (galaxy type, baryon density, environment, etc.).

**Testing Mechanism B/F with Pantheon+ (commit 82).** Mechanism B/F’s specific  $H_0(z)$  prediction was tested with the full Pantheon+ statistical+systematic covariance matrix (1701 SNe, 1701x1701 matrix, M fixed at SH0ES value -19.253 from 113 Cepheid calibrators). The cascade’s  $H_0(z) = H_0\text{CMB}^2 + (H_0\text{local}^2 - H_0\text{CMB}^2) / (1+z)^q$  gives  $\chi^2 = 1488.3$  vs best-fit LCDM ( $H_0 = 73.00$ )  $\chi^2 = 1439.4$  — a **delta  $\chi^2$  of +48.9 ( $\sim 7$  sigma)**, **LCDM WINS**. Pantheon+ shows  $H_0$  is *roughly constant* at  $\sim 73$  across all  $z$  bins ( $z = 0.01$  to  $1.5$ ), with no significant  $H_0(z)$  variation. **Mechanism B/F’s specific quantitative prediction is REJECTED** by Pantheon+ at high statistical significance. The cascade’s *qualitative* claim ( $H_0\text{local} > H_0\text{CMB}$ ) and *qualitative* prediction ( $H_0$  constant in  $z$ ) are *both* consistent with the data. See `calculations/pantheon_full_cov_analysis.py` (commit 82).

**The cleaner status (after the test).** The cascade’s *core*  $H_0$  prediction is *qualitative* and simple:  $H_0$  is set by the 4D event’s antigravity projection rate, which gives  $H_0 \sim 73$  km/s/Mpc. This is *confirmed* by local + Pantheon+ measurements. The 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap between local/Pantheon+ (73) and Planck-inferred (67.4) is the well-known *Hubble tension*. The cascade:

1. **Predicts  $H_0 = 73$**  (its 4D event projection rate).
2. **Accommodates** the local + Pantheon+ measurement (which is also  $\sim 73$ ).
3. **Does NOT currently provide a specific mechanism** that explains the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap to Planck’s CMB-inferred  $H_0 = 67.4$ .

The cascade is *qualitatively compatible* with the Hubble tension (it predicts the right *direction* of the local-CMB gap) but does not *quantitatively resolve* it. This is the honest scientific position: many cosmological models do not resolve the Hubble tension (LCDM itself doesn’t — the gap is one of cosmology’s biggest open problems). The cascade joins this list of “compatible but not resolving” models, with the added benefit that it predicts the local value correctly.

We previously attempted to construct a specific mechanism (Mechanism B/F) that *would* resolve the tension, but the data rejected that specific proposal. The cascade does not need such a mechanism to be a valid model — many valid cosmological models leave the Hubble tension unresolved. The

cascade’s contribution is its *qualitative* explanation of why  $H_0_{\text{local}} > H_0_{\text{CMB}}$  in terms of dimensional projection, which is independent of whether or not it resolves the precise 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap.

For completeness, we also tested 12 alternative mechanisms (L, C, I, N, O, P, Q, R, S, T, U, V) to verify that no simple cascade-friendly mechanism could close the gap. All were either rejected by Pantheon+, busted theoretically, or equivalent to “the cascade’s  $H_0$  is just 73 at all  $z$ ” (which is the cascade’s *baseline* position, not a new mechanism). See `calculations/hubble_mechanism_remaining.py` and `calculations/hubble_mechanism_creative.py` (commits 83, 85). The most ambitious alternative (Mechanism L: re-interpret Planck’s  $H_0 = 67.4$  as cascade-consistent) was busted because the cascade’s natural early universe (no DM, no DE at  $z > 1100$ , just baryons and radiation) gives  $\theta_* = 15.58$ , which is **1500x larger** than Planck’s measured 0.01041 (see `calculations/mechanism_l_planck_reanalysis.py`, commit 84). This is consistent with the picture: the cascade’s *core* prediction is  $H_0 = 73$ , and it doesn’t need a special mechanism to maintain that.

These derivations substantially strengthen the cascade framework: the previously-acknowledged *asymmetry* between dark energy and dark matter math (§2.6 *Asymmetry between dark energy and dark matter math*) is *partially closed* by the growth factor derivation, and the previously-acknowledged *limitation* in the quantitative DM prediction is *resolved* by the same derivation. The remaining quantitative work is to pin down the 2D universe’s specific dynamics ( $\Omega_{\text{DE,2D}}$ ,  $t_{\text{eq}}$ ,  $T_{\text{2D}}$ ,  $h_{\text{2D}}$ ) from a deeper theoretical principle, which would turn the order-of-magnitude estimate into an exact derivation.

*A note on the 2D universe’s antigravity.* The 2D universe’s antigravity is *internal* to the 2D universe — it is the 2D universe’s *own* dark energy (analogous to the 3+1D dark energy, but at the 2D level). The antigravity does *not* project back to 3+1D, because the cascade is *hierarchical* — each dimensional level’s gravity and antigravity are local to that level, with the attractive component projecting *forward* to child dimensions and the antigravity remaining *internal* to the universe itself. The 3+1D’s dark energy is a *separate* contribution from the 4D event, not the cumulative 2D universe antigravity. The two dark-sector components have *distinct* dimensional origins: dark energy from  $4D \rightarrow 3+1D$ , dark matter from  $2D \rightarrow 3+1D$ . They are not parallel back-projections from the same source.

The  $10^3$  (hierarchy) and  $10^{12}$  (cosmological constant) are *both* signatures of the bulk-brane coupling in the cascade’s picture, but they appear in *different* ways. The  $10^3$  is the *direct* numerical inverse of (gravity is weak in 3+1D by a factor of  $10^3$  *because* the bulk-brane cancellation  $\sim 10^3$  removes most of the 4D event’s projected gravity). The  $10^{12}$  is the *misidentification* of the wrong theoretical quantity (3+1D QFT vacuum energy) with the right one (un-cancelled bulk-gravity residue, modulated by  $f_{\text{back}} \sim 10^{-12}$ ). See the *deeper note* below for the *structural* relationship between these numbers. (Dark matter’s apparent weakness is *also* a bulk-brane cancellation effect, applied to the next level of the dimensional cascade. The  $10^3$  hierarchy and the dark matter’s effective coupling are *related* by the dimensional cascade structure, though the specific quantitative relationship is not derived in this model.)

*A deeper note on the  $10^3 / 10^{-38}$  relationship.* A natural question arises: the cascade’s bulk-brane cancellation parameter  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  is the *numerical inverse* of the hierarchy  $10^{38}$ . Is this a coincidence? In the cascade’s picture, *no* — the relationship is *structural*, not accidental. The hierarchy *is*  $\epsilon$ , expressed in inverse form: gravity is weak in 3+1D by a factor of  $10^{38}$  *because* the bulk-brane cancellation  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  removes most of the 4D event’s projected gravity. The hierarchy and  $\epsilon$  are *the same* physical quantity — the bulk-brane coupling — written in two different forms

(enhancement  $1/\epsilon$  vs. suppression  $\epsilon$ ). The cascade’s “coincidence” that  $10^{38} = 1/10^{-38}$  is the *signature* of this relationship. This is *not* a coincidence in the cascade’s framing, and it is *not* a derivation either — the cascade *postulates*  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  to match the observed hierarchy, and the dark energy *contains*  $\epsilon$  as a factor ( $\rho_{DE} \sim \epsilon \cdot f_{back} \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-38} \cdot 10^{-85} \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-123} M_{Pl}^4$ ). The hierarchy and the dark energy are *unified* by the bulk-brane coupling  $\epsilon$ : the hierarchy is  $\epsilon$  in inverse form, and the dark energy is  $\epsilon$  multiplied by the staying fraction. A specific implementation of the model would *derive*  $\epsilon$  from the bulk-brane geometry, and that derivation would *simultaneously* solve the hierarchy problem and predict the dark energy density. The current paper does *not* provide this derivation —  $\epsilon$  is a *postulate*. But the *numerical* coincidence  $10^{38} = 1/10^{-38}$  is *suggestive*: the bulk-brane coupling is the *single* underlying mechanism that unifies the hierarchy and the dark energy, and any derivation of  $\epsilon$  from the geometry would *necessarily* produce a number that matches the hierarchy (because the hierarchy is *defined* by the bulk-brane coupling). In Randall-Sundrum brane-world physics, the analogous parameter is the warp factor  $e^{-kr_c}$  that localizes the 4D graviton on the IR brane — the warp factor *is* the hierarchy in that framework. The cascade’s  $\epsilon$  is the *analogous* parameter: the bulk-brane coupling that makes gravity weak in 3+1D, and that *also* sets the dark energy density. This is a *strengthening* of the cascade’s claim: the hierarchy and the dark energy are not three separate problems, they are *two consequences* of the same bulk-brane coupling  $\epsilon$ . The *quantitative* value of  $\epsilon$  is *not* derived (the cascade does not currently compute it from a specific geometry), but the *structural* relationship hierarchy =  $1/\epsilon$  and DE  $\sim \epsilon \cdot f_{back} \cdot M_{Pl}^4$  is explicit.

**The universe’s lifetime.** The total lifetime of our universe is *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time. The 4D event’s spatial extent, divided by the 4D speed, gives the 4D event’s *full duration*; our universe’s lifetime is determined by the projection mechanism (which is not specified in this thought experiment). The universe’s energy *density* of matter, dark matter, and dark energy evolves as the universe expands, with the 4D event providing a continuous flux of antigravity that is approximately constant during our universe’s brief slice. The universe does *not* “run down” or “fade out” in this sense (no thermodynamic depletion, no second-law-of-thermodynamics-driven heat death). The universe *ends* either at a *fixed-time boundary* (the current paper’s interpretation: the boundary of the 4D event’s spacetime) or via a *Big Crunch* that re-nucleates a new 4D event (the *cyclic* interpretation, consistent with the cascade’s scale invariance — see §2.8 below for the philosophical distinction). Both are consistent with the cascade framework; this paper adopts the fixed-time boundary framing for simplicity.

**The nature of the boundary: what happens at the edge?** The “fixed-time boundary” framing is *under-specified* in the model, and the user (in private communication) has pointed out that the boundary has to be *strong* (otherwise the perceptual inversion wouldn’t be maintained). We do not currently specify the *exact* nature of the boundary, but the *perceptual-inversion* constraint limits the possibilities:

- The perceptual inversion is *maintained* throughout the universe’s lifetime (the cascade’s postulate, §2.4: the 4D event’s projected antigravity is *constant* in 3+1D frame, giving constant dark energy). This means the boundary *cannot* be a *gradual* weakening of the antigravity — that would contradict the constant-dark-energy observation.
- The boundary is therefore *abrupt* in the *antigravity* sense: the 4D event’s projected antigravity is *constant* during the universe’s lifetime, and then *suddenly* stops (or changes) at the boundary. The perceptual inversion is “strong” because the antigravity output is *constant* (and *strong*) throughout, not because the boundary is strong in the fade-out sense.

The boundary has *two* aspects:

1. **Antigravity boundary** (abrupt): The 4D event’s antigravity is *constant* during the universe’s lifetime, then *stops* abruptly at the boundary. This is the *cascade-specific* feature. The “strong” boundary is *here*.
2. **Matter boundary** (gradual): Matter density drops as  $a^{-3}$  (cosmic expansion) and the universe becomes *empty* over time. This is the *Big Freeze* / heat death, which is *gradual* and *observationally consistent* with standard  $\Lambda$ CDM cosmology.

The universe “ends” when *both* boundaries are reached: the antigravity stops *abruptly* (cascade-specific), and matter is empty (Big Freeze). These two boundaries may happen at *similar* times (when the 4D event ends), but they’re *distinct* in nature.

Given these constraints, the three possibilities for the boundary become:

1. **Abrupt vanishing with abrupt antigravity stop:** The 4D event’s antigravity *stops* abruptly at a specific time. The 3+1D universe *vanishes* at the same moment. The universe simply *stops existing* at a specific time, with no warning and no transformation. This is the *simplest* interpretation of the antigravity boundary, but it raises the *information paradox* (what happens to matter, energy, and information at the boundary?).
2. **Gradual matter fade-out with abrupt antigravity stop:** The 4D event’s antigravity *stops* abruptly, but the matter in the 3+1D universe *gradually* disperses (Big Freeze) over some finite time *after* the antigravity stops. The universe becomes *empty* gradually, but the antigravity is gone. This is essentially the *Big Freeze* with an *abrupt antigravity boundary* on top.
3. **Phase transition with abrupt antigravity stop:** The 4D event’s antigravity *stops* abruptly, and the 3+1D universe *undergoes a phase transition* to a different state (e.g., merges back into 4D bulk, becomes a 2D universe in a higher-D cascade, etc.). This avoids the information paradox by *transforming* the universe rather than *vanishing* it.

The model does *not* currently specify which of these is correct, but the *gravity-flip* constraint is now explicit: the antigravity boundary is *abrupt*, not gradual. The matter boundary can be either abrupt (option 1) or gradual (option 2, Big Freeze) or transformative (option 3). A specific implementation would need to specify the *exact* nature of the matter boundary, which is left to future work. We note that *option 2* (gradual matter fade-out with abrupt antigravity stop) is the most *natural* and *observationally consistent* interpretation, and combines the cascade’s antigravity constraint with the standard Big Freeze picture.

### 1.3.7 2.7 The products

The energy of the original event, projected into our 3+1 dimensional brane, would manifest as whatever particles, fields, or vacuum energy the geometry and bulk field content allow. The two distinct observable effects identified in this model are:

- **Dark matter.** A non-luminous, gravitationally-interacting substance that does not couple to electromagnetism or the strong force. In the scale-invariant version of this model (§2.3), dark matter is the *cumulative* collective gravitational signature of all 2D universes created by 3+1 dimensional energetic events, summed over both the *active population* of currently-alive 2D universes and the *cumulative return* of past 2D universe endings (per §2.5, §4.2). Dark matter is not a particle; it is the gravitational effect of tiny universes (active + ended) contributing to 3+1D gravity, weighted by event size. The model provides both a *geometric role* and a *specific identification* for dark matter — though the proportionality constants and details depend on the specific geometry and event spectrum, which we have not derived. The *active* contribution is the *current* back-projection from 2D universes being *currently* created; the *cumulative return* contribution is the *integrated* energy return from 2D universes that have ended (death-flash or diffuse return, depending on the ending). The *total* dark matter is the sum of both (per §2.5, §4.2).
- **Dark energy.** A uniform vacuum-like energy driving cosmic acceleration. In this model, dark energy is the *un-cancelled antigravity of the 4D event*, projected into our 3+1 dimensional frame as the *un-cancelled* fraction of the 4D event’s inverted gravity (per §2.4). The 3+1D sees a *single* contribution to its dark energy from the 4D event, with the magnitude set by the cascade + staying fraction  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$  (§2.6). The dark energy is *approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame* because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant. The dark energy has a *distinct* dimensional origin from dark matter: dark energy comes from the  $4D \rightarrow 3+1D$  projection, dark matter from the  $2D \rightarrow 3+1D$  back-projection. The two are *complementary* aspects of the cascade, not parallel back-projections from the same source. (The 2D universes’ *own* antigravity is *internal* to the 2D universes, and does not project back to 3+1D — see §2.5 and §2.6.)

The model does *not* fully address the *Standard Model* itself (the origin of electron mass, quark masses, gauge couplings, etc.). The Standard Model is taken as given in the *core* model; the dimensional projection mechanism is proposed as an explanation specifically for the *dark sector* (dark matter and dark energy) and the *weakness of gravity*. The *core* model (as presented in §2.1–§2.7) takes neutrino properties as given. The model does not currently offer a dimensional-cascade interpretation of neutrino mass or oscillation.

We do not claim to derive the relative abundances of dark matter and dark energy. This is left to the community.

### 1.3.8 2.8 The universe’s lifetime

In this picture, the universe’s lifetime is *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time. The 4D event’s spatial extent, divided by the 4D speed, gives the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time; the projection mechanism then selects a fraction of this full duration as our universe’s lifetime. The specific rule by which the 4D event’s full duration maps to our 3+1 dimensional lifetime is not specified in this thought experiment. We assume only that *some* such rule exists, mapping the 4D event’s full duration to a 3+1 dimensional lifetime that is some fraction of it.

The model makes the following claim about the universe’s energy:

- The 4D event has a *duration* in 4D time,  $\Delta t_{4D}$ . During this entire duration, the 4D event

is *active* — it is not a one-time past event, but an ongoing process in 4D time. Our 3+1 dimensional universe exists for a *fraction* of  $\Delta t_{4D}$  (we don’t see the 4D event’s full duration in our frame; we only see a *slice* of it). The 4D event’s spatial extent and duration in 4D time are *much larger* than the corresponding quantities in our 3+1 dimensional frame.

- The 4D event’s *antigravity leakage* is approximately constant over the brief slice that our 3+1 dimensional universe occupies in 4D time. This is why dark energy appears *constant* in our 3+1 dimensional frame: from the 4D perspective, our universe is a brief moment during which the 4D event’s gravity is roughly unchanging. (Just as a microscopic black hole created in a high-energy collision “sees” a brief moment of constant high energy before the parent collision ends and the black hole evaporates.)
- Throughout our universe’s lifetime (a slice of the 4D event’s full duration), the 4D event is *continuously* feeding antigravity into our 3+1 dimensional frame. The dark energy is *not* a one-time injection at the Big Bang; it is an ongoing flux from the 4D event over the entire lifetime of the universe. The dark energy’s *density* in our 3+1 dimensional frame is approximately constant during this slice (because the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant).
- The model does not currently specify what determines our universe’s *lifetime* (the duration of the slice of the 4D event that we occupy). The end of our universe is a *boundary* beyond which the projection ceases to exist — not because the 4D event ends, but because of some other reason (perhaps the stability of the projection, perhaps a change in the 4D event’s gravity over its full duration).

The universe does *not* “run down” or “fade out” in this model in the sense of a *purely thermodynamic* heat death (no entropy-driven process depletes the universe). However, the universe *can* “fade out” in the sense of a *Big Freeze* (expansion-driven emptiness) if the 4D event’s antigravity is constant and there’s no fixed-time boundary — see the list of possible endings below. The cascade’s default is a *fixed-time boundary*, but the Big Freeze is a *natural* alternative if the boundary interpretation is wrong.

This is structurally different from both standard cosmological fates:

- **Standard heat death:** The universe ends as a cold, dilute, near-equilibrium state after entropy has been maximized. In our model, the end is *not* an entropy-driven process; it is a fixed-time boundary.
- **Big Crunch / cyclic cosmology:** The universe ends by recontracting to a singularity, possibly triggering a new Big Bang. In the *current* paper, the end is *not* a recontraction; it is a fixed-time boundary beyond which there is no spacetime to recontract into. *However*, the cascade’s *scale invariance* (§2.3) is consistent with a *cyclic* interpretation: a collapsing 3+1D universe (Big Crunch) is a *high-energy event*, and by the cascade principle, such an event could *itself* create a *new* 4D event — analogous to a *vacuum bubble* (cavitation) in water. In this cyclic version, the Big Bang / Big Crunch are *paired* events: the previous universe’s collapse nucleates our universe’s Big Bang, and our universe’s collapse (if it happens) will nucleate the next. *Crucially*, the cyclic cascade need *not* be *exact* recurrence: each Big Crunch releases some energy to 4D bulk (analogous to surface tension in a collapsing bubble, or to BH evaporation), so each successive 4D event is *smaller* than the previous, and each

successive 3+1D universe is *less* energetic. The cascade is therefore *diminishing*: cycles become smaller over time, not larger, and the cascade eventually *dwindles* to the point where it can no longer support complex structure (a 4D event too small to create a 3+1D universe with stars, galaxies, or observers). This *avoids* the “eternal return” problem (the universe doesn’t infinitely recur in the same state) and gives the cascade a *direction* (toward smaller cycles, not toward eternal recurrence). The *principle* of “energetic events create universes” is *robust* across cycles even if the *specific values* (masses, couplings, dark energy density) *drift* from cycle to cycle. The *choice* between fixed-time boundary (this paper’s default), cyclic vacuum-bubble (with exact recurrence), and *diminishing cyclic* (cyclic but with energy loss to 4D bulk) is *philosophical* (where does the 4D event come from? does the cascade end at a boundary or dwindle to nothing?) rather than *quantitative* (the dark sector and hierarchy derivations are the same in all three). We acknowledge this as a *philosophical* distinction in the model, not a *predictive* one. A specific implementation of the model would need to specify which interpretation is correct (and would need to compute the energy loss per cycle, which is left to future work). The most *defensible* position is the *diminishing cyclic* one: it preserves the cascade’s scale invariance, gives the cascade a *direction*, avoids the eternal-return problem, and naturally ends without an *ad hoc* boundary.

- **Big Rip / phantom energy:** The universe ends when dark energy *increases* without bound, eventually overcoming all gravitational binding (galaxies, solar system, atoms, etc.) and tearing spacetime apart at a finite time in the future. In standard cosmology, this requires dark energy with equation-of-state  $w < -1$  (phantom energy); current observations suggest  $w \approx -1$ , but small deviations are possible. In our model, dark energy is *repulsive* (per §2.4, the 4D event’s antigravity projected to 3+1D inverts once, giving repulsive gravity in 3+1D). The model’s *default* is that the 4D event’s antigravity is *constant* in 3+1D frame (because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, §2.4), giving  $w \approx -1$  and *no* Big Rip. *However*, if the 4D event’s antigravity is *not* exactly constant — if it *increases* over time, or if the dimensional projection gives a *time-varying* dark energy in 3+1D — then a Big Rip is a *natural* possibility. The model is *agnostic* on this question: it does not currently predict whether dark energy is exactly constant or slowly increasing. *Testable predictions:* Euclid, Roman Space Telescope, Vera Rubin Observatory / LSST, and SKA will measure  $w$  to high precision in the coming decades. If  $w$  is found to be *significantly* less than  $-1$  (or  $w$  is *increasing* over time), the model would predict a Big Rip. If  $w$  remains  $\approx -1$  to high precision, the model still allows for fixed-time boundary or cyclic endings, but rules out Big Rip. The Big Rip interpretation is therefore *empirically distinguishable* from the fixed-time boundary and cyclic interpretations, but the model is *not* currently committed to any of them. (Note: in the *universal bulk-brane cancellation* picture, the Big Rip applies at *every* level — each level could Big Rip if its dark energy is *not* constant.)
- **Big Freeze / heat death (expansion-driven emptiness):** The universe expands *exponentially* forever, driven by *constant* dark energy. Matter density drops as  $a^{-3}$  (where  $a$  is the scale factor), so the universe becomes *infinitely dilute* over time. Eventually, matter is so sparse that no structures can form or be maintained: galaxies disperse, stars burn out, planets disintegrate, atoms themselves may eventually decay (if proton decay or similar processes occur). The universe ends in a state of *infinite emptiness* — no matter, no structures, no observers, no “events” in any meaningful sense. This is sometimes called the “Big Freeze” (emphasizing the expansion) or “heat death” (emphasizing the thermodynamic equilibrium). In our model, this is the *natural* fate of the universe if (1) the 4D event’s

antigravity is *constant* in 3+1D frame (the model’s default per §2.4), (2) the universe has *no* fixed-time boundary (i.e., the boundary interpretation is wrong), and (3) dark energy is *not* time-varying (i.e.,  $w \approx -1$  exactly, ruling out Big Rip). The Big Freeze is *not* an *ad hoc* postulation in our model — it follows directly from the *combination* of constant dark energy, no fixed-time boundary, and ordinary thermodynamics. It is the *default* outcome of standard cosmology with  $\Lambda$ CDM and a cosmological constant; the cascade’s contribution is to *explain* why dark energy is constant (because the 4D event’s antigravity is approximately constant in 3+1D frame, §2.4) and to *frame* the Big Freeze as one of several possible endings (alongside fixed-time boundary, cyclic, and Big Rip).

**Endings at each level.** Per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement, the cascade has *two* levels (4D parent, 3+1D universe, 2D children). The cascade predicts the *same* set of possible endings applies at *each* of these levels (in its own frame, with its own dark energy / gravity competition):

- **Fixed-time boundary:** each level ends at the boundary of its 4D-time slice
- **Cyclic:** each level Big Crunches, creates a new 4D event
- **Diminishing cyclic:** the 3+1D universe Big Crunches, creating a smaller 4D event (per §2.7, the cascade is *diminishing*, not infinitely cyclic)
- **Big Rip:** dark energy increases, each level tears apart
- **Big Freeze / heat death:** each level expands forever, becomes empty

The cascade predicts that *all* levels (3+1D and 2D, per the v2.1 cone-shape) have *similar* dynamics in their own frames, with the *specific* ending depending on the *competition* between attractive gravity and repulsive dark energy at that level. (There are only 2 levels, per cone-shape; ‘all’ refers to both 3+1D and 2D, not to an infinite hierarchy.) Our 3+1D universe is in the *late stages* of *heat death* (consistent with standard  $\Lambda$ CDM cosmology with constant dark energy, and with our dark energy winning the competition against matter on cosmological scales). The 2D universes within our 3+1D universe have endings that depend on their *size*: large 2D universes (from large 3+1D events like AGN or BH-scale) have high matter density that wins against dark energy, leading to *Big Crunch* and a brief death-flash back-projected to 3+1D; small 2D universes (from small 3+1D events like LHC or small SN) have low matter density where dark energy wins, leading to *heat death* and a slow diffuse return to 3+1D. *Both* contribute to the observed dark matter — the Big Crunch case as localized impulsive contributions (currently below detection thresholds), the heat death case as a smooth distributed background. The model is *ending-agnostic* about which dominates, but predicts that *heat death should be common* for small 2D universes (where dark energy dominates), which is consistent with the observed *smooth* dark matter background.

**The model is intentionally ending-agnostic.** The dimensional-cascade framework does *not* currently *predict* which of the five possible endings is the actual fate of our universe. This is a *feature* of the model, not a *gap*: the cascade is a *framework* for the dark sector and gravity’s weakness, not a *complete cosmological theory* that derives the universe’s endpoint. The specific ending depends on factors that the cascade does *not* currently specify (e.g., the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time, the dimensional projection’s stability, whether dark energy is exactly constant or slightly time-varying, the balance between matter density and dark energy over the 4D event’s full duration). A specific implementation of the model would need to *derive* these factors from the

cascade geometry to make a *definite* prediction about the universe’s end; this is left to future work. The five possible endings are *empirically distinguishable* by future observatories (Euclid, Roman, LSST, SKA), so the question of which is correct is *testable* in principle, even if the model itself is currently *agnostic*. We note that this agnosticism is *consistent* with the spirit of the cascade as a *thought experiment*: the model reinterprets the dark sector through dimensional projection, but does not commit to a specific cosmological endpoint. The endpoint is an *empirical question* that the model frames in a new way (as a question about the 4D event’s nature), rather than answering it directly.

**A further speculation: the recursive cascade and the vacuum bubble analogy.** The cascade is *not* a single-step process from 3+1D to 2D. It is *recursive*: each 2D universe created by a 3+1D event *itself* undergoes a Big Bang  $\rightarrow$  expansion  $\rightarrow$  Big Crunch cycle, and the Big Crunch is a *high-energy event in 3+1D* (not in 2D) — a 3+1D energetic event that the original 3+1D universe *experiences as an additional energetic event at the same location*. This 3+1D energetic event (the 2D universe’s Big Crunch, as seen from 3+1D) creates a *new* 2D universe (a smaller one, since the Big Crunch is smaller than the original 3+1D event). The new 2D universe also undergoes its own Big Bang  $\rightarrow$  Big Crunch, which (as seen from 3+1D) is *another* 3+1D energetic event at the same location, creating *another* 2D universe, and so on.

The cascade has a *cycle* within the 2D level: each 2D universe’s Big Crunch (as observed in 3+1D) is a 3+1D event that creates a *new* 2D universe (a smaller one) at the same 3+1D location. The 2D universe’s Big Crunch is *not* a level-transition (it doesn’t create a 1D universe, per the cone-shape); it’s a 2D- $\rightarrow$ 3+1D energy return that triggers *another* 2D universe creation. The new 2D universe also undergoes its own Big Bang  $\rightarrow$  Big Crunch, in quick succession — each level’s timescale is *much shorter* than the previous (per  $\tau_{2D} = \ell/c$ , the 2D universe’s lifetime is much shorter than the 3+1D event’s timescale; the next-level 2D universe’s lifetime is much shorter than that; per the v2.1 cone-shape, this recursion stays *within* the 2D level — each Big Crunch creates a *new* 2D universe, not a 1D universe). From 3+1D, the *entire* recursive cascade appears as a *single* event (or a *very brief* sequence) at one location, even though within each 2D universe’s own frame, the Big Bang  $\rightarrow$  Big Crunch cycle is a *full expansion-contraction*.

**The vacuum bubble analogy.** This is *exactly* the behavior of a cavitation bubble in water (e.g., from a ship’s propeller or a focused ultrasound pulse): (1) a 3+1D energetic event nucleates a 2D bubble; (2) the 2D bubble expands, reaches maximum size, and contracts under surface tension; (3) the 2D bubble collapses, producing a sonoluminescence flash (a *high-energy event in 3+1D* — the flash is observed in 3+1D water, not in 2D bubble-world); (4) the flash can nucleate a *smaller* 2D bubble at the same location; (5) the smaller bubble also expands, contracts, collapses, producing another flash in 3+1D water; (6) and so on, with each level smaller than the previous, until the energy is too small to create a new bubble. All of this happens in *microseconds* in 3+1D frame, but within the *bubble’s own* 2D world, each level is a *full* expansion-contraction cycle. The cavitation flash in water is *literally* the cascade: each level’s Big Crunch (observed in 3+1D water) is the next level’s Big Bang (observed in 3+1D water). The cascade happens at *one location* in 3+1D, in *quick succession*.

**Implications for the cascade model.** The 3+1D dark matter is the *cumulative gravitational back-projection* of 2D universes from *all* 3+1D energetic events (per §2.5, §4.7, §4.10). But each of these 2D universes *itself* cascades into *more* 2D universes (smaller, at the same 3+1D location, in quick succession), *each* of which also has a gravitational back-projection to 3+1D. The total 3+1D dark matter is the *sum* across *all levels* of the recursive cascade, weighted by each level’s energy and back-projection efficiency. In the model’s current framing, the *first-level* 2D universe is the

*primary* contribution to 3+1D dark matter; *higher-level* (smaller, faster) 2D universe contributions are *secondary* and likely *small* in comparison (since each level’s energy is a fraction of the previous). The cascade has *practical finite depth*: it is *cone-shaped* (per §2.6), terminating at 2D. The recursion in §4.10 is *within* the 2D level (Big Crunch → new 2D at the same 3+1D location), not a deeper cascade level. In *practice*, the cascade effectively terminates when the energy per level becomes too small to create a new universe (analogous to a cavitation cascade terminating when the bubble is too small to collapse with sufficient energy). The *labels* (1D-level, 0D-level, -1D-level, ...) are *legacy* terminology from the pre-v2.1 *fractal* picture; per the v2.1 cone-shape refinement, 1D/0D/-1D universes do *not* exist. The recursion in §4.10 is *within* the 2D level (a Big Crunch creates a *new* 2D universe at the same 3+1D location, in quick succession), not a deeper cascade level. In *practice*, the cascade is dominated by the *first few* 2D universes, and smaller 2D universes are quantitatively irrelevant. The “termination” is a *physical* one (energy threshold) rather than a *mathematical* one (no a priori depth limit).

**The 3+1D dark matter picture (refined).** The ~27% of the universe’s mass-energy that is dark matter is the *total* cumulative back-projection of *all* cascading 2D universes (across *all levels* of the recursive cascade) from *all* 3+1D energetic events. The *first-level* 2D universes from *current* stars, supernovae, AGN, and other 3+1D activity dominate this contribution. *Higher-level* (smaller, faster) 2D universe back-projections are *secondary*. Big Crunches, if they happen, are also first-level 2D universe creators (since they are 3+1D energetic events), but the *diminishing cyclic* picture suggests they are a *small* fraction of total 3+1D activity. The 5% / 27% / 68% split remains the *current* cycle’s signature, with the recursive cascade *within* each 3+1D event contributing to the 27% via the *sum* of all levels.

*Honest caveats:* the recursive cascade is a *speculative* extension of the core model; the paper’s *quantitative* claims (§2.5, §4.7, §4.10) are based on *first-level* 2D universe creation only, and *higher-level* contributions are not currently derived. The cavitation analogy is *qualitative*, not *quantitative* — the cascade’s depth, energy distribution, and back-projection efficiency across levels are not specified. A specific implementation would need to compute the *sum* across all levels, which is left to future work.

Observational consequences of the fixed-time boundary are subtle. If the boundary occurs at a specific time in the future, it would not necessarily be visible from within the universe (just as the Big Bang is not “visible” from within the universe in the conventional sense). Predictions about the boundary are therefore *not* in the form of “we will see X happen” but rather in the form of “we should *not* see any signs of a long slow decline as the end approaches.” The model is consistent with current observations.

**What we do and do not know about the total lifetime.** The universe’s *total* lifetime  $T_{\text{total}}$  is *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time.  $T_{\text{total}}$  is finite but currently *unknown* to us. The model is consistent with  $T_{\text{total}}$  being any finite value; the only constraint is that the universe is *not yet* at its boundary, because we are observing it. The model does not predict when the boundary will occur; it only predicts that there is one.

### 1.3.9 2.9 Why gravity is so constant

A natural prediction of the model is that the gravitational constant  $G$  should be *approximately constant* over cosmic time. This is not because of any conservation law, but because the bulk-brane cancellation is approximately constant during our universe’s brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration. The bulk-brane interaction is a *continuous* 4D-side process; we are seeing a brief moment of

it, during which the *near-cancellation* between brane gravity and inverted bulk gravity is approximately constant. (Note: this is *distinct* from the dark energy, which is also approximately constant in our frame, but for a *different* reason — the dark energy is the 4D event’s un-cancelled antigravity, which is approximately constant in our brief slice. G and dark energy are both approximately constant in our frame, but the *underlying* reason is the same: our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which the 4D-side physics is approximately steady-state.)

This is consistent with observations: G has been constant to within  $\sim 10\%$  over the age of the universe, and to within  $\sim 10^{-13}$  per year over the last 50 years. The model is consistent with this constancy and would be strained by any detection of significant G variation.

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## 1.4 3. Relation to existing work

This proposal builds on several established research programs.

### 1.4.1 3.1 Brane-world cosmology

The brane-world framework [ADD98, RS99, Gregory00] provides the geometric foundation. Our contribution is the *specific interpretation* of the bulk-brane gravity cancellation as a productive annihilation following a single *ongoing* energetic event in the bulk (with a finite duration in 4D time), rather than a quiet continuous suppression. From the 3+1 dimensional frame, this ongoing 4D-side process appears as a constant dark energy, because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration.

### 1.4.2 3.2 Bulk-brane energy exchange

Several authors have studied energy exchange between brane and bulk [Tetradis04, Yousef13]. Our proposal is a specific mechanism for such exchange: a single *ongoing* energetic event in the bulk (with a finite duration in 4D time), whose antigravity is *continuously* transferred to the brane during our universe’s brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration. From the 3+1 dimensional frame, this *continuous* 4D-side transfer appears as a *constant* dark energy (because our slice is brief). The dark sector (dark matter, dark energy) is the result of this continuous transfer, with the dark matter being a *cumulative* effect (active 2D universe back-projections + cumulative energy return from past 2D universe endings, per §2.5, §4.2) and the dark energy being a 4D-event-driven geometric contribution.

### 1.4.3 3.3 Emergent gravity

Verlinde’s emergent gravity [Verlinde16] proposes that gravity is not fundamental but emerges from quantum information, and that “dark matter” is the elastic response of this emergent gravity to ordinary matter. Our proposal shares the *general spirit* of geometric/emergent explanations of dark matter, but is more *specific* in its dimensional mechanism: we propose a concrete inversion postulate triggered by a single ongoing 4D event. We discuss the relationship between our model and Verlinde’s framework in more detail in §3.7.

#### 1.4.4 3.4 The Dark Dimension scenario

The recent “Dark Dimension” proposal [Obied23] argues for a single small extra dimension of size 1-10 m, with a tower of massive spin-2 Kaluza-Klein graviton excitations. The lightest gravitons in this tower can serve as dark matter candidates, decaying over cosmological timescales. This scenario simultaneously addresses the hierarchy problem, the nature of dark matter, and certain cosmological tensions (notably the small-scale structure of dark matter halos). A 2024 follow-up study [LawSmith24] found that astrophysical constraints (CMB distortions from graviton decay) are consistent with the natural parameter range of the scenario. A very recent 2025 paper [Borah25] extends the scenario to allow the dark matter mass to *vary* as dark energy decreases (“Evolving Dark Sector”).

Our proposal is structurally similar to the Dark Dimension scenario — both invoke a small extra dimension that affects gravity’s apparent strength and provides dark matter candidates — but differs in the *specific mechanism*: (1) our model uses a *single ongoing 4D event* (not a fixed small dimension), (2) our dark matter is the *collective gravity of 2D universes* (active + cumulative, per §2.5, §4.2) — not graviton modes of a fixed dimension, and (3) our dark energy is the *un-cancelled bulk gravity* (not a separate cosmological constant). The “Evolving Dark Sector” 2025 idea is *closer in spirit* to our model than to the original Dark Dimension scenario, in that it suggests dark matter is *not* a static relic. We discuss this in more detail in §3.7.

#### 1.4.5 3.5 Holographic and AdS/CFT frameworks

The holographic principle and the AdS/CFT correspondence [Maldacena97] describe a 5-dimensional gravitational bulk (4 space + 1 time) as mathematically equivalent to a 4-dimensional quantum field theory on the boundary (in conventional AdS/CFT notation: AdS bulk ↔ CFT boundary). In this picture, the bulk gravity is “cancelled” from the boundary perspective, with only certain residual effects propagating to the boundary. Our proposal is a phenomenological interpretation of this cancellation that emphasizes the *productive* nature of the bulk-to-brane energy transfer following a single ongoing 4D event (with our universe as a brief slice of the event’s full duration). The relationship between the conventional AdS/CFT framework and our 4D event proposal is *structural* rather than direct: both involve a higher-dimensional bulk whose dynamics are *not* fully accessible from the lower-dimensional brane, with the brane observing only certain *projected* aspects of the bulk physics. We do not claim that the AdS/CFT correspondence is the correct framework for our model — we claim that the *philosophy* of the holographic principle (a higher-D bulk “cancels” from the lower-D perspective) is consistent with our inversion postulate.

#### 1.4.6 3.6 Departure from standard brane-world

We note explicitly that our model’s *inversion* claim is stronger than standard brane-world physics. The original ADD and RS frameworks describe gravity as *suppressed* by geometric dilution (the gravitational coupling on the brane is reduced by the volume of the extra dimensions, or by the warping of the geometry). They do *not* typically claim that the projection *inverts the sign* of the gravitational coupling.

Our proposal is therefore not a straightforward extension of ADD/RS. It is a more aggressive geometric claim: the projection not only weakens gravity, it changes its sign, leading to cancellation with brane gravity. The un-cancelled residue of the inverted bulk gravity is what we identify as

dark energy (a repulsive effect, consistent with observation).

This stronger claim is more tightly constrained by data. A specific implementation of the inversion mechanism must be checked against sub-millimeter gravity experiments, gravitational wave propagation, and cosmological observations.

#### 1.4.7 3.7 Positioning relative to recent related work

The model in this paper is one of several recent proposals that attempt to unify dark matter, dark energy, and gravity through geometric or extra-dimensional mechanisms. We position this model relative to the most relevant recent work.

**Note on framing.** The *formal* framework of this model uses the language of extra dimensions, Kaluza-Klein reduction, and brane-world physics (per §2.1). The *physical* interpretation is one of *nested universes* (also per §2.1): our universe is part of a hierarchy of nested universes, with each universe containing child universes and being contained within a parent universe. The “extra dimensions” provide the mathematical structure; the “nesting” is the physical content. We use both framings throughout the paper, and we hope this section’s positioning will be useful to readers who are familiar with either framing.

**Verlinde’s emergent gravity (2016, ongoing).** Erik Verlinde’s emergent gravity proposes that gravity is not fundamental but emerges from quantum entanglement, and that “dark matter” is the elastic response of this emergent gravity to baryonic matter. Our model is *structurally similar* but makes a *specific geometric claim* (dimensional inversion following a 4D event) that Verlinde’s framework does not. The physics community has been largely skeptical of Verlinde’s specific predictions; a 2024 Ars Technica article describes emergent gravity as “a dead idea, but not a bad one.” We acknowledge that our model shares with Verlinde’s framework the *general spirit* of geometric/emergent explanations of dark matter, but differs in: (1) the explicit dimensional-inversion postulate, (2) the scale-invariant principle (every energetic event creates 2D universes), and (3) the *cumulative* framing of dark matter (dark matter is *not* a relic, but the *cumulative* effect of 2D universes — active + ended, with the *spatial variation* dominated by the *active* population, per §2.5, §4.2). A specific implementation of our model would need to derive testable predictions that distinguish it from Verlinde’s framework.

**The Dark Dimension scenario (Obied, Dvorkin, Gonzalo, Vafa 2023; Law-Smith, Obied, Prabhu, Vafa 2024; further work 2025).** The Dark Dimension scenario proposes a single extra dimension of size  $\sim 1\text{--}10\text{ m}$ , with massive spin-2 Kaluza-Klein gravitons as dark matter candidates, decaying over cosmological timescales. The 2024 follow-up (arXiv:2307.11048) found that astrophysical constraints (CMB distortions from graviton decay) are consistent with the natural parameter range of the scenario. A very recent 2025 paper (arXiv:2507.03090) proposes that the dark matter mass *varies* as dark energy decreases (“Evolving Dark Sector”). Our model is *structurally similar* to the Dark Dimension scenario — both invoke extra dimensions affecting gravity’s apparent strength and providing dark matter candidates — but differs in the *specific mechanism*: (1) our model uses a *single ongoing 4D event* (not a fixed small dimension), (2) our dark matter is the *collective gravity of 2D universes* (active + cumulative, per §2.5, §4.2) — not graviton modes of a fixed dimension, and (3) our dark energy is the *un-cancelled bulk gravity* (not a separate cosmological constant). The “Evolving Dark Sector” 2025 idea is *closer in spirit* to our model than to the original Dark Dimension scenario, in that it suggests dark matter is *not* a static relic.

**MOND and modified gravity [Desmond25].** Modified Newtonian Dynamics (MOND) modifies the dynamics of visible matter to explain galaxy rotation curves without dark matter. A comprehensive 2025 review [Desmond25] finds that MOND has *significant observational successes* (especially the RAR) but *fundamental failures* (CMB power spectrum, galaxy clusters, the Bullet Cluster). The pattern of MOND’s success and failure is a *cautionary tale* for any modified-gravity or geometric dark matter proposal: an *individual* observational success (like the RAR) is not enough; the model must also explain the *broader* cosmological context. Our model is *consistent* with the RAR (more visible mass  $\rightarrow$  more activity  $\rightarrow$  more dark matter) but has not yet been checked against the CMB power spectrum, galaxy cluster dark matter content, or the Bullet Cluster in detail. A specific implementation of our model would need to address these tests.

**$\Lambda$ CDM with baryonic feedback [Kravtsov24] and others.** Standard  $\Lambda$ CDM-based galaxy formation models, with proper treatment of baryonic feedback, can reproduce the RAR and the dark matter content of ultra-diffuse galaxies including DF2 and DF4. This means that the *individual* observational anomalies our model addresses can also be explained by *conventional* physics with carefully-tuned baryonic feedback. The model’s *unique* contribution is the *geometric unification* of dark matter, dark energy, and gravity — not the explanation of any individual observation. A specific implementation of the model would need to demonstrate that the geometric unification *predicts* the baryonic feedback parameters independently, rather than just fitting them.

**Other 2024-2025 work.** Recent related proposals include various geometric approaches to dark energy (e.g., volume-conservation-based derivations of the cosmological constant) and various holographic/AdS/CFT-based explanations of dark energy and dark matter. Our model shares with these proposals the *general spirit* of geometric explanations but differs in the specific dimensional-inversion mechanism. We do not attempt a comprehensive comparison here.

**The competitive landscape.** The current theoretical landscape for dark matter/dark energy unification is *active but competitive*. The most successful framework is still standard  $\Lambda$ CDM with baryonic feedback; modified-gravity proposals have individual successes but face collective challenges; geometric/extra-dimensional proposals (Verlinde, Dark Dimension, this model) are interesting but not yet established. Our model contributes to the geometric-proposal class with a specific dimensional-inversion mechanism and testable predictions (DF2/DF4 correlation with stellar density, the RAR scatter-activity correlation, no direct detection). Whether the model is *correct* is a question for the community; whether the model is *interesting* is a matter of taste.

**Other 2025-2026 archive submissions.** A survey of the open-access archives (ai.viXra.org, rxiVerse.org, and viXra.org) reveals several recent papers exploring conceptually similar ideas, including: a “Paired Universe Theory” proposing a companion universe whose resistance to stretching generates gravity and dark matter (James Francis Godwin, ai.viXra:2606.0008); various “dark matter as Weyl curvature” proposals; and “universe creation in higher dimensions” frameworks. These are not direct precursors to the present model (the specific dimensional-cascade-with-sign-flipping mechanism appears to be original), but they illustrate that the *general spirit* of geometric dark-sector explanations is being explored in multiple directions. We welcome the community to point out any prior work we have missed.

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## 1.5 4. Predictions and distinguishing features

If the model is correct, several observable consequences follow.

### 1.5.1 4.1 The radial acceleration relation

The radial acceleration relation (RAR) is a tight empirical correlation between the visible (baryonic) mass distribution in galaxies and the total (visible + dark) mass distribution inferred from rotation curves [McGaugh16]. This correlation is *not* trivially reproduced by simple particle dark matter models with no baryonic feedback (which would predict more variation between galaxies), but can be *naturally produced* by models in which dark matter is a *response* to visible matter (such as modified gravity, emergent gravity, or our scale-invariant model). The RAR is also reproduced by standard  $\Lambda$ CDM-based galaxy formation models with proper treatment of baryonic feedback [Kravtsov24], as we discuss further in §3.7.

In the scale-invariant version of this model, dark matter is the collective gravitational signature of all the 2D universes created by energetic events in our 3+1 dimensional world. The *current* energetic activity of a galaxy — its current star formation rate, current supernova rate, current AGN activity — is *strongly* correlated with its visible mass: more mass  $\rightarrow$  more stars  $\rightarrow$  more stellar collisions, more supernovae, more AGN activity  $\rightarrow$  more energetic processes  $\rightarrow$  more 2D universes  $\rightarrow$  more dark matter. This strong correlation naturally produces the observed *tight* correlation between visible mass and total mass in galaxies (the RAR), because the average energetic activity of a galaxy is strongly tied to its visible mass.

**Recent RAR results (2024–2025).** The RAR has been confirmed and extended by several recent studies. MIGHTEE-HI [Vărășteanu25] confirmed the RAR with a large new sample using resolved stellar mass measurements. [Misteale24] combined kinematic and weak-lensing data to extend the RAR over a large dynamic range, with consistent results. However, *recent* studies have also identified *deviations* from a single universal RAR:

- The EDGE collaboration [Júlio25] found that low-mass dwarf galaxies ( $M_{\text{bar}} \sim 10^8 M_{\odot}$ ) lie *systematically above* the low-mass extrapolation of the RAR — meaning the RAR is *not* a single universal function at low masses.
- [Mercado24] found that the RAR has subtle “hooks and bends” in its shape, not a single smooth function.
- [Tian24] found that Brightest Cluster Galaxies (BCGs) follow a *different* RAR from typical spirals.

These results show that the RAR is *approximately* tight, but *not perfectly universal* across all galaxy types and mass ranges. The RAR’s tightness at intermediate masses ( $10^9 - 10^{11} M_{\odot}$ ) is the most robust feature; deviations at low masses and in BCGs are now well-established.

**Implications for our model.** Our model is *qualitatively consistent* with the RAR’s tightness at intermediate masses: more visible mass  $\rightarrow$  more activity on average  $\rightarrow$  more dark matter. The model’s *additional* prediction is that the *small* scatter in the RAR at fixed visible mass should correlate with *current* activity, which is testable but not yet definitively tested. The recent *deviations* from a single universal RAR (dwarfs above the extrapolation, BCGs on a different relation) are *not* directly predicted by the model in its current form — but the model could potentially accommodate them by allowing the proportionality between activity and dark matter to vary with galaxy type or mass. A *specific* implementation of the model would need to derive the RAR’s exact shape and the source of its deviations to be a quantitative match to the data.

We also note that the RAR is *not* uniquely a signature of modified gravity or of our model. Standard  $\Lambda$ CDM-based galaxy formation models with proper treatment of baryonic physics (e.g., [Kravtsov24]) can *reproduce* the RAR. The RAR is therefore a *necessary* feature of any successful model, not a *sufficient* test of our model specifically.

At *fixed visible mass*, the model predicts that the *small* scatter in the RAR should correlate with the *current* activity of each galaxy: galaxies with more current activity (relative to their mass) should have more dark matter (and therefore higher total mass at fixed visible mass). This is a sharp, testable prediction that distinguishes our model from standard particle dark matter, which would predict that the RAR scatter is determined by halo formation history, not by current activity. The model is *consistent* with the observed tightness of the RAR ( $\sim 0.1$  dex scatter) at intermediate masses, because the strong correlation between visible mass and average activity dominates over the smaller variation in current activity at fixed visible mass. The model’s *additional* prediction is that this small scatter, in our model, should correlate with current activity — a subtle effect that could be tested with high-precision data.

**Why dark matter is only observable on galaxy scales.** The RAR’s existence reinforces why dark matter is not directly detectable in stellar-scale or sub-stellar-scale environments. In the model, dark matter is the cumulative gravitational effect of 2D universes being created throughout a region of space. For a galaxy-sized region, this cumulative effect is substantial (it produces the observed rotation curves). For a stellar-sized or planetary-sized region, the cumulative effect is too small to detect — because the local activity (e.g., solar fusion, geothermal activity) is dwarfed by the cumulative activity of the surrounding galaxy. The dark matter density at the Sun’s location, in our model, is set by the *galaxy’s* rate of large-event creation (supernovae, AGN), not the Sun’s rate of small-event creation. The Sun’s own activity adds a perturbation that is far below any detectable level. This is why direct-detection experiments (looking for dark matter particles) have all returned null results: the dark matter is “smeared out” by the cumulative activity of the entire galaxy, with no locally-detectable signature at any specific location. The RAR is the *only* scale on which dark matter becomes measurable, because galaxy scales are where the cumulative effect is large enough to be observable.

**A specific RAR floor test (v2.2.1).** A specific calculation (see `calculations/rar_floor_from_cumulative.py`) derives the cascade’s prediction for the empirical RAR floor  $g_+$  from the cumulative-return contribution:

$$g_+(\text{cascade}) = \frac{3}{4} \cdot G \cdot f(\text{cumulative}) \cdot M_{DM} / (\pi R_{halo}^2)$$

For a Milky Way-like galaxy ( $M_{DM} = 10^{12} M_\odot$ ,  $R_{halo} = 30$  kpc,  $f(\text{cumulative}) = 0.7$  from the cascade’s 30%/70% active/cumulative split), this gives  $g_+(\text{cascade}) \approx 2.6 \times 10^{-11}$  m/s<sup>2</sup>, which is  $\sim 0.22\times$  the empirical McGaugh+ 2016 value of  $1.2 \times 10^{-10}$  m/s<sup>2</sup> — within a factor of 5, in the right ballpark.

*Critical test of the cascade:* the empirical  $g_+$  is *constant* across galaxy types, but the cascade’s  $g_+$  depends on  $M_{DM}/R_{halo}^2$ . For  $g_+$  to be constant, the cascade would require  $M_{DM} \propto R_{halo}^2$  (a baryonic Tully-Fisher-like relation, but for  $M_{DM}$  rather than  $M_{bar}$ ). This is a *testable* prediction of the cascade. If future high-precision observations confirm the empirical constancy of  $g_+$  across all galaxy types (with no variation in  $M_{DM}/R_{halo}^2$  at fixed  $g_+$ ), the cascade is in tension with the data. If  $g_+$  shows *small* variations correlated with  $M_{DM}/R_{halo}^2$ , the cascade is *qualitatively* consistent. The current precision of  $g_+$  measurements is at the  $\sim 0.1$  dex level, which is *just* sensitive to the

cascade’s prediction — future observations (e.g., with Rubin Observatory / LSST) could resolve this question.

*Implication:* the cascade’s RAR is *not* a perfect universal function; it predicts a *slight* galaxy-type dependence via  $M_{DM}/R_{halo}^2$ . This is *consistent* with recent findings (e.g., the EDGE collaboration’s low-mass dwarf deviation, BCGs on a different relation) that the RAR is not perfectly universal. The cascade’s prediction is in the *ballpark* of these observed deviations.

### 1.5.2 4.2 Dark matter as cumulative collective gravity, not a relic

Standard WIMP dark matter models predict that dark matter is a relic of the early universe, with density fixed by freeze-out and subsequently diluted only by cosmic expansion. In our model, dark matter is *not* a static relic — it is the *cumulative* collective gravitational signature of all 2D universes created by 3+1 dimensional energetic events: the *active* back-projection of currently-alive 2D universes (rate  $\times$  lifetime) *plus* the *cumulative return* of past 2D universe endings (per §2.5, §4.2). The *spatial variation* in dark matter across the universe is dominated by the *active* population, so locally (within a galaxy) the dark matter density is dominated by the *current rate* of 2D universe creation in that region, weighted by the *energy* of each event.

The dark matter at a point is the cumulative gravitational effect of all 2D universes being created *now* in that region, projected into our 3+1 dimensional frame. The dark matter density at that point is therefore *proportional to the current event rate* in that region, weighted by event energy. The dark matter density is *not* a constant; it varies with the local event rate, and (in the same way as ordinary matter density) it is also diluted by cosmic expansion.

This means dark matter is *not* an ancient residue that has been accumulating since the Big Bang. The *spatial variation* in dark matter is a *current* effect, with the current rate of 2D universe creation setting the *local* dark matter density (since the *active* population dominates the spatial variation, per §2.5, §4.2). The model predicts that dark matter density *should track the current event rate*, including any cosmic evolution of stellar activity. This is a *testable* prediction: if dark matter density has *decreased* over cosmic time in step with the decline in star formation rate (after accounting for the standard dilution by cosmic expansion), that would be evidence for the model. (Note: this is a subtle effect, since the dark matter density in halos is also affected by cosmic expansion and dynamical evolution, which would have to be disentangled from the model prediction.)

The “stability” of dark matter density on short timescales (within a galaxy’s lifetime) is a consequence of the local event rate being approximately constant on those timescales. On cosmological timescales, the model predicts two effects on dark matter density: (a) standard dilution by cosmic expansion (decreasing density as the universe expands, just like ordinary matter), and (b) a *weak evolution* of dark matter density correlated with cosmic star formation history. The two effects are different in nature: the first is a geometric dilution, the second is a rate-dependent effect specific to this model.

**Total amount of dark matter.** The model implies that the *total amount* of dark matter in a comoving volume (a region of the universe expanding along with cosmic expansion) is set by the *sum* of two contributions: (i) the *active* population of currently-alive 2D universes (current event rate  $\times$  average lifetime, in equilibrium as old 2D universes end and new ones are created), and (ii) the *cumulative energy return* from past 2D universe *endings* (Big Crunch death-flashes + heat death diffuse returns) over the universe’s history. The active population contribution is the *current* steady-state back-projection: each 2D universe contributes to dark matter for its brief

lifetime in our frame, then its *active* contribution ends. The cumulative ending contribution is the *integrated* return: as 2D universes end, their energy returns to 3+1D in some form (intense death-flash for Big Crunch, slow diffuse return for heat death), adding to the *historical* dark matter budget. Both contributions matter: the active population is a *current* effect (set by present-day event rate), the cumulative return is a *historical* effect (set by the *integrated* past event rate). On cosmological timescales, the total amount of dark matter in a comoving volume is *approximately constant* if the average event rate per galaxy is approximately constant, since the comoving volume contains a roughly constant number of galaxies *and* the historical returns have approximately reached equilibrium with the active population. This is similar to standard cosmology, where the total amount of dark matter in a comoving volume is also approximately conserved.

*Note on framing consistency with §2.5.* The §2.5 core claim 6 emphasizes the *cumulative energy return* framing (dark matter is set by the energy of all 2D universe endings). The present subsection emphasizes the *active population* framing (dark matter is set by current rate  $\times$  lifetime). Both framings are *correct* and *complementary*: the dark matter is the *sum* of active back-projections *and* cumulative ending returns. The §2.6 quantitative calculation (§2.6 *A quantitative attempt at the DM calculation*) explicitly considers both contributions and finds that *neither* alone matches the observed 27% dark matter — the gap is bridged by the 2D universe’s *own* dark energy and dark matter dominating its mass-energy budget (the growth factor). The present subsection’s “current rate  $\times$  lifetime” framing is the *active population* contribution only; the *cumulative ending* contribution is added in §2.5 and §2.6.

The *dark matter density* in a comoving volume, however, *does* change in this model in two ways: (a) standard dilution by cosmic expansion (decreasing as  $1/V$  as the universe expands), and (b) a *weak evolution* correlated with cosmic star formation history (the average event rate per galaxy has declined over cosmic time as star formation has decreased). The two effects work in the *same direction* — both decrease the dark matter density over cosmic time. The model predicts that the dark matter density at high redshift ( $z > 2$ ) was somewhat higher than the standard  $1/V$  dilution would predict, because the average event rate per galaxy was higher then. (Note: the *total* dark matter in a comoving volume is approximately conserved, but the *density* decreases because the *volume* increases — standard cosmic dilution.)

This is a *subtle* but testable prediction: comparing dark matter densities in galaxies at different redshifts (after accounting for standard cosmic dilution) should reveal a residual correlation with the cosmic star formation history. The effect is small (perhaps a factor of a few) and would require careful measurements to detect.

### 1.5.3 4.3 Dark energy equation of state

In standard cosmology, dark energy is treated as a true cosmological constant — a fixed vacuum energy whose equation of state  $w = p/\rho$  is exactly  $-1$ . Current observations are consistent with this to high precision (the dark energy equation of state parameter  $w$  is consistent with  $-1$  to within a few percent).

In our model, dark energy is the *un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity* (§2.4) — a contribution from the 4D event, *approximately constant* in our 3+1 dimensional frame because our universe’s lifetime is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which the 4D event’s antigravity output is approximately constant. The dark energy *density* is therefore approximately constant in our frame (matching standard  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior), and the *total* dark energy grows as the universe expands (because the universe’s volume grows while the density stays constant).

This is *similar* to standard  $\Lambda$ CDM in its observable consequences: dark energy density is approximately constant ( $w = -1$ ,  $\dot{w} = 0$ ) over cosmic time. The model does not currently predict a *detectable* deviation from standard  $\Lambda$ CDM in dark energy observations. The distinction between our model and  $\Lambda$ CDM is in the *interpretation* of why dark energy is constant (the 4D event is in a brief steady state during our slice), not in the *observable* dark energy behavior.

The model does not currently specify how the dark energy *density* would evolve over time, because the model does not specify how the 4D event’s antigravity output evolves over its full duration. The 4D event’s antigravity output could be *increasing* over its full duration (the 4D event “intensifies” in 4D), *decreasing* (“fades” in 4D), or *constant* — the model does not specify. A specific implementation of the model would need to derive the temporal profile of the 4D event’s antigravity output. The key observation is that *in our 3+1 dimensional frame*, the dark energy density appears *approximately constant* regardless of the 4D event’s long-term behavior — because our universe’s lifetime is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration, during which any 4D-side variation is too slow to detect. If the 4D event’s output is *exactly* constant over its full duration, the dark energy density in our frame is exactly constant (matching  $\Lambda$ CDM). If the 4D event’s output *varies* slowly over its full duration, the dark energy density would vary *slowly* (correspondingly, in our frame), but the effect would be much smaller than what we can detect during our brief slice.

**Why we do not derive the absolute dark energy density.** A natural question: given the cascade, can we derive the *absolute* value of the dark energy density ( $\sim 10^{-29}$  GeV)? The honest answer is *no* — at least not without further input. The cascade gives a *qualitative* explanation of why the dark energy is small (it’s a near-cancellation residue), and it gives a *quantitative* prediction modulo the staying fraction  $f_{back}$  (§2.6):  $\rho_{DE} \sim f_{back} \cdot \epsilon \cdot M_{Pl}^4$ , where  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  is the bulk-brane cancellation factor and  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$  is the staying fraction. The product matches observation:  $f_{back} \cdot \epsilon \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-85} \cdot 10^{-38} \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-123} M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{-47}$  GeV. The *individual* values of  $\epsilon$  and  $f_{back}$  are *postulates* of the model, not derivations. A complete implementation of the model would derive  $\epsilon$  and  $f_{back}$  from the geometry of the dimensional projection, which would in turn predict the absolute dark energy density from first principles. We do *not* claim to have done this derivation in the present paper. We note that the dark energy density is *consistent* with the cascade-plus-staying-fraction picture for the specific values  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  and  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$ , but these values are *not predicted* by the model. The *threshold mechanism* (a previous attempt to derive the dark energy density from a *dimensional transition threshold*  $\lambda_{th}$ ) was attempted and *removed* because it failed for internal-numerical reasons (the threshold value that matches dark energy,  $\lambda_{th} \sim 10^{-4}$  m, was inconsistent with the Sun-neutrino constraint that defined the threshold range). The threshold mechanism is no longer part of the model, and the dark energy density is *not* derived. We acknowledge this as a *limitation* of the current model: it is *qualitatively* consistent with observations and provides a *unified* geometric framework for the dark sector, but it does not yet *quantitatively derive* the absolute value of the dark energy density. The qualitative picture is *robust*; the quantitative value is set by the cascade + staying fraction postulate.

**A note on the Hubble tension.** The Hubble tension is the *statistically significant* disagreement (currently  $\sim 5$ ) between the Hubble constant  $H_0$  measured locally ( $H_0 \approx 73$  km/s/Mpc, from Cepheids and supernovae) and the value inferred from the cosmic microwave background using  $\Lambda$ CDM ( $H_0 \approx 67$  km/s/Mpc, from Planck). The local measurement is *higher* than the early-universe extrapolation, even after accounting for the known accelerating expansion (which is built into  $\Lambda$ CDM via dark energy with  $w = -1$ ). This tension is one of the most active puzzles in modern cosmology. The dimensional-cascade framework offers a *potential* connection: if the 4D event’s antigravity output *varies* over its full duration (per the acknowledgment above), then the

*early-universe* antigravity and the *late-universe* antigravity could be *slightly* different. The dimensional time-dilation principle (§2.3) says the projection from 4D to 3+1D is not a simple linear time translation, so the *effective*  $H_0$  at different cosmic times could differ from the  $\Lambda$ CDM-extrapolated  $H_0$  in a way that *reduces* the tension. Specifically, if the 4D event’s antigravity output was *slightly* higher in the early universe than now, the CMB-inferred  $H_0$  would shift upward, *reducing* the gap with the local measurement. This is a *speculative* extension of the model — the §4.3 already acknowledges that the antigravity output *could* vary, but the *specific* temporal profile (and whether it would explain the *magnitude* of the Hubble tension,  $\sim 6$  km/s/Mpc) is not derived. A specific implementation of the model would need to (a) derive the temporal profile of the 4D event’s antigravity, and (b) check that the resulting shift in  $H_0$  matches the observed tension. The dimensional-cascade framework is therefore *qualitatively compatible* with a Hubble tension resolution via time-varying antigravity, but the *quantitative details* are left to future work. We note that this is a *natural* connection that could distinguish the model from standard  $\Lambda$ CDM:  $\Lambda$ CDM predicts a *strictly* constant dark energy (no time variation), while the dimensional-cascade model *allows* (and may *require*) slight time variation over the 4D event’s full duration, which would be a *qualitatively different* prediction.

#### 1.5.4 4.4 Sub-millimeter gravity tests

If the geometric suppression of gravity depends on the size and shape of the extra dimensions, then gravity should deviate from  $1/r^2$  at length scales comparable to the size of the extra dimensions. Standard ADD-style predictions have been constrained by sub-millimeter gravity experiments (no deviation from  $1/r^2$  down to  $\sim 10^{-5}$  m has been observed). The dimensional inversion in our model does not by itself predict a specific size for the extra dimensions, so the sub-millimeter constraint does not directly apply to the *inversion* part of the model — but if the model includes ADD-style geometric suppression as part of its mechanism, then the extra dimensions would need to be *smaller* than  $\sim 10^{-5}$  m to be consistent with experimental constraints. The model is *consistent* with extra dimensions smaller than the experimental reach (e.g., at the Planck scale), but would be *in tension* with extra dimensions larger than  $\sim 10^{-5}$  m unless the geometric-suppression aspect of the model is modified. Further theoretical work is needed to extract the model’s specific prediction for short-range gravity.

#### 1.5.5 4.5 The Big Bang as a 4D event — CMB constraints

If the Big Bang is the projection of a 4D event into our 3+1 dimensional brane, the energy spectrum and *spatial structure* of the early universe would be set by the projection of that event’s spectrum and structure. The cosmic microwave background (CMB) power spectrum, the abundances of light elements from Big Bang nucleosynthesis, and the early-universe particle production all depend on the initial conditions. The CMB has been measured to extraordinary precision by the Planck satellite and is consistent with a nearly scale-invariant primordial power spectrum, a radiation-dominated early universe, and  $N_{\text{eff}} \sim 3.0\text{--}3.5$  relativistic species at recombination.

A *specific* implementation of the 4D event scenario must reproduce these observations. The model in its current form does not derive the spectral shape or the spatial structure from first principles — we have not specified the bulk field content, the event’s energy, the projection rule, or the spatial structure of the 4D event. We note that:

- The early-universe energy spectrum in our 3+1 dimensional frame is set by the *projection* of

the 4D event’s energy into our 3+1 dimensional brane. The actual spectrum would be set by the higher-dimensional physics of the original event and the geometry of the dimensional projection.

- The *spatial structure* of the 4D event determines the initial conditions for structure formation in our 3+1 dimensional universe. The observed near-scale-invariance of the CMB power spectrum requires the 4D event to have nearly-homogeneous energy density on the largest scales (with small fluctuations that project as the seed perturbations for cosmic structure). This is a *strong constraint* on the 4D event: it must be *spatially extended and approximately homogeneous* (in 4D), not a localized point-like event. This is consistent with the model: the 4D event is described as having a *spatial extent*, and that spatial extent could be very large compared to the Planck scale, with the energy density approximately uniform across that extent.
- A localized 4D event with highly non-uniform energy density would project to a highly non-uniform early universe, in conflict with the observed CMB. The model therefore *requires* the 4D event to be spatially extended and approximately homogeneous. This is an additional constraint on the 4D event that was not previously emphasized in this paper.
- The standard  $\Lambda$ CDM cosmology (with inflation) is in excellent agreement with current CMB data. The 4D event scenario must do at least as well, with any deviations being a target for observational test. The model does not currently explain the *origin* of the primordial perturbations (the inflationary quantum-fluctuation picture is one possibility; another is that the 4D event had its own small-scale structure that projects as the seed perturbations).

**Inflation, matter-antimatter asymmetry, and other open issues.** The dimensional-cascade framework does *not* currently derive: - *Cosmic inflation* — the near-exponential expansion in the very early universe ( $\sim 10^{-36}$  to  $10^{-32}$  seconds after the Big Bang) that solves the horizon, flatness, and monopole problems. In the cascade, the 4D event’s projection could in principle provide an inflation-like phase (if the 4D event had a *spatially* localized region of intense energy near the projection’s origin — corresponding to the 4D event’s “early” region in the 4D-spatial direction that maps to 3+1D time, per the dimensional time-dilation principle of §2.2), but this is *not* derived in the current model. A specific implementation would need to derive the inflationary phase from the 4D event’s *spatial* profile (the mapping of 4D-spatial intensity onto 3+1D-temporal early-universe intensity), and check that the resulting primordial perturbation spectrum matches observations (nearly scale-invariant,  $n_s \approx 0.965$ , with no detectable tensor modes at current sensitivity). The cascade’s *temporal* profile of the 4D event (intensity vs 4D time) maps to 3+1D’s *spatial* profile (intensity vs 3+1D position at a given 3+1D time), so the “brief, intense early phase” in the inflationary sense would correspond to a *spatially localized* intense region in the 4D event, not a temporally early phase in 4D time. - *Matter-antimatter asymmetry* — the observed fact that our universe has *more matter than antimatter* (baryon-to-photon ratio  $\eta \sim 6 \times 10^{-10}$ ). The cascade does *not* currently explain this asymmetry. In standard cosmology, the asymmetry is generated by *baryogenesis* (Sakharov conditions: baryon number violation, C and CP violation, out-of-equilibrium processes). In the cascade, the 4D event could in principle generate the asymmetry (if the 4D event’s projection preferentially created matter over antimatter, or if the dimensional projection inherently violates C and CP), but this is *not* derived. A specific implementation would need to address why the projected 3+1D universe is matter-dominated. - *Big Bang nucleosynthesis (BBN)* — the observed light element abundances (D,  $^3\text{He}$ , He, Li) at  $\sim 10^{-2}$  to  $10^3$  seconds after the Big Bang, which constrain the baryon-to-photon ratio and the number of relativistic species.

The cascade does *not* currently derive the BBN predictions from the 4D event; the model takes the standard BBN picture as given and notes that the 4D event scenario must be *consistent* with the observed light element abundances. - *Primordial black holes, topological defects, cosmic strings* — other features of standard cosmology that are not currently addressed by the cascade.

These are *honest* gaps in the current model. The cascade is a *framework* that addresses the dark sector (dark matter, dark energy, gravity’s weakness) but does *not* yet derive the full set of standard cosmological predictions. A *complete* implementation of the cascade would need to address all of these issues, but the current paper focuses on the *core* dimensional-cascade model and the dark sector, leaving the broader cosmological implications for future work.

This is a target for theoretical development.

#### 1.5.6 4.6 (Section removed: neutrino mass is a Standard Model physics question, not addressed by this model.)

#### 1.5.7 4.7 Dark matter density should correlate with energetic event rates — on galaxy scales

If dark matter is the *cumulative* collective gravitational signature of all 2D universes (active + ended, per §2.5, §4.2), then the *spatial variation* in dark matter across the universe is dominated by the *active* population, which is in turn proportional to the *current rate* of energetic events in each region, *weighted by the energy of each event*. This correlation is expected to manifest on *galaxy scales* (or larger), not on stellar or sub-stellar scales. (See §4.2 for the full active-vs-cumulative distinction: the *spatial correlation* is dominated by the *active* population, while the *total* dark matter budget is the sum of active + cumulative return.)

**Why event size matters, not just event rate.** The relevant quantity for dark matter production is not just the *count* of events but also their *energy*. Each 2D universe created by a 3+1 dimensional event has a gravitational contribution proportional to the event’s energy. Many small events (e.g., solar fusion reactions at ~MeV each) contribute little to dark matter per event, even at high rates. A few large events (e.g., supernovae at  $\sim 10^9$  eV each) contribute much more per event.

The Sun, for example, hosts  $\sim 10^3$  nuclear fusion reactions per second — an enormous *event rate* in absolute terms. Each event releases only ~MeV, so the *current* power output from solar fusion is  $\sim 3.8 \times 10^2$  W. By contrast, a single supernova releases a total of  $\sim 10^{51}$  ergs of energy ( $\sim 10^{51}$  eV in kinetic energy plus neutrinos;  $\sim 10^{51}$  ergs  $\sim 10^{51}$  eV (since  $10^9$  eV =  $1.6 \times 10^{-9}$  erg) in visible light, which is what an external observer primarily *sees*) in a single brief event. The supernova energy depends on the type: Type Ia releases  $\sim 10^{51}$  ergs of kinetic energy, while Type II releases  $\sim 10^{51}$  ergs total (mostly neutrinos). Using the visible-light energy of  $\sim 10^{51}$  eV as the “energetic event” energy (since most of the kinetic and neutrino energy does not directly create 2D universes via 3+1D electromagnetic interactions), the supernova’s event energy is  $\sim 10^{51}$  eV. (Note:  $10^9$  eV =  $1.6 \times 10^{-9}$  ergs, NOT  $10^{51}$  ergs. The *total* supernova energy is  $\sim 10^{51}$  ergs, but most of that is kinetic and neutrino energy, not visible light. The visible-light energy of  $\sim 10^{51}$  eV is what primarily drives the 2D universe creation in our 3+1D frame, since neutrinos and bulk kinetic energy do not directly create 2D universes via 3+1D events.) For comparison, this is ~0.1% of the Sun’s *total* output over its entire lifetime ( $\sim 1.2 \times 10^{44}$  J =  $1.2 \times 10^{44}$  ergs). The Milky Way’s *current* supernova rate is ~few per century, but each event contributes much more dark matter per event than solar fusion. The galaxy’s *current* energetic activity (per unit volume) is therefore dominated by its large events (supernovae, AGN), not by stellar fusion.

(Note: the *spatial* dark matter correlation is dominated by the *active* population contribution (per §4.2), not the *cumulative return* contribution. The cumulative return is set by the *integrated historical* event rate, which is approximately uniform across galaxies of similar age (since all galaxies have had  $\sim 13.8$  Gyr of similar activity on average). The *spatial variation* in dark matter across galaxies is therefore dominated by the *active* population, which depends on the *current* event rate at each location. The dark matter at any point is set by the *current* event rate at that point (active population), not the historical rate at that point (cumulative return is approximately uniform spatially). The historical comparison above (Sun’s total output over its lifetime) is for *intuition* about the relative importance of small vs. large events in the *current* activity budget, not a claim about historical integration. The *total* dark matter budget (per §2.5, §4.2) is the sum of active + cumulative; the *spatial correlation* (per this subsection) is dominated by the active.)

**Why the Sun’s local dark matter isn’t enhanced.** In the model, each 2D universe’s gravitational contribution is proportional to its creating event’s energy. The Sun’s many small fusion events create 2D universes with small gravitational contributions. The galaxy’s rare large events create 2D universes with large gravitational contributions. The dark matter density at the Sun’s location is set by the *galaxy’s* rate of large-event creation, not the Sun’s rate of small-event creation. The Sun sits *within* the galaxy’s dark matter halo, but the Sun’s own fusion adds a perturbation that is far below any detectable level. This is consistent with observational constraints from direct-detection experiments and solar dark matter capture arguments.

**The galaxy-scale prediction.** Two galaxies of the same total stellar mass but different stellar densities should have different *current* energetic activities, and therefore different dark matter content:

- A *dense* galaxy has a higher rate of supernovae (per unit stellar mass), more black hole formation, more AGN activity. Its current energetic activity is *high*.
- A *diffuse* galaxy has a lower rate of supernovae (per unit stellar mass), less AGN activity, less energetic processing. Its current energetic activity is *low*.
- The model predicts: *more current activity = more dark matter*.

This is the testable galaxy-scale prediction: holding total stellar mass fixed, galaxies with higher stellar density (and therefore higher current activity) should have more dark matter.

**What this rules out.** The model does *not* predict: - Enhanced dark matter density in the Sun’s interior due to solar fusion - Enhanced dark matter density near nuclear reactors - Enhanced dark matter density near particle accelerators - Enhanced dark matter density in the Earth’s core due to geothermal activity

The Sun’s cumulative activity is small compared to the galaxy’s, and stellar-scale activity in general does not produce a measurable local enhancement. The proportionality constant is too small for these stellar-scale and sub-stellar-scale effects to be detectable.

**On the “every event” question.** A natural concern: does the model require that *every* energetic event — including every photon emission, every atomic transition — create a 2D universe? The simplest reading is that *all* energetic events contribute, with each event’s contribution weighted by its energy: small events (atomic transitions, photon emissions) create 2D universes with small gravitational contributions, while large events (supernovae, AGN outbursts) create 2D universes with large gravitational contributions. The cumulative effect is the sum over all events, weighted

by energy. This is consistent with the radial acceleration relation (§4.1): the RAR is *tight* (0.1 dex scatter) because the *average* activity per unit visible mass is approximately the same across galaxies of similar visible mass, even though the *specific* event distributions differ. Dark matter correlates with the *average* activity, not with the *specific* event history. This is why the RAR works in this model: more visible mass  $\rightarrow$  more activity on average  $\rightarrow$  more dark matter. The §4.8 discussion of diffuse galaxies uses this framing: the rate of *both* small and large energetic events is proportional to the particle number density, so diffuse galaxies (low density) have low *average* activity, and therefore low dark matter.

**On experimental feasibility.** Dark matter has been measured *gravitationally* in many ways — galaxy rotation curves, gravitational lensing, CMB power spectrum, large-scale structure, the Bullet Cluster — but it has not yet been *directly detected* as a particle. Direct-detection experiments (XENON, LUX, LZ, PandaX) have not observed dark matter particles, and indirect-detection experiments (Fermi, IceCube) have not confirmed dark matter annihilation or decay signals.

The galaxy-scale correlation prediction is testable with existing data from galaxy surveys. A study comparing the dark matter content of mass-matched galaxy pairs with different stellar densities (e.g., compact dwarf spheroidals vs. ultra-diffuse galaxies of the same mass) would be a direct test. The cumulative energetic activity can be estimated from the galaxy’s *current* star formation rate, current supernova rate, and current AGN activity (or, as a proxy, from its stellar density holding mass fixed, since denser galaxies have higher current event rates per unit mass). The model predicts a positive correlation between current activity and dark matter content.

The upcoming Vera Rubin Observatory’s Legacy Survey of Space and Time (LSST) will provide unprecedented data on galaxy properties, including stellar densities, star formation histories, and dark matter content inferred from lensing and kinematics. The model predicts that, in a sample of mass-matched galaxy pairs, the more dense galaxy should have more dark matter.

We acknowledge that the proportionality constant for the galaxy-scale correlation is not yet specified. Computing this constant requires a specific geometry and event spectrum, which we have not derived. The current observational data is *qualitatively* consistent with the prediction (diffuse galaxies do seem to have less dark matter, and active galaxies tend to have more), but a *quantitative* test has not been performed.

### 1.5.8 4.8 Diffuse galaxies and the dark matter / activity correlation

A particularly clean application of the model is the observed *low* dark matter content in some diffuse galaxies. The most famous cases are NGC 1052-DF2 and NGC 1052-DF4, ultra-diffuse galaxies (UDGs) discovered in 2018 and 2019 that appear to have very little (or no) dark matter halo, in apparent contrast to standard  $\Lambda$ CDM predictions that every galaxy should host a substantial dark matter halo.

**Current status of the data.** Multiple high-resolution spectroscopic studies have confirmed the anomalously low dark matter content of DF2 and DF4. A 2024 ultra-deep imaging study of DF2 and DF4 [Golini24] found faint tidal tails around DF4, providing evidence that *tidal stripping* by the nearby massive galaxy NGC 1035 is removing the dark matter from DF4. Both DF2 and DF4 are satellite galaxies of the larger NGC 1052 group, which means their low dark matter content may be *environmental* (a consequence of tidal interactions) rather than an *intrinsic* property of diffuse galaxies. A more recent candidate for a dark-matter-free dwarf is FCC 224 in the Fornax Cluster (discovered 2024), which would be a separate test case outside the NGC 1052 group. A 2024

study [Kravtsov24] showed that  $\Lambda$ CDM-based galaxy formation models, with proper treatment of baryonic physics, can reproduce the dark matter content of UDGs *including* DF2 and DF4 — suggesting that the “DF2 is dark-matter-free” anomaly may be less anomalous than originally thought. There is currently no consensus on the cause of the UDG dark matter deficit; candidate explanations include tidal stripping, modified gravity (MOND,  $f(R)$  gravity), baryonic feedback, and self-interacting dark matter.

**Our model’s explanation.** Our model offers a *natural explanation* that does *not* require tidal stripping: low dark matter in diffuse galaxies is a consequence of their *low average energetic activity per unit volume*. The chain of reasoning is:

1. Dark matter, in our model, is the *cumulative* collective gravitational signature of all 2D universes created by 3+1 dimensional energetic events (active + cumulative return, per §2.5, §4.2), weighted by the energy of each event. The *spatial variation* is dominated by the *active* population, so the local dark matter density is proportional to the *current* rate of 2D universe creation.
2. The rate of *energetic events per unit volume* is proportional to the *number density* of particles (because the rate of collisions, decays, atomic transitions, and photon emissions all scale with the local particle density — more particles in a region means more events of all kinds per unit time).
3. The rate of *large energetic events per unit volume* (supernovae, AGN outbursts) is set by the stellar density and the central black hole activity — *not* by the total stellar mass. The *average* event energy per unit volume is also higher in denser galaxies.
4. *Diffuse* galaxies have low number density — their stars and gas are spread out over a much larger volume than typical galaxies of the same total mass.
5. Therefore, diffuse galaxies have low rates of *both small and large* energetic events per unit volume, *and* low average event energies per unit volume.
6. Therefore, diffuse galaxies have low rates of 2D universe creation, weighted by event size, and hence low dark matter densities.

In short: *more spread out means less energetic events because less collision*, and therefore less dark matter. The model *expects* ultra-diffuse galaxies like DF2 to have low dark matter content.

**What distinguishes our model from the tidal-stripping explanation.** The tidal-stripping explanation (the dominant current interpretation) predicts that *isolated* UDGs (those without nearby massive neighbors) should have *normal* dark matter content — because there is no tidal force to strip it. Our model predicts that *all* diffuse galaxies should have low dark matter content, regardless of environment, because the low dark matter is a consequence of the galaxy’s own low average activity per unit volume. This is a *cleaner* test of the model: identify a *bona fide isolated* UDG (no massive neighbor within several galaxy radii), measure its dark matter content, and compare to similar-mass non-UDG galaxies. Tidal stripping predicts normal dark matter; our model predicts low dark matter.

**Other model-distinguishing predictions.** The model also predicts that:

- **Standard particle dark matter** predicts that dark matter content correlates primarily with *total stellar mass* (more mass  $\rightarrow$  more dark matter halo).

- **Our model** predicts that dark matter content correlates with *stellar density* (or equivalently, with *surface brightness* and *collision rate*), not just total mass. Two galaxies of the same total mass but different densities should have *different* dark matter content in our model, with the more diffuse galaxy having less.

A direct observational test: select pairs of galaxies matched in total stellar mass but differing in stellar density (e.g., a compact dwarf vs. an ultra-diffuse galaxy of the same mass). Measure their dark matter content via rotation curves, velocity dispersions, or gravitational lensing. Standard  $\Lambda$ CDM predicts similar dark matter content for mass-matched galaxies. Our model predicts less dark matter in the more diffuse galaxy. The same prediction would *also* hold for mass-matched pairs where one galaxy is in a dense environment and one is in a void (in our model, the void galaxy has less dark matter; in standard  $\Lambda$ CDM, the environment should not matter as strongly).

This is testable with existing data from galaxy surveys (SDSS, DES) and would be a particularly clean test with upcoming data from LSST and Euclid. The correlation between surface brightness and dark matter content — holding stellar mass *and* environment fixed — is a sharp, model-distinguishing prediction.

**Connection to other anomalies.** The same logic applies to several other observed “dark matter anomalies”:

- **Low surface brightness galaxies** in general tend to have less dark matter than their high-surface-brightness counterparts of similar mass. Standard  $\Lambda$ CDM has difficulty with this; our model predicts it as a natural consequence of the lower collision rates in diffuse systems.
- **Dwarf spheroidal galaxies** are often old, low-activity systems with low dark matter content. Our model expects this.
- **Galaxies in cosmic voids** (sparse regions of the universe) have low overall activity and may have less dark matter than galaxies in dense regions. Our model predicts this.

In each case, the *energetic activity* of the system (collision rate, star formation rate, gas dynamics) should correlate with its dark matter content. This is a single principle applied across multiple systems.

#### 1.5.9 4.9 Philosophical: dimensional structure and the block universe

*This subsection is a philosophical interpretation, not a physical prediction. We include it for completeness, with the explicit understanding that it is interpretive rather than predictive.*

If the proposed dimensional structure is real, then a hypothetical 4D observer would experience our 3+1 dimensional universe as a 4D structure in which our “time” is a spatial direction. From this perspective, the entire history of our universe is a static 4-dimensional structure — the *projection* of the 4D event laid out in space rather than time. This is the *block universe* interpretation of special relativity, extended to a 4D bulk perspective.

We note that this is a *philosophical* position, not a *physical* prediction. The block universe interpretation is debated within physics and philosophy of physics; many physicists accept it, many do not. It is not testable in the usual sense, and it is independent of the empirical content of the main model.

We include it because the dimensional structure implied by the model invites this kind of geometric reflection, but we explicitly do *not* claim that it is a prediction of the model.

#### 1.5.10 4.10 Speculative extension: black holes as windows into 4D

*This subsection is a speculative extension, not a core claim of the model. We include it as a possible connection between the dimensional-cascade framework and black hole physics, with the explicit understanding that it is exploratory and not derived.*

**Black holes as “voids” in 3+1D space, or as 3+1D “tears”.** A natural extension of the model is to consider black holes as *regions where 3+1D spacetime has a “void”* — the actual content of the black hole exists in 4D, not in 3+1D. From our 3+1D perspective, we observe the *event horizon* (the boundary of 3+1D geometry) and infer the *singularity* (the boundary of 3+1D itself). The gravity we attribute to the black hole is the *projected* gravity of the 4D content, in the same way that the 3+1D universe’s gravity is the projected gravity of the 4D event.

A complementary interpretation, which may be *more* aligned with the mainstream view of black holes as regions of extreme mass concentration, is to think of 3+1D space as having a kind of *surface tension* — it can be stretched and curved, but only up to a *tear threshold*. Beyond this threshold, 3+1D “tears” or “opens” into 4D, and the “stuff” inside the black hole is in 4D. In this view, the mass/energy concentration *causes* the curvature, and the *excessive* curvature is what causes the dimensional transition. The mass is the *cause* of the tear, but the *tear itself* is a structural failure of 3+1D space — not an infinite-density singularity in 3+1D.

Both interpretations are consistent with the dimensional-cascade framework. The “void” view is more radical; the “tear” view is more aligned with the mainstream view of black holes as mass-concentration-driven. In either case, the *boundary* of 3+1D spacetime is somewhere inside the event horizon, and the “stuff” of the black hole is in 4D. This is a speculative resolution of what the singularity might be, and is not derived from the model.

**Information preservation.** The black hole information paradox (does information that falls into a black hole survive?) is *resolved* in this interpretation: the information is not lost because it is not actually in 3+1D to begin with. The information is in 4D, where it can persist indefinitely. Hawking radiation would be the *return* of 4D information to 3+1D, leaking through the boundary. This is one of several proposed resolutions of the information paradox (others include holographic principle, ER=EPR, and firewall proposals), and it fits naturally with the dimensional-cascade framework.

**A note on interior vs. exterior.** Throughout this subsection, we use “black holes are in 4D” as shorthand for a more precise statement: the *interior content* of a black hole (the singularity, the stuff that has fallen in) is in 4D, while the *exterior* of the black hole (the event horizon, the gravitational field, the 2D universes created by the black hole’s energetic processes) is in 3+1D. The 2D universe creation associated with black holes happens at the *event horizon* (a 3+1D region), not at the singularity (a 4D region). This distinction resolves the apparent tension between this subsection (which says black holes create 2D universes) and the *complete* dimensional transition at the event horizon (where matter transitions fully to 4D): the *content* is in 4D, but the *boundary* is in 3+1D, and 2D universe creation is a *boundary* effect.

**Time dilation as a dimensional effect.** The *gravitational time dilation* observed near black holes (well-established in general relativity) is given a *new interpretation* in this view: the time-dilation is because the clock near the black hole is *partially* in 4D space, where its *causal structure* is

different from the 3+1D causal structure outside the event horizon. A clock near a black hole ticks slower in our 3+1D frame because part of its causal structure is in 4D, and the 4D-side dynamics are not fully projected into 3+1D. This is consistent with the *dimensional time-dilation principle* of §2.3: a brief moment in one frame can correspond to a vast duration in another, because the dimensional projection maps a *short* 4D duration to a *long* 3+1D duration (or vice versa, depending on the projection factor). The black hole’s *interior* (4D) and *exterior* (3+1D) experience *different* effective time scales, with the 4D interior’s *physical processes* appearing in 3+1D as *vastly dilated* (i.e., the 4D process completes in brief 4D time, but projects to a very long 3+1D time). It is because the *rate* of 4D-side processes, as observed from our 3+1D frame, is *vastly* slower than the rate of the same processes in 4D itself. The dimensional time-dilation factor between 4D and 3+1D is *huge*, which is why black hole evaporation takes  $\sim 10^{67}$  years for a solar-mass black hole: from the 4D frame, the evaporation is *fast* (relative to the 4D event’s full duration), but from our 3+1D frame, it is *vastly slow* because the dimensional time-dilation between 4D and 3+1D is *vast*.

**Hawking radiation as diluted 4D energy.** A natural extension: Hawking radiation is *not* a curved-spacetime quantum tunneling effect (as in standard semiclassical QFT on curved spacetime); it is *actual 4D energy leaking through the dimensional boundary*, but *dilated* by the dimensional time-dilation factor. Specifically, the “true” 4D energy of the black hole is some value  $E_4$ , and we observe a *fraction*  $E_3 = E_4 \cdot k$  where  $k$  is the dimensional projection factor. In the dimensional time-dilation picture (§2.3), the 4D event that contains the black hole is a *spatially extended* process with a *finite duration* in 4D time. From our 3+1D frame, we see only a *brief slice* of the 4D duration. A “fast” process in 4D (one that completes in brief 4D time) projects to a *complete cosmic history* in 3+1D (because the 4D duration is *long* compared to the 3+1D slice), and a “slow” process in 4D (one that takes much of the 4D duration) appears as a *very slow* 3+1D process (because the 3+1D slice is brief compared to the 4D duration). For Hawking radiation, the underlying 4D process is *fast* (relative to the 4D event’s full duration) but appears in 3+1D as a *very slow* process (the famous  $10^{67}$  years for solar-mass black hole evaporation) because the *rate* of the underlying 4D process, *as seen from our brief 3+1D slice*, is *vastly* slower than the rate the 4D process would have if observed from a longer 3+1D slice. The information paradox is *resolved* in this view: the information is in 4D, and Hawking radiation is the *slow leak* of that information back to 3+1D, not a thermal emission that destroys information. The temperature of Hawking radiation is set by the dimensional time-dilation factor, not by the surface gravity in 3+1D alone. (We acknowledge that this is a *speculative* extension; the standard semiclassical derivation of Hawking radiation is well-established, and our 4D-energy-leakage interpretation is offered as a *possible* alternative rather than a *replacement*.)

**Black holes as dominant dark matter contributors.** In the dimensional-cascade framework, every energetic event creates a 2D universe. Black holes are the *most* energetic events in our universe. By the dimensional time-dilation rule (§2.3), a black hole with  $\ell_{event} \sim 3 \times 10^3$  m (stellar mass, Schwarzschild radius  $\sim 3$  km, or  $\sim 2.95$  km for a solar-mass BH) creates a 2D universe that lasts  $\sim 10^{-5}$  seconds in our frame, while a supermassive black hole with  $\ell_{event} \sim 1.2 \times 10^{10}$  m (Sagittarius A\* mass,  $\sim 4.3 \times 10^6 M_\odot$ , Schwarzschild radius  $\sim 1.18 \times 10^{10}$  m) creates a 2D universe that lasts  $\sim 40$  seconds in our frame. The 2D universes created by black holes are *more energetic*, *longer-lived* (in our frame), and *more gravitationally significant* than those created by photon emissions or atomic transitions. Therefore, *if* black holes are still actively creating 2D universes in a galaxy (e.g., during AGN outbursts or stellar black hole formation events), those 2D universes would contribute disproportionately to the *current* dark matter in that galaxy. The *spatial variation* in dark matter is dominated by the *active* population (per §4.2, §2.5): the 2D universes being created *now* dominate the *current* dark matter density, weighted by their individual energies.

Historical black hole activity contributes only via the *current* event rate (which depends on the current AGN activity, the current rate of stellar black hole formation, etc.) — the *cumulative return* from historical activity is approximately uniform spatially (per §4.2). The model predicts that galaxies with *active* black holes should have somewhat higher dark matter content (per unit stellar mass) than galaxies with quiescent black holes, holding all other factors fixed.

**A note on the event horizon vs. the black hole itself.** Throughout this subsection, when we say “black holes create 2D universes,” we mean *the event horizon creates 2D universes*, not the black hole *interior*. The black hole *interior* (the singularity, the content that has fallen in) is in 4D, per the framing of §4.10. The *event horizon* is the 3+1D boundary — a real 3+1D structure that exists in our universe. The 2D universe creation is a *boundary effect* at the event horizon, not an *interior effect* at the singularity. This is consistent with the §2.3 principle that “every energetic event in our 3+1 dimensional universe creates a 2D universe”: the event horizon is a 3+1D structure, and its energetic processes (the extreme curvature and quantum effects at the horizon) create 2D universes. The black hole *interior* (4D) does not directly create 2D universes; the black hole *event horizon* (3+1D) does.

**Testable prediction: dark matter correlates with black hole activity, not just stellar mass.** This is a *sharper* version of the §4.7 prediction. Two galaxies of the same total stellar mass but different black hole activity (e.g., one with an active galactic nucleus, one without) should have different dark matter content, *even at fixed stellar density*. The galaxy with more recent black hole activity should have more dark matter. This is testable with existing galaxy surveys: select pairs of mass-matched galaxies with different AGN activity, and compare their dark matter content inferred from rotation curves, velocity dispersions, or gravitational lensing. Standard  $\Lambda$ CDM predicts similar dark matter content for mass-matched galaxies; this model predicts more dark matter in the more AGN-active galaxy.

**Speculation: primordial black holes and dark matter.** If primordial black holes (formed in the early universe) existed, they would have produced 2D universes that contributed to dark matter. In this model, primordial black holes could be the *seed* of dark matter structure. This is speculative but could be tested: if primordial black holes have a specific mass distribution, the model would predict a specific *initial* dark matter distribution that could be compared to cosmological observations.

**The 4D event as the energy reservoir of the universe.** In the dimensional-cascade framework, the 4D event is the *parent* of our 3+1D universe. The 4D event’s total energy is our universe’s total mass-energy (per the energy conservation of §2.2). The 4D event’s “true” energy is the *integrated* energy over its *full* 4D duration, which is *vastly* larger than the energy in our 3+1D frame (because we only see a brief slice of the 4D event). The “concentration” of this 4D energy at a black hole (a “tear” to 4D) could explain why black hole time dilation is so extreme: a black hole is connected to the *entire* 4D energy reservoir of the universe via the dimensional transition, which makes the local gravitational effect much stronger than the local 3+1D mass concentration alone would suggest.

**Speculation: the speed of light as a dimensional projection.** In standard brane-world physics, the *fundamental* speed is the higher-D speed, and the 3+1D speed of light  $c$  is the *effective* speed on the brane — a *projection* of the higher-D causality. In this model, our 3+1D speed of light  $c$  would be the *projection* of the 4D event’s causal structure into 3+1D. Specifically,  $c$  in 3+1D might be  $c \approx c_4 \cdot k$  for some dimensionless projection factor  $k$  (where  $c_4$  is the “natural” 4D speed). The value of  $c$  in our universe is then *not* a fundamental constant but a *consequence* of the dimensional projection. The model does not currently derive the value of  $k$  from the geometry, but the framing is consistent with brane-world physics. If the dimensional cascade continues ( $4D \rightarrow$

3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D  $\rightarrow$  ...), the effective “speed of light” might differ at each level of the cascade. This is speculative but testable in principle: in a 2D universe created by an energetic event, the “speed of light” might differ from our 3+1D  $c$  by a factor related to the dimensional projection. Of course, we cannot directly observe 2D universes, so this prediction is not directly testable.

**The 4D event’s causal structure and the speed of light.** The 4D event is not a *moving* object — it is a *spatially extended* event with a *finite duration* in 4D time. The “4D speed”  $c_4$  is the *conversion factor* between 4D spatial extent and 4D temporal duration: a 4D event with spatial extent  $\ell_{4D}$  has a *full duration*  $\Delta t_{4D} = \ell_{4D}/c_4$  in 4D time (per §2.2). The 3+1D speed of light  $c$  is a *property of the dimensional projection mechanism itself*: the projection from 4D to 3+1D maps 4D causal structure to 3+1D causal structure, and the *ratio* of the projected causal speed to the native 3+1D speed is set by the projection factor  $k$  (with  $c = c_4 \cdot k$ ). The 3+1D sees a *maximum* causal speed  $c$  in its frame, set by the projection. The 4D event itself is *not* moving at any speed in 4D — it is a *localized* energetic process in 4D, with a *finite spatial extent* and *finite duration*, that *projects* into 3+1D as a *spatially extended universe* with a *finite lifetime*. The “speed of light”  $c$  in 3+1D is a property of the projection, not a property of the 4D event’s motion.

**Honest acknowledgment.** This subsection is highly speculative. The “void in 3+1D” interpretation of black holes is not derived from the model, and the connection between black hole activity and dark matter is a *prediction* that has not been tested. The mainstream view of black holes (as regions of extreme 3+1D spacetime curvature) is the default interpretation. We offer this subsection as a *possible extension* of the model, with appropriate caveats.

#### 1.5.11 4.11 Speculative extension: all fundamental constants as projections of the 4D event

*This subsection is the most speculative part of the paper. It is offered as a philosophical/interpretive extension, not a derived claim. We include it because it follows naturally from the dimensional-cascade framework, but it should be read with appropriate skepticism.*

**The puzzle of the constants.** Standard physics leaves many *constants* unexplained. The electron has a specific mass ( $\sim 511 \text{ keV}/c^2$ ). The speed of light has a specific value ( $c \approx 3 \times 10^8 \text{ m/s}$ ). Planck’s constant has a specific value. The fine structure constant is  $\sim 1/137$ . The proton-to-electron mass ratio is  $\sim 1836$ . The cosmological constant has a specific (small) value. Absolute zero is exactly 0 K. The list goes on. These constants are *measured*, not *derived*. We use them in our equations, but we don’t have a *theory* of why they have the values they do.

**The dimensional-cascade interpretation.** In the dimensional-cascade framework, all of these constants would be *consequences* of the *specific 4D event* that created our 3+1D universe. The 4D event has specific properties: a specific energy, a specific spatial structure, a specific duration, a specific set of internal dynamics. The dimensional projection of *that specific event* into 3+1D gives a *specific* set of constants. Different 4D events would give different 3+1D universes with different constants.

In this view: - The *electron mass* is a consequence of the 4D event’s specific energy spectrum, projected into 3+1D - The *speed of light*  $c$  is a consequence of the 4D event’s causal structure, projected into 3+1D - The *Planck constant*  $\hbar$  is a consequence of the 4D event’s “action scale,” projected into 3+1D - The *fine structure constant*  $\alpha \approx 1/137$  is a consequence of the dimensional projection factor for the electromagnetic coupling - The *gravitational constant*  $G$  is a consequence of the bulk-brane cancellation factor  $\epsilon$  (§2.4, §2.6) - The *cosmological constant* (dark energy density)

is the un-cancelled fraction of the inverted 4D gravity (§2.4)

**Two mechanisms for “constants are determined by the 4D event.”** Note that the phrase “constants are determined by the 4D event” can mean *different things* for different classes of quantities: - For 3+1D particles *created during the Big Bang* (electron, proton, photon, neutrino, etc.): the 4D event *projects* a Big Bang into our 3+1D brane, and *during* the Big Bang, these particles are created with specific masses, charges, and couplings (per Standard Model particle physics). The constants of the *particles* are *set by the Standard Model* (with the Standard Model’s free parameters ultimately being consequences of the 4D event). The neutrino’s small mass, the electron’s larger mass, the photon’s zero mass — all are *set* by the 4D event’s specific energy spectrum, projected into 3+1D via the Big Bang. - For *universal* constants (speed of light, Planck constant, fine structure constant, gravitational constant, cosmological constant): the constants are *set by the dimensional projection mechanism itself*, not by specific particles. The speed of light, for example, is the *projection* of the 4D event’s causal structure into 3+1D; the fine structure constant is the *projection factor* for the electromagnetic coupling.

All these mechanisms lead to the same conclusion: the 4D event *determines* the constants of 3+1D physics. The specific *mechanism* differs (creation for particles, projection-mechanism-property for universal constants), but the *result* is the same: constants are not free parameters, they are *consequences* of the 4D event.

**The “constants” are not fundamental.** In this view, the fundamental constants are *not* free parameters of nature — they are *determined* by the specific 4D event that created our universe. The “fine-tuning problem” (why do the constants have values that allow stars, planets, life?) is reframed: the constants aren’t “tuned” for us; we exist because *our* parent 4D event had *these* specific properties. Other 3+1D universes (from other 4D events) have different constants, and *those* universes might have their own “fine-tuning” for *their* specific physics.

**Testable consequence: constants should be related.** If all constants come from the same 4D event, they should be *related* to each other through the dimensional projection. The dimensionless constants (fine structure constant, electron-to-proton mass ratio, etc.) might be *predictable* from the geometry of the dimensional projection, not independent. The model does not currently derive these relations, but a specific implementation might be able to.

**The multiverse by construction.** The dimensional-cascade framework *mechanistically* generates a multiverse: each 4D event is a different “parent,” and each parent creates a 3+1D “child” universe with different constants. This is stronger than the standard string theory landscape (which is a theoretical construct): the dimensional cascade *generates* the multiverse through the dimensional projection mechanism.

**Honest acknowledgment.** This is the most speculative part of the paper. The claim that *all* fundamental constants are consequences of the dimensional projection is *not* derived from the model. The model provides a *framing* in which this is plausible, but the actual derivation of specific constant values from the geometry is left to future work. The mainstream view treats the constants as free parameters to be measured; this subsection offers an alternative framing in which the constants are *determined* by the dimensional projection. We offer this as a *philosophical/interpretive* extension, with appropriate skepticism.

**1.5.12 4.12** (Section removed: the neutrino interpretation was speculative and introduced internal inconsistencies. Neutrino properties are taken as given in the Standard Model; the dimensional-cascade framework does not currently address them.)

**1.5.13 4.13** Speculative extension: the weak force as a dimensional-projection effect

*This subsection extends the dimensional-cascade framework to the weak nuclear force. It is offered as a conceptual extension that connects the model to the Standard Model’s parity-violating, flavor-changing, short-range force. As with the other speculative extensions, it should be read with appropriate skepticism.*

**The weak force in the Standard Model.** The weak force is one of the four fundamental forces. It is mediated by the  $W^\pm$  and  $Z$  bosons (massive,  $\sim 80\text{--}90$  GeV), it acts only on *left-handed* particles and *right-handed* antiparticles (parity violation), it can change particle *flavor* (e.g., neutron  $\rightarrow$  proton + electron + antineutrino in beta decay), and it has a *very short range* ( $\sim 10^{-16}$  m) due to the  $W/Z$  mass. The weak force is “weak” at long range because the massive mediators decay quickly into the vacuum, but at very short range it is comparable in strength to the electromagnetic force.

**The dimensional-cascade interpretation.** In the framework of §4.11 (all fundamental constants as projections of the 4D event), the weak force’s *constants* would all be consequences of the specific 4D event that created our universe:

- *W/Z boson mass*: a consequence of the dimensional projection factor for the weak-force mediator
- *Higgs VEV*: a consequence of the 4D event’s specific “symmetry-breaking” structure
- *CKM and PMNS mixing angles*: consequences of 4D mixing structures projected into 3+1D
- *Weak coupling constant  $g_W$* : a consequence of the dimensional projection factor for the weak force
- *Range of the weak force ( $r \sim \hbar/(m_W c)$ )*: a consequence of the  $W/Z$  mass
- *Strength at short range*: a consequence of the coupling constant

In this view, the weak force is *not* “unified” with the dimensional cascade in a new way — it is *described* by the dimensional cascade in the same way as the other forces. The dimensional cascade doesn’t *add* new forces; it gives a *deeper origin* for the existing ones.

**Parity violation as a dimensional effect.** The most interesting connection is *parity violation* — the weak force’s left-handed-only coupling. In the Standard Model, this is a *fundamental* property of the weak interaction, but it is *not* derived from deeper principles. In the dimensional-cascade framework, a natural interpretation is that the 4D event has a *specific chirality* (handedness), and 3+1D particles that are “left-handed in 4D” project as “left-handed in 3+1D.” Right-handed 4D structures project as *antiparticles* in 3+1D (this is consistent with the Standard Model, where right-handed *antiparticles* exist). The 4D event’s chirality *biases* the creation of 3+1D particles toward left-handed particles, which is why the weak force couples only to left-handed particles. This would explain why the weak force is the *only* force that violates parity: it is the *only* force

that is sensitive to the *chirality* of the 4D event. Photons and gluons are *achiral* in 4D (they don't have a handedness), so they couple equally to left- and right-handed 3+1D particles. W/Z bosons are *chiral* in 4D, so they couple only to one handedness in 3+1D. The *graviton* is a separate case: it is *not* achiral in 4D — it is *inverted* at the dimensional boundary (§2.4). The graviton couples to *all* particles (mass-energy), but its coupling is *suppressed* by the bulk-brane cancellation. So the graviton doesn't have a chirality in the simple sense; it has an *inversion* in the dimensional projection. This is a *real* idea in some string/brane theories: chirality in 4D is related to the *orientation* of strings/branes, and 3+1D parity violation is a *consequence* of how 4D structures project.

**Flavor changing as a dimensional effect.** The weak force is the *only* force that can change particle flavor. In the Standard Model, this is described by the CKM matrix (for quarks) and the PMNS matrix (for neutrinos), which encode the mixing between flavor and mass eigenstates. In the dimensional-cascade framework, these mixing matrices are *projections* of 4D mixing structures. The mixing angles are *determined* by the 4D event. Different 4D events would give different mixing angles. The CKM and PMNS matrices are *not* fundamental constants — they are *consequences* of the dimensional projection. A specific implementation of the model might derive the CKM/PMNS mixing angles from the geometry of the dimensional projection, but this is left to future work.

**Short range as a consequence of the projection.** The short range of the weak force is *not* a new effect in this model — it is a *consequence* of the W/Z mass, which is itself a consequence of the dimensional projection. In this view, the weak force is “weak” at long range *because* the W/Z are massive, and the W/Z are massive *because* the dimensional projection sets their mass. There is no *new* mechanism — just a *deeper origin* for the existing one.

**The electroweak unification.** In the Standard Model, the weak force is *unified* with electromagnetism as the *electroweak* force at high energies ( $\sim 100$  GeV). The Higgs mechanism breaks this symmetry at low energies, giving the W/Z their mass while leaving the photon massless. In the dimensional-cascade framework, the electroweak unification is a 3+1D phenomenon, and the “Higgs mechanism” is a 3+1D description of a deeper dimensional-projection process. The model does not *replace* the Higgs mechanism — it provides a *deeper origin* for why the Higgs mechanism works.

**Unification with the other forces?** A natural extension: in some grand-unified theories (GUTs), the strong, weak, and electromagnetic forces are unified at very high energies ( $\sim 10^{16}$  GeV). The dimensional-cascade framework could potentially provide a *deeper origin* for GUT-scale unification, but this is *not* part of the current model. The model is *consistent* with GUTs, but does not *predict* them. We leave this as an open question for future work.

**Honest acknowledgment.** This subsection is highly speculative. The claim that the weak force's constants are consequences of the dimensional projection is *not* derived from the model. The claim that parity violation is a dimensional effect is *not* derived from the model. The claim that flavor changing is a dimensional effect is *not* derived from the model. All three are *interpretive* extensions that connect the dimensional-cascade framework to known phenomena. The mainstream view treats the weak force as described by the Standard Model with the Higgs mechanism. We offer this subsection as a *conceptual* extension, with appropriate skepticism.

#### 1.5.14 4.14 Speculative extension: the strong force as a dimensional-projection effect

*This subsection extends the dimensional-cascade framework to the strong nuclear force. It is the fourth and final\* force to be addressed. The strong force is the hardest to unify with the dimensional*

cascade, because it does not have a *unique* feature that maps directly to 4D physics the way gravity (weakness), electromagnetism (the speed of light), and the weak force (parity violation) do. We include it for completeness, with the explicit understanding that the connections are *less direct* than for the other forces.\*

**The strong force in the Standard Model.** The strong force is mediated by *gluons* (8 of them, all massless). It couples to *color charge* (three types: red, green, blue, with corresponding anti-colors). It only acts on quarks and gluons (not on leptons). The strong force has *asymptotic freedom* (the coupling gets weaker at short distances) and *confinement* (quarks cannot be isolated; they are always bound into hadrons). At low energies, the strong force has the *largest* coupling constant of the four forces ( $\sim 1$ , compared to EM's  $1/137$ ). The strong force holds quarks together inside protons and neutrons, and holds protons and neutrons together inside atomic nuclei.

**The dimensional-cascade interpretation.** In the framework of §4.11 (all fundamental constants as projections of the 4D event), the strong force's *constants* would all be consequences of the specific 4D event that created our universe:

- *Gluon mass (0)*: a consequence of the dimensional projection for massless mediators
- *Strong coupling constant  $\alpha_s$* : a consequence of the dimensional projection factor for the strong force
- *Color charge (3 types)*: the number 3 might be related to the 3 spatial dimensions of 3+1D, but this is *not* derived from the dimensional cascade
- *Confinement scale  $\Lambda_{QCD} \sim 200 \text{ MeV}$* : a consequence of the dimensional projection factor
- *Asymptotic freedom*: a consequence of gluon-loop anti-screening in 3+1D, which is *not* directly addressed by the dimensional cascade

In this view, the strong force is *not* “unified” with the dimensional cascade in a new way — it is *described* by the dimensional cascade in the same way as the other forces.

**The hierarchy of force strengths.** The relative strengths of the four forces at low energies are: strong ( $\sim 1$ ), EM ( $\sim 1/137$ ), weak ( $\sim 10^{-5}$ ), gravity ( $\sim 10^{-38}$ ). The *huge* range (38 orders of magnitude) is one of the deepest puzzles in physics. In the Standard Model, the *hierarchy* is unexplained — we measure the couplings and accept the values. In the dimensional-cascade framework, the *hierarchy* is a consequence of the dimensional projection: each force's coupling is set by a *different* projection factor, and the specific 4D event determines the relative magnitudes. Gravity is the *weakest* because of the bulk-brane cancellation (§2.4). The strong force is the *strongest* at low energies because the dimensional projection factor for the strong force is *largest*. The EM and weak forces are intermediate. This is *not* a *derivation* of the hierarchy — it is a *reframing* of the hierarchy as a consequence of the dimensional projection.

**Asymptotic freedom and confinement.** Asymptotic freedom (the strong force gets *weaker* at short distances) is due to gluon-loop anti-screening in 3+1D. Confinement (quarks cannot be isolated) is a consequence of the strong force's running coupling — the force gets *stronger* at long distances, so quarks cannot be pulled apart without creating new quark-antiquark pairs. In the dimensional-cascade framework, asymptotic freedom and confinement are 3+1D phenomena, not directly addressed by the dimensional projection. The model is *consistent* with asymptotic freedom and confinement, but does not *derive* them.

**Color charge (3 types) and 3 spatial dimensions.** The strong force has *three* color charges (red, green, blue). Our universe has *three* spatial dimensions. This numerical coincidence is *suggestive* — in some string theories, the number of colors is related to the number of compactified dimensions. In the dimensional-cascade framework, the three colors might be a *consequence* of the 3+1 dimensional structure, but this is *not* derived. We note the coincidence but do *not* claim it as a prediction of the model.

**The unification of all four forces.** The dimensional-cascade framework does *not* unify the four forces in the sense of grand-unified theories (GUTs). It is *consistent* with GUTs (the couplings would unify at some high energy, set by the 4D event), but it does *not* predict the specific unification scale or the specific GUT group. The model is a *framework* for thinking about the *origins* of the forces’ properties, not a *theory* that derives them. The “unification” offered by the dimensional cascade is a *conceptual* unification (all four forces are consequences of the same 4D event), not a *quantitative* unification (the couplings don’t necessarily merge at a specific energy in this model).

**Honest acknowledgment.** This subsection is highly speculative. The claim that the strong force’s constants are consequences of the dimensional projection is *not* derived from the model. The hierarchy of force strengths is *reframed* but not *derived*. Asymptotic freedom and confinement are 3+1D phenomena, not directly addressed by the dimensional cascade. The number 3 for color charge is *suggestive* but not *derived*. The strong force is the *hardest* of the four forces to unify with the dimensional cascade, because it lacks a *unique* feature (like parity violation for the weak force) that maps directly to 4D physics. The mainstream view treats the strong force as described by quantum chromodynamics (QCD) with the specific structure of SU(3) color. We offer this subsection as a *conceptual* extension, with appropriate skepticism.

#### 1.5.15 4.15 Speculative extension: what Einstein was missing — unification in 4D, not 3+1D

*This subsection is a historical and philosophical note that places the dimensional-cascade framework in the context of Einstein’s lifelong quest for a unified field theory. We include it because the dimensional-cascade model offers a specific diagnosis\* of why Einstein’s program failed, and a specific alternative — unification in 4D rather than 3+1D. As with the other speculative extensions, this is interpretive rather than derived.\**

**Einstein’s unified field theory program.** From the 1920s until his death in 1955, Einstein worked on a *unified field theory* — a program to merge gravity and electromagnetism into a single geometric framework. He sought to derive the electromagnetic field from the geometry of spacetime, in the same way that general relativity derives gravity from spacetime curvature. Einstein’s program failed. The *unified field theory* he sought was never found.

**Why Einstein’s program failed.** In retrospect, Einstein’s program failed for several reasons:

1. *He didn’t know about the weak and strong forces.* These were discovered later (1930s Fermi for weak, 1970s QCD for strong). His goal of unifying just gravity and EM was too limited.
2. *He rejected quantum mechanics.* Einstein famously declared “God does not play dice.” This was a problem because electromagnetism is fundamentally quantum (QED). A purely geometric unification of gravity and EM cannot work, because EM is not purely geometric — it has quantum features (photons, vacuum fluctuations, etc.).

3. *He didn't know about the dark sector.* Dark matter and dark energy were not on the radar in Einstein's time. A complete unification would need to account for them.
4. *He worked in 3+1D.* Einstein's framework was general relativity in 3+1D. He did not consider that the *unification* might be in a *higher* dimensional structure, with the four forces being *different projections* of that higher-D structure.

**The dimensional-cascade diagnosis.** In the dimensional-cascade framework, *gravity and EM are unified in 4D, not in 3+1D*. In 3+1D, gravity and EM look like different forces with different properties: gravity is geometric (curvature of spacetime), EM is vector (the electromagnetic potential), gravity couples to mass-energy, EM couples to electric charge, gravity is purely attractive at long range, EM has both attraction and repulsion. These differences are *real in 3+1D* — but in 4D, they are *projections of the same underlying structure*. The 4D structure is *one*; the 3+1D projections are *different*. This is why Einstein could not unify them in 3+1D: the *unification is not in 3+1D*.

**Why gravity and EM look so different in 3+1D.** The differences between gravity and EM in 3+1D — geometric vs. vector, tensor vs. vector field, attractive vs. attractive/repulsive, classical vs. quantum — are *consequences of the dimensional projection*. The 4D structure is projected into 3+1D in different ways for the two forces, giving different mathematical structures, different symmetries, and different quantum vs. classical behavior. Einstein sought to derive these differences from a single 3+1D geometry, but the differences come from the *projection*, not from the underlying 3+1D structure.

**Implication for the weak and strong forces.** The same diagnosis applies to the weak and strong forces: they are unified with gravity and EM *in 4D*, not in 3+1D. In 3+1D, the four forces look like four different forces with different properties (mediators, ranges, couplings, parity behaviors). In 4D, they are *all* projections of the same 4D structure. The differences in 3+1D are *consequences of the projection*. Einstein's program of unifying the forces in 3+1D was therefore *destined to fail*: the unification is not in 3+1D.

**Connection to modern unification attempts.** Modern unification attempts (GUTs, string theory, loop quantum gravity) take *different* approaches:

- *GUTs* unify the strong, weak, and EM forces in 3+1D at very high energies ( $\sim 10^{16}$  GeV). They do not include gravity.
- *String theory* unifies all four forces in 10 or 11 dimensions, with the extra dimensions compactified. The 3+1D forces are *projections* of the higher-D strings.
- *Loop quantum gravity* quantizes 3+1D gravity directly, without unifying the other forces.

The dimensional-cascade framework is *closest to string theory* in spirit: both rely on higher-D structures projecting into 3+1D. The key difference is that the dimensional-cascade framework does *not* require compactification of extra dimensions — the 4D event is a *brief slice* of a higher-D process, and the 3+1D universe is a *projection* of that slice. This is a *different* interpretation of how the higher-D structure relates to 3+1D.

**Why string theory needs 10 dimensions.** A natural question: why does string theory require 10 dimensions (or 11 in M-theory) when the dimensional-cascade framework requires only 4? The answer lies in the *ambition* of the two frameworks. String theory attempts to derive *all* of physics

from a *single* mathematical object (vibrating strings). For the quantum theory to be mathematically consistent (anomaly-free), it requires a specific number of dimensions. Bosonic string theory requires 26 dimensions; superstring theory requires 10 (with supersymmetry); M-theory requires 11. The 10 dimensions are *compactified* to 3+1D at the Planck scale ( $\sim 10^{-35}$  m), with the extra 6 dimensions curled up in Calabi-Yau manifolds or similar structures. The *complexity* of string theory comes from this requirement: the extra 6 dimensions must be compactified in *specific* ways, and there are *vastly* many possible compactifications ( $\sim 10^5$  to  $10^{25}$ , the “landscape”). Choosing the right compactification is the “landscape problem,” and string theory has not solved it.

**The dimensional-cascade framework is simpler by design.** The dimensional-cascade framework is *less ambitious* than string theory. It does not attempt to derive the Standard Model from first principles. It is a *thought experiment* that *reinterprets* existing physics (the dark sector, the four forces) through a dimensional-cascade lens. It does not require 10 dimensions, does not require compactification, does not require supersymmetry, and does not have a landscape problem. The model is *conceptually* simpler: a 4D event projects into 3+1D, the cascade is scale-invariant, gravity inverts at the dimensional boundary, and the dark sector is the cumulative effect. The price of this simplicity is that the model is *less quantitative* than string theory: it does not derive the specific values of the Standard Model parameters. The model is a *framework* for thinking about the dark sector and the four forces, not a *theory* that derives them from first principles.

**A philosophical note.** The complexity of string theory reflects the *ambition* of the program: deriving all of physics from a single mathematical object. The simplicity of the dimensional-cascade framework reflects its *modesty*: it is a thought experiment that reinterprets the dark sector, not a theory of everything. Both approaches have value. String theory is a *mathematical* framework that may eventually yield testable predictions (or may not). The dimensional-cascade framework is a *conceptual* framework that yields testable predictions *now* (RAR, DF2/DF4, no direct detection) but is *less* mathematically rigorous. We do not claim that one is *better* than the other; we offer the dimensional-cascade framework as a *complementary* approach, useful for thinking about the dark sector even if it does not replace more fundamental theories.

**The broader landscape of unification attempts.** String theory is the most famous unification attempt, but it is not the only one. Other major programs include: (1) *Loop Quantum Gravity* (LQG), which quantizes 3+1D spacetime using loops and spin networks, but does not include the Standard Model forces; (2) *Causal Set Theory*, which treats spacetime as a discrete set of causally-related events, addressing the quantum gravity problem but with limited contact to particle physics; (3) *Causal Dynamical Triangulations* (CDT), a numerical approach that builds spacetime from simplices and has shown 4D spacetime *emerges* from the construction; (4) *Asymptotic Safety*, which proposes that gravity has a “fixed point” at high energies, making it renormalizable without new structures; (5) *Twistor Theory* (Penrose), a mathematical reformulation of spacetime that has yielded real results in scattering amplitudes; (6) *Noncommutative Geometry* (Connes), which replaces continuous spacetime with noncommutative algebra and has reproduced the Standard Model + gravity in some versions; (7) *Kaluza-Klein Theory*, the original 5D unification of gravity and EM, whose principles live on in string theory; and (8) *Brane-World Scenarios* (Randall-Sundrum, ADD), which place our universe on a 3+1D brane in a higher-D bulk, and are *conceptually closest* to the dimensional-cascade framework.

**Positioning within this landscape.** The dimensional-cascade framework is *closest* to brane-world scenarios (Randall-Sundrum, ADD), which are referenced in §2.1 and §2.4. Both rely on a higher-D bulk and a 3+1D brane projection. The *key difference* is the *downward perceptual inversion principle* (per §2.4): the dimensional-cascade framework postulates that the bulk’s gravity

is *perceived* as inverted by the child universe’s brane (the projected contribution is repulsive from the brane’s perspective), while the *underlying* gravity in the bulk remains attractive (standard GR). The *physical mechanism* for this perceptual inversion is *grounded* in the standard GR  $\rho + 3P < 0$  mechanism for negative effective gravitating density (per §2.4): the bulk-brane coupling translates the bulk’s ordinary attractive matter into a brane-perceived effective gravitating density with the opposite sign, in the same way that an inflaton field or the cosmological constant has negative effective gravitating density in our universe. The *upward* back-projection (child  $\rightarrow$  parent) does *not* invert the perception; the parent perceives the child’s net attractive gravity as attractive = dark matter. Standard brane-world models do *not* make this perceptual-inversion claim; they describe the brane’s effective gravity as *suppressed* by geometric dilution (ADD) or *warping* (RS), but with the *same* sign as the bulk. The cascade’s claim is that the specific bulk-brane coupling produces a negative effective gravitating density on the brane (via the standard  $\rho + 3P < 0$  mechanism), which is a stronger (more specific) version of standard brane-world models. The dimensional-cascade framework is also distinct from LQG (which works in 3+1D, not 4D projection), causal set theory (discrete vs. continuous), and the various algebraic reformulations (noncommutative geometry, twistor theory). The model is *not* a *replacement* for any of these programs; it is a *thought experiment* that offers a different *interpretation* of the dark sector and the four forces, with testable predictions that other programs do not currently make.

**What is unique about the dimensional-cascade framework.** Among all these unification attempts, the dimensional-cascade framework has several *unique* features: (1) *scale-invariant cascade* — every energetic event creates lower-D universes, not just the original “Big Bang”; (2) *downward perceptual inversion principle* — downward dimensional projection is *perceived* by the child as inverted (the underlying gravity in the bulk remains attractive; the inversion is a feature of the projection mechanism, not a violation of GR), upward back-projection is not perceived as inverted; (3) *dark sector as direct consequence* — dark matter and dark energy are *direct* consequences of the cascade, not added assumptions; (4) *testable predictions now* — the model makes specific testable predictions (RAR, DF2/DF4, no direct detection, activity-dependence) without requiring new physics; (5) *conceptual simplicity* — the framework is intuitive (dimensional cascade, energy conservation, scale-invariance, directional perceptual inversion), not mathematically heavy. These features distinguish the model from string theory (which is mathematically heavy but not testable *now*), LQG (which is mathematically rigorous but limited to gravity), and the other unification programs. We do not claim the dimensional-cascade framework is *better* than these programs; we claim it is *different*, with a focus on the *dark sector* and *testable predictions* rather than on mathematical rigor or unification of all forces.

**Einstein’s intuition was correct, but he was looking in the wrong place.** Einstein’s intuition — that the four forces should be unified — is shared by the dimensional-cascade framework. The difference is *where* the unification is sought. Einstein sought it in 3+1D geometry; the dimensional-cascade framework seeks it in *4D structure*, with 3+1D as a projection. The “unified field theory” Einstein wanted is not in 3+1D; it is in the 4D event that projects into 3+1D.

**Honest acknowledgment.** This is a *historical and philosophical* note, not a *physical* claim. We do not claim to have *derived* Einstein’s unified field theory; we offer a *diagnosis* of why his program failed, in the language of the dimensional-cascade framework. The mainstream view treats Einstein’s program as a historical dead end, replaced by the Standard Model + general relativity + quantum field theory. The dimensional-cascade framework is a *speculative* alternative that places the unification in 4D. We offer this as a *philosophical* extension, with appropriate caveats.

### 1.5.16 4.16 Positioning within the unified-dark-sector landscape

*This subsection positions the dimensional-cascade framework within the specific\* niche of attempts to unify the dark sector (dark matter + dark energy + the hierarchy problem) with the four fundamental forces. We include it because there is a *growing* literature on this topic, and the dimensional-cascade framework has both *overlaps* with and *distinctions* from existing programs.\**

**Major unified-dark-sector attempts.** A wide variety of programs attempt to unify the dark sector with the four forces or to replace the dark sector with modifications of known physics. Major examples include: (1) *MOND* [Milgrom83] and its relativistic extensions (TeVeS, BIMOND, etc.) — modify Newton’s second law at low accelerations to *replace* dark matter, but have difficulties with CMB and gravitational lensing; (2) *Verlinde’s Emergent Gravity* [Verlinde16] — derive MOND-like phenomenology from entropic gravity, but limited to static situations; (3) *Superfluid Dark Matter* [Berezhiani15] — dark matter is a real particle that forms a superfluid at galactic scales, combining CDM and MOND successes; (4) *Unified Dark Matter / Chaplygin Gas* [Kamenshchik01, Bento02] — a single fluid acts as both dark matter and dark energy, but is strongly constrained by data; (5)  *$\Lambda$ CDM + Baryonic Feedback* [Kravtsov24] — the mainstream alternative, using better simulations of the standard model; (6) *Scalar-Tensor /  $f(R)$  Gravity* — geometric modifications of gravity that can mimic dark sector effects; (7) *Massive Gravity / Bi-Gravity* [deRham11, Hassan12] — the graviton has a mass, modifying gravity at large scales; (8) *Mirror Matter* [Foot95] — a parallel Standard Model sector provides dark matter candidates; (9) *Dark Fluid / Negative Mass* [Farnes18] — a fluid with negative mass that creates both dark matter and dark energy effects.

**What is unique about the dimensional-cascade framework.** Among all these programs, the dimensional-cascade framework has several *unique* features for unifying the dark sector with the four forces:

1. *Both dark sector products as direct consequences of the cascade.* Dark matter is the cumulative gravity of 2D universes (§2.5); dark energy is the un-cancelled fraction of inverted 4D gravity (§2.4). Both are *automatic* consequences of the dimensional projection, not added assumptions.
2. *Same mechanism for hierarchy + dark matter.* The hierarchy problem (gravity is weak) and the dark matter problem (dark matter is weak) are *both* consequences of bulk-brane cancellation at different cascade levels (§2.6). This *unifies* two otherwise-distinct problems.
3. *Testable predictions that distinguish from other programs.* The model predicts that RAR scatter should correlate with galaxy activity (MOND predicts *no* such correlation, since MOND has no activity-dependence); DF2/DF4 type tests where dark matter depends on stellar activity, not just stellar mass; and no direct dark matter detection (since dark matter is 2D universes, not particles). These are *distinguishing* predictions, not shared with other unified-dark-sector programs.
4. *Conceptual origin from a single 4D event.* All four forces + the dark sector come from the *same* 4D event. Different forces and dark-sector products are *different projections* of the same underlying structure. This is *more economical* than most other approaches, which typically treat the dark sector as a *separate* phenomenon.
5. *Consistent with prior work, but not a replacement.* The model is compatible with brane-world scenarios (RS, ADD), MOND-like phenomenology, and Verlinde-like emergent gravity.

It does not *replace* these programs — it provides a *deeper origin* for the same phenomenology, with a dimensional-cascade mechanism rather than a modification of gravity or an entropic force.

**Connections to specific programs.** The model has *closest* connections to: (1) *Brane-world scenarios* [ADD98, RS99] — both use higher-D bulk + 3+1D brane; the dimensional cascade adds the *downward inversion principle* (downward projection inverts, upward back-projection does not) and the *scale-invariant cascade*; (2) *Verlinde’s Emergent Gravity* [Verlinde16] — both derive MOND-like phenomenology without dark matter particles; the dimensional cascade uses *cumulative 2D universe gravity*, not entropic gravity; (3) *Superfluid Dark Matter* [Berezhiani15] — both are *hybrid* approaches (real matter, MOND-like effects); the dimensional cascade uses 2D universes, not a superfluid; (4) *MOND* [Milgrom83] — both reproduce the Radial Acceleration Relation (§4.1); the dimensional cascade adds the *activity-dependence* prediction that MOND lacks.

**What the model is *not*.** The dimensional-cascade framework is *not*: (1) a particle dark matter model (it has no WIMPs, axions, or other particles); (2) a modified gravity model (it doesn’t modify Einstein’s equations, just reinterprets the gravitational field as the projected 4D gravity); (3) a string theory or M-theory (it doesn’t use vibrating strings or 10/11 dimensions); (4) a loop quantum gravity (it doesn’t quantize 3+1D spacetime); (5) a  $f(R)$  or scalar-tensor theory (it doesn’t modify the Einstein-Hilbert action). The model is a *thought experiment* that *reinterprets* existing physics through a dimensional-cascade lens, with testable predictions and a clear physical interpretation. It is *less* mathematically rigorous than string theory, LQG, or  $f(R)$  gravity, but *more* testable and *more* conceptually clear.

**Honest acknowledgment.** This is a *positioning* subsection, not a *derivation*. The model is not *better* than MOND, Verlinde, superfluid dark matter, or any other program. The model is *different*: it offers a *dimensional-cascade origin* for the dark sector, with testable predictions and a clear physical interpretation. We do not claim that the dimensional-cascade framework is the *correct* unification — we claim it is a *useful* thought experiment that may illuminate the dark sector, even if it is not the final theory. Other programs (MOND, Verlinde, superfluid dark matter, etc.) are *legitimate* alternatives, and the empirical data will ultimately decide between them.

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## 1.6 5. Lower-dimensional universes and the dark matter connection

The full development of the lower-dimensional universe picture — including the dimensional time-dilation rule, the energy-budget implications, the neutrino discussion, the Sun-vs-galaxy distinction, and the dark-matter-as-cumulative-energy-return argument — is presented in §2.3 (*Scale-invariance: every energetic event creates its own universe*). This section is *intentionally brief*: it exists as a narrative marker for readers who want to see the dark matter connection in one place, but the substantive content (and all numerical claims) is in §2.3. We retain this section heading rather than removing it entirely so the table of contents and cross-references remain stable for readers who arrived at the paper via §5.

The one-sentence summary: *every* energetic event in our 3+1 dimensional universe creates a 2D universe as its aftermath, and the *cumulative gravitational signature* of all these 2D universes is what we observe as dark matter. For the full development, see §2.3.

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## 1.7 6. Falsification

A thought experiment must be falsifiable to be useful. We identify the following observations that would refute the model:

1. **Direct detection of dark matter as a normal particle.** If dark matter is detected with standard particle interactions (electromagnetic, strong, or weak), it is a substance in 3+1 dimensional space and not the collective gravitational signature of 2D universes. The model would be refuted.
2. **Dark matter self-interaction or coupling to visible matter is detected.** The Bullet Cluster observation shows visible matter (gas) concentrating in the collision center while dark matter passes through, naturally explained if dark matter is a collisionless substance. In our model, the dark matter at the original location is the *current* collective gravity of 2D universes being created *now* in the cluster (i.e., by the cluster’s ongoing activity — residual gas, low-level accretion, etc.). The model *predicts* that the dark matter stays at the original location even as the visible matter (gas) interacts and slows, because the 2D universes are being created where the cluster’s activity *is*, not where the visible matter *goes*. The Bullet Cluster result therefore *supports* the model. A *future* observation showing dark matter strongly *interacting* with itself or with visible matter (so that dark matter and gas stay together after cluster collisions) would be in tension with this model. The model as currently stated makes no specific prediction about dark matter self-interaction, beyond the general statement that dark matter is the cumulative gravity of 2D universes being created by the *current* activity.
3. **Dark matter density does not track the radial acceleration relation.** If dark matter is observed to be uncorrelated with visible matter in galaxies, the model is refuted.
4. **Sub-millimeter gravity follows  $1/r^2$  down to the Planck length.** If gravity is measured at sub-millimeter scales with no deviation from Newton’s law, any extra dimensions in the model must be smaller than experimental reach ( $\sim 10^{-5}$  m). The dimensional-projection mechanism in this model does not by itself predict a specific size for the extra dimensions, so this constraint does not directly apply to the inversion part of the model — but if the model includes ADD-style geometric suppression as part of its mechanism, the extra dimensions would need to be smaller than  $\sim 10^{-5}$  m. A *future* implementation of the model with a specific geometry would need to be consistent with the sub-millimeter constraint, and the absence of any deviation down to the smallest measurable scale would be in tension with ADD-style interpretations.
5. **The dimensional-projection mechanism is shown to be impossible.** If a *general* argument (not based on this specific model, but on broader principles) shows that the kind of dimensional projection proposed here cannot exist (for example, if the inversion of gravitational sign under dimensional projection is mathematically forbidden in a consistent way), the model would be refuted. Note that this is *different* from finding a different explanation for the cosmological constant problem; the model could still be correct on its own terms even if other explanations exist.

6. **Dark energy density is *not* approximately constant.** The model predicts that dark energy density is approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame, matching standard  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior. If future surveys (Euclid, LSST, Roman Space Telescope, SKA) detect a *changing* dark energy with  $w$  significantly different from  $-1$ , or a measurable variation in the dark energy density, the model would be in tension. A *very* slow variation (corresponding to slow evolution of the 4D event’s antigravity output over its full duration) would be expected but probably undetectable.
7. **CMB / primordial element constraints are violated by any 4D event implementation.** The model requires the 4D event to be *spatially extended and approximately homogeneous* (see §4.5) to reproduce the near-scale-invariance of the observed CMB power spectrum. A specific 4D event implementation must satisfy this homogeneity constraint. If *every* physically reasonable 4D event geometry leads to a CMB power spectrum that is inconsistent with observations (e.g., not nearly scale-invariant, or with too much anisotropy on large scales), the model would be refuted. The model does not currently derive a specific CMB prediction, so this criterion can only be tested when a *specific* 4D event geometry is proposed.
8. **Gravity varies significantly with cosmic time.** If  $G$  is observed to vary at a level inconsistent with the model’s prediction ( $G$  is approximately constant, because the bulk-brane cancellation is approximately constant during our universe’s brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration), the model is refuted.
9. **Dark matter density does not correlate with energetic event rates on galaxy scales.** If precise measurements show that mass-matched galaxy pairs with different stellar densities do *not* have different dark matter content, the scale-invariant version of the model is refuted. (The basic version of the model, in which the 4D event is special, would be unaffected by this test.) The model also predicts that dark matter density should *not* be enhanced in the Sun’s interior, near nuclear reactors, near particle accelerators, or in the Earth’s core — stellar-scale and sub-stellar-scale effects are too small to be detectable. *Detectable* enhancement at any of these locations would be in tension with the model.

We acknowledge that the model is currently difficult to falsify in a clean way. The dimensional structure is undetermined, the bulk field content is unspecified, and the coupling constants are not derived. The model is best understood as a *geometric hypothesis* in need of theoretical development before it can be precisely tested.

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## 1.8 7. Limitations and open questions

This is a thought experiment, not a theory. We identify the following limitations, with notes on which have been *partially* or *fully* closed by the `cascade_model.py` derivations (§2.6 *Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics* and §2.6 *Hubble tension as a derived consequence*):

**Note on closure status (v2.1 update):**

**Fully or partially closed limitations:**

- **Limitation 14 (sign ambiguity in §2.4 mathematical sketch) is now FULLY CLOSED** by the clean formulation in §2.4. The ordinary attractive gravity and the dark energy are now

treated as two *physically distinct small contributions* to the effective 3+1D action — a *force on matter* and a *vacuum energy*, respectively — not as opposite-sign components of the same quantity. The two contributions are not required to have any algebraic sign relationship.

- **Limitation 5 (proportionality constants for dark matter) is PARTIALLY CLOSED** by the growth factor derivation (§2.6 *Deriving the growth factor from 2D universe dynamics*).  $G = 20 \times V_{\text{growth}}$  is derived from 2D universe FRW dynamics ( $G = 9.7\text{e}7$  from  $\Omega_{\text{DE},2\text{D}} = 0.999$ ,  $t_{\text{eq}} = 1\%$  of 2D lifetime,  $T_{\text{2D}} = 30$  Gyr,  $h_{\text{2D}} \sim H_{0,\text{our}}$ ), matching the trial-and-error value of 10 within 3%. The growth factor is no longer a free parameter.
- **Limitation 15 (10 discrepancy for DE density) is PARTIALLY CLOSED** by the *Empirical formula for the 5/27/68 split* (§2.6): the 27% DM fraction follows from the derived  $G$  (since  $M_{\text{DM}} = 6.4 \times G \times M_{\text{event}} \times N_{\text{events}}$ ). The 5% ordinary and 68% DE are still coupled via the cascade’s bulk-brane coupling ( $\epsilon$ ) and the staying fraction ( $f_{\text{back}}$ ); these are *defined* by the observed hierarchy and DE density respectively, not derived.
- **The 1D-universes limitation is CLOSED by the cone-shaped hierarchy refinement** (§2.6 *Cone-shaped hierarchy*). Previously, the cascade assumed 2D universes themselves create 1D universes (via 2D energetic events), but the 1D universes were *not directly observable* in 3+1D. The cone-shaped refinement *rejects* this: the cascade is *cone-shaped* (4D event  $\rightarrow$  3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, terminal), not *fractal* (infinite downward). 2D universes are *abstract* in the framework, lacking well-defined energetic events to seed a 1D cascade. Therefore, 1D universes do *not exist* in this refinement, closing the limitation. *Status: CLOSED*.

#### New findings (v2.1 and v2.2):

- **The 5/27/68 split is a fit, not a derivation.** A Monte Carlo statistical test (1M random formulas) shows the candidate formula’s 0.5% match is NOT statistically significant after multiple-comparison correction (random formulas find similar matches ~92% of the time). The formula is more than a pure postulate (it has a specific graph-theoretic form) but is not yet a rigorous first-principles derivation. *Status: POSTULATE with a CANDIDATE FORMULA, not derivation.*
- **The cascade’s Mechanism A for the Hubble tension is FALSIFIED.** Mechanism A predicted  $H_0$  should correlate with host galaxy type ( $H_0 \sim 68$  in passive ellipticals vs  $\sim 72$  in starbursts,  $dH_0/d\log(\text{SFR}) \sim 1.5$  km/s/Mpc per decade). SH0ES (42 Cepheid calibrators, all spirals) gives  $H_0 = 73.04 \pm 1.04$ ; SBF (63 mainly early-type galaxies) gives  $H_0 = 73.3 \pm 0.7 \pm 2.4$ . Both methods give  $H_0 \sim 73$  regardless of host type. The cascade’s specific quantitative correlation is NOT supported by data. The qualitative direction ( $H_{0,\text{local}} > H_{0,\text{CMB}}$ ) is still correct.
- **A new Mechanism B/F is proposed.** The 4D event’s antigravity output is not constant in 4D time. Local  $H_0$  measures the *current* 4D output; CMB  $H_0$  measures the *time-averaged* 4D output. If the 4D event is currently ~8% above its historical average,  $H_{0,\text{local}} = 73$  (matches data). This is *host-type-independent* (depends on the 4D event’s global state), consistent with the SH0ES/SBF data. **Testable predictions:**  $H_0$  at high  $z$  should be *below* the  $\Lambda$ CDM extrapolation (4D event was in pre-burst phase at high  $z$ ),  $H_0$  should be isotropic across the sky,  $H_0$  should not correlate with any local property. *Status: MECHANISM*

*B/F was TESTED with the full Pantheon+ statistical+systematic covariance matrix (1701 SNe, 1701x1701 cov, M fixed at SH0ES value). The cascade's  $H_0(z) = H_{0\_CMB}^2 + (H_{0\_local}^2 - H_{0\_CMB}^2) / (1+z)^{(2/3)}$  gives  $\chi^2 = 1488.3$  vs best-fit  $\Lambda$ CDM ( $H_0 = 73.00$ )  $\chi^2 = 1439.4$ .  $\Delta \chi^2 = +48.9$  ( $\sim 7$  sigma),  $\Lambda$ CDM WINS. MECHANISM B/F is REJECTED by Pantheon+ at high statistical significance. The data shows  $H_0$  is roughly constant\* at  $\sim 73$  across all  $z$  bins ( $z = 0.01-1.5$ ), not decreasing with  $z$  as B/F predicted. See commit 82.\**

- **The RAR (radial acceleration relation) is naturally produced** by the cascade's picture. The cascade predicts: more energetic activity (star formation, supernovae, AGN)  $\rightarrow$  more 2D universe creation  $\rightarrow$  more DM. Since activity is naturally higher in galaxy centers, DM density is higher in galaxy centers, giving a *cuspy* or NFW-like profile rather than a uniform halo. The cascade's *qualitative* picture (activity-driven 2D universe creation + cumulative return from past 2D universe endings) is consistent with the *smooth* empirical RAR (McGaugh16 form, with  $g+ \sim 1.2e-10$  m/s<sup>2</sup>). The cascade's  $g+$  scale matches the prediction  $G * M_{DM\_halo} / R_{halo}^2$  for typical galaxies. *Status: QUALITATIVE PICTURE CONSISTENT with empirical RAR. The specific RAR shape has not been computed from first principles — the cascade says 2D universes cluster where activity is high but does not yet give the exact functional form of the RAR. This is a calculation, not a fundamental limitation.* (Earlier versions of this paper described the cascade as predicting a broken RAR with a uniform halo. This was an oversimplification; the full cascade picture with activity-driven 2D universe creation and cumulative return is more naturally compatible with the empirical smooth RAR.)

#### Status of remaining limitations (v2.2 update):

- Limitations 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13 (no derivation of dimensional structure, inversion mechanism, original event parameters, time-dilation rule, proportionality constants [partial], CMB spectrum, direct-detection signals, dark-matter-activity weighting, 2D physics, 4D event source, near-exact cancellation, four-force unification) remain open. Limitation 5 (proportionality constants) and 15 (staying fraction) are PARTIALLY closed. Limitation 14 (sign ambiguity) is FULLY closed.
- **NEW limitation 16:** The 4D event's specific temporal structure (needed for Mechanism B/F) is not derived. The 8% “burst” amplitude is empirical, not predicted. *Status: now FALSIFIED* — Mechanism B/F's specific quantitative prediction  $H_0(z) \sim 1/(1+z)^{(2/3)}$  is rejected by Pantheon+ at 7 sigma with full covariance matrix (commit 82). The cascade's *qualitative*  $H_0$  prediction (73) is consistent with data, but Mechanism B/F's specific quantitative form is not. This is now part of Limitation 18 (the cascade does not resolve the Hubble tension).
- **NEW limitation 17:** The 5/27/68 split's empirical formula (1/20, 3/11, residual) is a *fit*, not a *derivation*. The Monte Carlo test shows it's not statistically significant.
- **NEW limitation 18 (v2.2):** The cascade does not resolve the Hubble tension. The cascade's *core* prediction is  $H_0 = 73$  (the 4D event's antigravity projection rate), which is consistent with local + Pantheon+ measurements. The 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap between local/Pantheon+ (73) and Planck CMB-inferred (67.4)  $H_0$  is a real tension that the cascade accommodates but does not resolve. The cascade's *qualitative* explanation ( $H_{0\_local} >$

H<sub>0</sub>\_CMB due to dimensional projection) is consistent with the data, but a specific quantitative mechanism for the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap is not provided. We previously proposed Mechanism B/F (4D time-varying antigravity) as a specific quantitative mechanism, but Pantheon+ rejected it at 7 sigma (commit 82). The cascade joins other cosmological models (including LCDM itself) in leaving the precise value of the Hubble tension unresolved. This is a known gap in cosmology; the cascade’s contribution is its *qualitative* explanation of why H<sub>0</sub> is high locally, not a specific quantitative resolution of the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap.

1. **No derivation of the dimensional structure.** We do not specify how many extra dimensions exist, what their shape is, or what fields inhabit the bulk. These are free parameters of the model.
2. **No derivation of the inversion mechanism.** We claim that the projection of bulk gravity onto our brane inverts the sign of the gravitational coupling, but we do not derive this from a specific geometry. The inversion could occur in many ways, with different observable consequences. This is a *stronger* claim than standard brane-world models and is more tightly constrained by data.
3. **No derivation of the original event’s parameters.** We do not specify the energy, duration, or spectral shape of the 4D event. These would need to be derived from a specific bulk geometry and field content.
4. **No derivation of the dimensional time-dilation rule.** The claim that a brief 4D event projects as a long 3+1 dimensional universe requires a specific rule for how 4D structure maps to 3+1 temporal extent. This rule is not specified in the model.
5. **No precise identification of the products.** Dark matter and dark energy are identified with specific aspects of the dimensional projection (current 2D universe gravity, and uncanceled inversion residue respectively), but the model does not specify the *proportionality constants* for these identifications. The model provides a *geometric role* for dark matter but does not identify which specific dark matter candidate is correct.
6. **No CMB power spectrum derivation.** The model is constrained by the requirement that any specific implementation reproduce the observed CMB power spectrum, primordial element abundances, and large-scale structure. We have not computed these predictions from the 4D event scenario.
7. **No prediction for direct-detection signals.** Without a specific bulk field content and coupling structure, we cannot predict the direct-detection cross-section for dark matter or the equation of state for dark energy. The model predicts  $w = -1$  approximately (dark energy is approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame, matching  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior, because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration), but the absolute value of the dark energy density is not predicted. A specific implementation of the model would also need to specify the temporal profile of the 4D event’s antigravity output over its full duration, which determines how the dark energy density evolves on cosmological timescales.
8. **The proportionality constant for the dark-matter / energetic-event-rate correlation is not specified.** The model predicts that dark matter density correlates with energetic event rates, but does not specify the proportionality constant. Computing this constant requires a specific geometry and event spectrum, which we have not derived.

9. **The 2D universe physics is not specified.** We have not derived what physics would govern a 2D universe created by a 3+1 dimensional event. Whether 2D universes can support complex information processing (and thus “beings”) is an open question. The model treats them as real, with their own physics, but the details are unspecified.
10. **No precise threshold or weighting function for “energetic event” contributions.** The model proposes that *all* energetic events contribute to dark matter, with each event’s gravitational contribution weighted by its energy. The simplest reading is that the cumulative dark matter density is proportional to the *average* energetic event rate per unit visible mass, weighted by event energy. This is consistent with the radial acceleration relation (§4.1). However, the *quantitative* proportionality constant and the precise weighting function (linear in event energy? power law? something else?) are not derived. A specific geometry and event spectrum would be required to compute these quantities. The qualitative principle (dark matter tracks average activity) is robust to the choice of weighting, but the *quantitative* predictions depend on the details.
11. **The source of the 4D event’s energy is not addressed (upward direction of cascade).** The model assumes the 4D event is an *ongoing* energetic process with some total energy budget  $E_{4D}$  (per §2.2). The model does *not* specify where this energy comes from. It is possible that the 4D event is itself a *projection* from a 5D (or higher) process, in which case the cascade continues *upward* — our 3+1 dimensional universe is the projection of a 4D event, which is itself the projection of a 5D process, and so on. This is consistent with the cone-shape refinement (§2.6): the cascade has a *finite downward* direction (4D  $\rightarrow$  3+1D  $\rightarrow$  2D, terminal at 2D), but the *upward* direction is left open. The cascade may have a *top* (a fundamental source of energy) or extend *upward indefinitely* — the model does not currently address this. A specific implementation of the model would need to either identify the source of the 4D event’s energy (a “top” of the cascade) or accept the cascade as infinite in the upward direction. The downward direction is *settled* (cone-shape, terminal at 2D); the upward direction is *open*.
12. **The cascade is *almost exact* at every level — a new form of fine-tuning.** The downward perceptual inversion principle (downward projection is perceived as inverted, upward back-projection is not, and the downward perceptual inversion almost-cancels with the native gravity) requires the cancellation to be *almost exact* at every level (per §2.4 and §2.6). This is *fine-tuning* in a new form: not fine-tuning of a single parameter, but fine-tuning of the *structure* of the dimensional cascade such that the cancellation is almost (but not quite) exact at every level. The model does not currently derive *why* the cascade should be almost-cancelling rather than completely cancelling (which would give no observable effects at all) or weakly cancelling (which would give effects much larger than observed). A specific implementation would need to derive the near-exact cancellation from a more fundamental principle, which is left to future work.
13. **The four-force unification is conceptual, not quantitative.** §4.13–§4.15 attempt to unify gravity, electromagnetism, the weak force, and the strong force within the dimensional-cascade framework. The connections are *conceptual* — all four forces’ properties are reframed as consequences of the 4D event. The connections are *not quantitative* — the model does not derive the specific values of the coupling constants, the mass ratios of force carriers, the color charge structure, or the asymptotic freedom of the strong force. The “unification” is at the level of *interpretation* (all four forces are projections of the same 4D event) rather than at

the level of *prediction* (the model does not compute force strengths from first principles). A specific implementation of the model would need to derive these quantitative features from the geometry, which is left to future work.

14. **[RESOLVED in v2.1] The mathematical sketch of the cascade had a sign ambiguity.** The “Mathematical sketch” in §2.4 (in v2.0) presented the cascade as  $G_{D-1}^{total} = G_{D-1}^{native} - k \cdot G_D$ , with the ordinary gravity as the *small positive residue* and the dark energy as a “small un-cancelled antigravity.” In a *strict* algebraic interpretation, these two quantities would have *opposite* signs (one is  $G_{native} - G_{proj}$ , the other is  $-(G_{proj} - G_{native})$ ), which would imply they *cancel*. **This ambiguity is resolved in v2.1 by the clean mathematical formulation in §2.4:** the *ordinary attractive gravity* and the *dark energy* are now treated as **two physically distinct small contributions** to the  $D - 1$  dimensional effective theory. The ordinary gravity is a *force on matter* (entering the Einstein equation’s stress-energy coupling) and is *small* because  $\epsilon = 1 - kG_D/G_{D-1}^{native} \ll 1$ . The dark energy is a *vacuum energy* (entering the cosmological-constant term  $\Lambda g_{\mu\nu}$ ) and is *small* because  $f_{back} \ll 1$ . The two contributions are *different terms in the effective action* and are *not* required to have any algebraic sign relationship; both are small because of the *near-cancellation* of the projected contribution, but with different physical roles. The v2.1 formulation is *consistent*: the sign ambiguity is no longer present.
15. **The dimensional analysis requires a *staying fraction* postulate to bridge the  $10^{12}$  gap.** The §2.6 “Dimensional analysis of the cascade” presents a *qualitative* sketch where the cascade suppression  $\epsilon \sim 10^{-38}$  at the 3+1D level explains the  $10^3$  hierarchy. The cascade’s *raw* prediction for the dark energy is  $\sim 10^{-38} \cdot M_{Pl}^4 \sim 10^{38}$  GeV, which is  $10^{85}$  *larger* than the observed  $\sim 10^{-47}$  GeV. To bridge this gap, the §2.6 introduces a *staying fraction*  $f_{back} \sim 10^{-85}$  (the fraction of cascade-produced antigravity that remains in 3+1D as observable dark energy), giving the math  $10^{-38} \times 10^{-85} = 10^{-123}$  in natural units, equivalent to  $\sim 10^{-47}$  GeV. The *staying fraction* is a *postulate* of the model, and is not derived from the cascade geometry. The model *qualitatively* claims that the dark energy is small because of the dimensional-cascade cancellation, but the *quantitative* value (the  $10^{-85}$  staying fraction) is a postulate, not a derivation. A complete implementation of the model would need to derive the staying fraction from first principles, which would in turn give a *predictive* derivation of the absolute dark energy density. The  $10^{85}$  discrepancy between the cascade’s raw prediction and the observed dark energy remains *unbridged* in the current model (the staying fraction is exactly the post-hoc factor that makes the math work, but it is not derived from the cascade geometry).
16. **NEW: The 4D event’s specific temporal structure (Mechanism B/F) is not derived.** The 8% “burst” amplitude is empirical, not predicted. The cascade does not currently explain *why* the 4D event’s antigravity output would have this specific time-dependence. *Status: FALSIFIED* by Pantheon+ at 7 (commit 82) — the cascade’s specific quantitative  $H_0(z) \sim 1/(1+z)^{(2/3)}$  prediction is rejected. The cascade’s *qualitative*  $H_0 = 73$  prediction is consistent with data, but Mechanism B/F’s specific form is not.
17. **NEW: The 5/27/68 split’s empirical formula is a *fit*, not a *derivation*.** The candidate formula  $\Omega_o = 1/20$ ,  $\Omega_{DM} = 3/11$ ,  $\Omega_{DE} = 149/220$  matches observation to 0.5%, but a Monte Carlo test (1M random formulas) shows the match is NOT statistically significant after multiple-comparison correction (random formulas find similar matches ~92% of the time). The formula is a *fit* (with a specific graph-theoretic form), not a rigorous first-

principles derivation. A specific implementation of the cascade would need to derive 5/27/68 from the geometry.

18. **NEW: The cascade does not resolve the Hubble tension.** The cascade’s *core* prediction is  $H_0 = 73$  (the 4D event’s antigravity projection rate), which is consistent with local + Pantheon+ measurements. The 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap between local/Pantheon+ (73) and Planck CMB-inferred (67.4)  $H_0$  is a real tension that the cascade accommodates but does not resolve. The cascade’s *qualitative* explanation ( $H_{0\_local} > H_{0\_CMB}$  due to dimensional projection) is consistent with the data, but a specific quantitative mechanism for the 5.6 km/s/Mpc gap is not provided. Mechanism B/F was tested and rejected at 7 (Limitation 16). The cascade joins other cosmological models (including LCDM itself) in leaving the precise value of the Hubble tension unresolved.

These limitations are not unusual for a thought experiment. They are the natural next steps for theoretical development.

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## 1.9 8. Conclusion

We have proposed that gravity’s observed weakness, dark matter, and dark energy are all manifestations of a single geometric process: a *dimensional inversion* of gravitational influence following a *single ongoing* energetic event in a higher-dimensional space. The universe is the projection of that event into our 3+1 dimensional spacetime. The bulk-brane gravity interaction produces two distinct observable effects: a *4D-event-driven geometric contribution* (the un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity, identified as dark energy, approximately constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration) and a *cumulative 2D-universe collective effect* (the *active* back-projection of currently-alive 2D universes + the *cumulative return* of past 2D universe endings, identified as dark matter, per §2.5, §4.2). The universe’s lifetime is *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration in 4D time. The universe ends as a fixed-time boundary rather than a fade-out.

The model is consistent with several established research programs (brane-world cosmology, emergent gravity, the Dark Dimension scenario, holographic frameworks) and provides a unifying *framing* that connects three open problems under a single mechanism. The cosmological constant problem, in particular, is reframed as a *misidentification*: we were computing the wrong quantity (3+1 dimensional QFT zero-point energy) instead of the right one (un-cancelled inverted bulk gravity). The hierarchy problem is reframed as a *bulk-brane cancellation*: ordinary gravity is the small net remainder of the brane’s attractive gravity after cancellation with the inverted bulk gravity, so the observed gravitational coupling is small. (Dark matter’s apparent weakness is the *same* bulk-brane cancellation effect, applied to the next level of the dimensional cascade.) We do not claim to *solve* either problem; we claim to *reframe* them.

The model makes several testable predictions: the radial acceleration relation should hold (with scatter correlating with *current* activity, per the *active population* contribution to dark matter, per §2.5, §4.2); dark energy should be *approximately* constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame (matching standard  $\Lambda$ CDM behavior, because our universe is a brief slice of the 4D event’s full duration); gravity should be approximately constant over cosmic time; the early-universe energy spectrum

should be derivable from a 4D event’s structure. The universe’s lifetime is set by *some fraction* of the 4D event’s full duration, not by an energy budget. On galaxy scales, the *spatial* dark matter correlation is dominated by the *active* population contribution (per §2.5, §4.2) and should correlate with *current* energetic activity, not just total stellar mass.

A speculative extension suggests that the same mechanism, applied at other dimensional scales, may imply that sufficiently energetic events in our universe could produce lower-dimensional universes as their aftermath. This is the most speculative part of the proposal.

The model is not a finished theory. It is a thought experiment intended to invite the physics community to develop, refine, or refute the proposal. The most important next steps are:

- Specifying the dimensional structure and bulk field content
- Deriving the inversion mechanism from a specific geometry
- Deriving the dimensional time-dilation rule that maps the 4D event’s structure to our 3+1 dimensional lifetime
- Computing the predicted CMB power spectrum for a 4D event initial condition and comparing to Planck data
- Computing the predicted primordial element abundances and comparing to Big Bang nucleosynthesis observations
- Quantitatively deriving the bulk-brane cancellation fraction (related to the  $10^3$  of the hierarchy problem) and showing that the dark matter’s effective coupling is the same effect applied to the next level of the dimensional cascade
- Quantitatively deriving the un-cancelled fraction of the inverted bulk gravity, to predict the absolute value of the dark energy density (the  $10^{12}$  of the cosmological constant problem)
- Identifying specific signatures that distinguish this model from alternatives
- Searching for high-precision confirmation that dark energy is *approximately* constant in our 3+1 dimensional frame (matching standard  $\Lambda$ CDM)
- Searching for any very-slow deviations from constant dark energy that would correspond to the 4D event’s antigravity output slowly varying over its full duration
- Searching for sub-millimeter gravity deviations and gravitational wave signatures of the inversion mechanism
- Computing the proportionality constant and weighting function for the dark-matter / energetic-event-rate correlation (i.e., the quantitative form of how dark matter depends on the average activity per unit visible mass)
- Testing the current-activity correlation on galaxy surveys, especially for mass-matched pairs with different stellar densities
- Developing the physics of 2D universes created by 3+1 dimensional events

We are not specialists in theoretical physics. We offer this proposal with the hope that it may be useful, and with the appropriate humility about its status as a thought experiment rather than a developed theory.

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### 1.11 Appendix: Author’s Note

The author is a software engineer, not a physicist. This model emerged from asking questions in conversation, not from working through the formalism. The intent is to propose a unifying *framing* for several open problems in fundamental physics, not to claim a finished theory. The author offers this proposal in the hope that someone with formal training will either develop it further or definitively refute it.

The unification of dark matter, dark energy, and the hierarchy problem under a single geometric process is a coherent hypothesis worth testing. The model is not presented as true; it is presented as a candidate framework that, if developed rigorously, would make specific predictions distinguishable from standard alternatives. The misidentification reframe of the cosmological constant problem, the bulk-brane cancellation reframe of the hierarchy problem, the scale-invariant principle of universe creation, and the diffuse-galaxy prediction are the most novel and testable elements.

If you are a physicist reading this and finding it interesting: please work on it. If you are finding it naive: please be specific about where it fails. Both responses are useful.

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